SHUN ROUTE

Chapter 1: Morning duty

Student
"Good morning."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good morning."
Student
"Good morning, President Hoshina. Vice President Anesaki."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Morning."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good morning."

I was mechanically returning greetings when a student stepped in front of me.

Yu Oshii
"Good morning."

Oh, I remember him... We met yesterday.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Good morning, Oshii-kun."
Yu Oshii
"Oh, so you remembered me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Of course. Thank you for yesterday."
Yu Oshii
"Don't mention it. …Is this some kind of school conduct patrol?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. It's mostly in name only, though."
Yu Oshii
"Haha. Does my outfit pass?"

Oshii-kun straightened his back.
I scanned him from the top of his head to the tips of his shoes.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You look almost perfect..."
Yu Oshii
"Almost?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"If I were nitpicking, I would probably say your tie is a bit sloppy."

His tie was sitting quite crookedly around his neck.

Yu Oshii
"Ah… I'm not really good at this kind of thing…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Haha, really? Let me help you a bit."

I beckoned him over, and when Oshii-kun came closer, I reached out toward his tie.

Yu Oshii
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I know how to handle stuff like this."
Yu Oshii
"I-I see…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay, it's done."

After fixing his tie, I looked up to find Oshii-kun smiling shyly.

Yu Oshii
"...Thank you very much."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're welcome. …Hm?"

As I was looking at our surroundings, I noticed Shun standing behind Oshii-kun.
Shun trudged over with a groggy look on his face.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun."
Shun Anesaki
"Mm…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good morning."
Shun Anesaki
"...Good morning."

He let out a big yawn.
…*Sigh*. What a mess.
I walked towards Shun and grabbed his loosely hanging tie.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wake up already!"

I gave his tie a sharp tug.

Shun Anesaki
"Ugh."

Oops, I overdid it. I think I even choked him a little.

Shun Anesaki
"*Cough*… Are you trying to kill me?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, sorry, sorry. But hey, you're fully awake now."

When I said that with a smirk, Oshii-kun, who had been silent until then, spoke up with a puzzled expression on his face.

Yu Oshii
"Anesaki-senpai… you seem different when you're around Shun."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…"

I silently let go of Shun's tie, straightened my posture, and smiled at them.

Nozomi Anesaki
"The bell's about to ring. You two should head to your classroom, okay?"
Yu Oshii
"Ah, sure."
Shun Anesaki
"…"

I ignored Shun's glare, which practically screamed, "You jerk," and waved to the two of them with my usual smile.
Watching Shun and Oshii-kun disappear around the corner, I finally felt at ease.
Phew... That was close. I tend to let my true self show when I'm around Shun. I need to be more careful.
When I returned to the classroom after finishing my student council activities, I was a little startled by the sight of the person sitting next to me.
Kuraguchi-kun…
Yesterday, I weaseled my way out by pretending that he'd mistaken me for someone else, but was he really convinced…?

Nozomi Anesaki
"…"

I decided to simply take my seat.
Then Kuraguchi-kun glanced over at me, and our eyes met.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…G-good morning…"

Ayumu Kuraguchi
"Morning, Anesaki-san."

Kuraguchi-kun gave me a brief reply and resumed reading.

…Phew. Seems like it worked out somehow.
Let's forget about the past and continue to treat Kuraguchi-kun as just any ordinary classmate...

Chapter 2: I triggered a flag

Female student
"...And that's what happened. Isn't it just aaawful?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, that's pretty terrible…"
Male student
"Anesaki-san, how do you solve this one?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Let's see... you substitute the value obtained from the previous problem into x, and then…"

The break had just started, and students immediately came over and crowded around my desk.
They probably felt more comfortable gathering around since Miho was absent today with a cold.
I looked over and noticed that the people around Kuraguchi-kun had left him with barely any room.
Kuraguchi-kun looked completely unfazed as he read his book, but he was probably feeling pretty inconvenienced deep down.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Excuse me, I'm going to the bathroom for a moment."
Female student
"Oh, okay. Go ahead."
Male student
"Can I come along?"
Female student
"You can't do that, you know. That's sexual harassment."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hahaha… I'll be right back."

As always, the moment I left the classroom, I felt the tension in my shoulders release.
I think I'll never be a true social butterfly.
While I was taking in this feeling of relief, I noticed a familiar teacher approaching from the front.
She was carrying a stack of printouts.
...Wow… I have a bad feeling about this.

Teacher
"Oh, hello, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hello."
Teacher

"Sorry to trouble you, but... could you put these printouts on my desk in the staff room?"

…I just knew it…

Nozomi Anesaki
"Of course…"

I didn't let any frustration show on my face as I took the printouts from her hands.
Seriously, why do the teachers at this school always make students do so much work...?
Speaking of which… This stack of printouts is so heavy. My arms are already starting to feel like they're going to give out...!

Female student
"Hii, Nozomi."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hii."
Male student
"Hii, Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hii."

I kept smiling, but my arms were trembling.
I must have looked like I was handling it, because no one seemed willing to step in and help.
If only Lord Walt were here... He'd have noticed right away.

???
"Oh? Anesaki-senpai?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

As I raised my eyes, Oshii-kun came into view.
At the same moment, a sharp pain shot through my arm, and I winced.

Yu Oshii
"Ah, are you okay?"

Oshii-kun immediately reached out and steadied the stack of handouts.
The moment the weight was lifted from my arms, I let out a long sigh of relief.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Th-thank you…"
Yu Oshii
"Don't mention it. …This is really heavy."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Right? Sorry, I'm okay now."

After saying that, I braced myself and tightened my grip,
but Oshii-kun took the stack of handouts from my hands in one swift motion.

Yu Oshii
"Where are you taking these to?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Just to the staff room…"
Yu Oshii
"I'll take them there in your place."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Yu Oshii
"I mean, these are incredibly heavy. Carrying them is a man's job."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm…"

I appreciate Oshii-kun's offer, but this was something I was assigned to do.

Nozomi Anesaki
"In that case..."

I took the top half of the stack. This much was easy enough for me to carry.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Could you take half of them?"
Yu Oshii
"...Okay."

Oshii-kun's gentle smile almost made my heart skip a beat. I guess I have a soft spot for sincere kindness.

Yu Oshii
"By the way, these are answer sheets from my class."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, really?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes, our year had a practice exam a while ago."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see."

That was the first time I'd heard of it. Shun never mentioned any tests.
I wonder how well he scored…
As I examined the stack of handouts closely, Oshii-kun chuckled softly.

Yu Oshii
"Are you curious about Shun's score?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes... kind of. Shun always dodges the subject whenever I ask about his test results. I know his grades aren't very good, though."
Yu Oshii

"Ooh… He doesn't want to talk about it? That's surprising."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Whenever he does badly on a test, I scold him about it, so he tries not to let me see his results."
Yu Oshii
"...Maybe he doesn't want you to think less of him, Senpai?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ahaha, of course not."

As we continued talking, we eventually arrived at the staff room.
I stopped and put my share of the handouts back onto the stack Oshii-kun was holding.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You don't need to go any farther. I'll handle the rest."

With that, I took the stack of handouts from Oshii-kun.
…It was indeed very heavy.

Yu Oshii
"Are you sure you're okay…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, I'm fine. The staff room is right here. Thanks for helping me this far."
Yu Oshii
"You're welcome. Please, go ahead."

Oshii-kun opened the staff room door for me. What a gentleman.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Thanks. See you later."
Yu Oshii
"Ah, um…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Yu Oshii
"Senpai, do you have any plans after school today?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Umm… No, not really…?"
Yu Oshii
"Then… If it's not too much trouble, I was hoping you could help me study..."

I briefly considered his timid request.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, sure."

I smiled and nodded. I wanted to thank him for helping me this far, and I also wanted to make a good impression on Shun's friend.

Yu Oshii
"Really? Thank you so much...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"All right. See you after school, then. How about the library?"
Yu Oshii
"S-sure…! I'll be waiting for you there after classes, then."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay. See you later."

I said goodbye to Oshii-kun with a smile.
But the moment I stepped into the room, my cheerful expression disappeared.
...My arm was killing me.

Chapter 3: Shun's love life

After classes ended, I slipped away from the group of classmates and headed to the library like I'd promised.
The library saw very few visitors, so the surrounding hallways were deserted as well, making the whole area incredibly quiet.
I quietly slid the door open and stepped inside.

Image:
Books in the study area may not be checked out!

I made my way toward the study area at the back, where I found Oshii-kun already seated at a desk, waiting for me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oshii-kun."
Yu Oshii
"Ah, hello, Senpai."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry to keep you waiting."
Yu Oshii
"No, I just got here myself."

I went ahead and sat down across from Oshii-kun.
Oshii-kun immediately began getting his study materials ready.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um… what do you need help with?"
Yu Oshii
"Do you remember the practice exam we talked about earlier? There were a few things I couldn't figure out even after looking at the explanations."

Oshii-kun pulled out the test paper and his answer sheet.
I took a quick look and my eyes widened slightly.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wow, you're pretty smart, Oshii-kun."

Almost all of his answers were marked correct. He must have scored well above average.

Yu Oshii
"No... I'm not nearly as smart as you, Anesaki-senpai."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Haha, I've worked pretty hard to get there."
Yu Oshii
"Me too."

Oshii-kun smiled modestly. I found myself growing a little fonder of him.
There was something about him that made him easy to talk to.
Maybe it had something to do with him being younger than me. I just felt more at ease around him than I did with my classmates.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well then, shall we get started?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes, thank you."

While I was explaining the problems to Oshii-kun, I started hearing some voices coming from the hallway.
I wasn't intentionally listening in, but it was so quiet in here that I couldn't help hearing them.
Especially when it was a voice I knew so well.

Shun Anesaki
"—you—"

...That was Shun.
But who was he talking to...? The other voice belonged to a girl I didn't recognize.
Their conversation and footsteps gradually grew closer, until they stopped right outside the library.
Then, almost immediately, I heard the door open.

Shun Anesaki
"...So, what did you want to talk about?"

Shun's voice came through more clearly than before.
They must have been talking near the entrance to the library, because they didn't seem to have noticed that we were further inside.

Female student
"Um… there's something I've been meaning to tell you for a long time..."

I heard a soft, sweet girl's voice.

The nervousness in her tone immediately told me what this conversation was about.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

For some reason, my whole body tensed up.
When I suddenly felt someone watching me, I looked up to see Oshii-kun holding a finger to his lips.
I was already careful not to make any noise.
Even so, the realization that we were now effectively eavesdropping left me feeling terribly guilty.

Female student
"I like you, Shun-kun…"

As I expected, she confessed to him.
The library fell completely silent.
I hardly dared to breathe. I found myself staring at Oshii-kun across from me, afraid to make a sound.

Shun Anesaki
"...Ah… Um… I'm sorry."

Shun's response was rather nonchalant.
That, too, was more or less what I'd expected.
I'd had a feeling that Shun wasn't particularly interested in anyone yet.
And I also knew he wasn't the sort of person to start dating someone just because they confessed to him.
I couldn't say exactly why I'd thought so. It was really just... a hunch.
If I had to give it a name, perhaps it was the "intuition of an otome gamer."

Female student
"I understand..."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah... I'm sorry."
Female student
"Um... can I ask why?"
Shun Anesaki
"Why...? Hmm... It's because I only see you as a friend, Shinohara."
Female student
"I see..."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."
Female student
"Say…"
Shun Anesaki
"Hm?"
Female student

"Is there someone you like...?"

Silence fell over the library once again.
"There isn't," I answered the girl's question in my head.

Shun Anesaki
"There is."
Nozomi Anesaki
"There is?"

……
……
Wait.
I said that out loud!!!
Oshii-kun forced a smile.
I tried to keep my expression neutral as I focused my attention on Shun and the girl.
My voice had clearly echoed throughout the room.
But perhaps Shun and the girl hadn't heard it. Their conversation resumed as if nothing had happened.

Female student
"I see... Then... I'll give up."
Female student
"Bye-bye."

I heard the sliding door open, followed by footsteps echoing down the hallway.
Once I could no longer hear them, I let out a long sigh of relief.

Nozomi Anesaki
"That was close…"
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oshii-kun?"
Yu Oshii
"..."

Oshii-kun just sat there in silence, wearing an expression I couldn't quite read.
...Actually, it seemed like he was looking past me.
Or behind me…?

Nozomi Anesaki
"...?"

I turned around to see what Oshii-kun was looking at.

Nozomi Anesaki
"!!!"

I jumped out of my seat.
The desk rattled, knocking several writing utensils onto the floor, but I didn't have time to pick them up.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun looked at me without blinking.
I couldn't get a single word out. All I could do was stare up at him, opening and closing my mouth like I was trying to remember how to speak.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun said nothing. He simply glared at us, spun on his heel, and stormed out of the library.
Now that they were both gone, it was just Oshii-kun and me.
After a long, agonizing silence, my shoulders sagged.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Shun was really angry…"
Yu Oshii
"That's true…"

Oshii-kun laughed softly as he picked up the pens and pencils from the floor.

Yu Oshii
"You're kind of clumsy, Senpai."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I'm sorry..."
Yu Oshii
"No, it was actually pretty fun. Quite the thrill."

Once he put the writing utensils back in his pencil case, Oshii-kun stretched a little.

Yu Oshii
"I think I've kind of lost my focus, so maybe we should call it a day."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Sorry. We didn't really get to solve many problems."
Yu Oshii
"Not at all. I learned a lot today. Thank you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"If there's anything else you don't understand, feel free to ask me."
Yu Oshii
"Yes. I'll be sure to take you up on your offer."

We packed everything away and headed out of the library.
As we walked down the hallway, I let out an involuntary sigh.

Yu Oshii
"…Are you still worried about what happened earlier?"

Oshii-kun picked up on my mood and asked me about it.
I mumbled a quiet "Hm…" and nodded slightly.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I was just thinking about how I'm kind of dreading going home..."

Knowing Shun, he would probably keep sulking for a while.

Yu Oshii
"It was completely unavoidable. I'm sure he'll understand once you explain what happened."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I hope so. ...Shun sure is popular with girls."

I mused aloud.
I knew he was pretty popular, but witnessing something like that for myself was still an eye-opening experience.

Yu Oshii
"That's right. It seems he's been through this before."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I figured."
Yu Oshii
"From what I've heard, it's already happened several times since he enrolled here."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ohh…"

I had no idea. Shun never talks about this kind of thing.

Yu Oshii
"He was pretty popular in middle school, too. He turned every girl down, though."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You've known Shun for a long time, haven't you, Oshii-kun?"
Yu Oshii
"Well... yes, I guess so."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see. Then you probably know Shun better than I do."

I said it without thinking much of it. Oshii-kun fell silent for a moment, then smiled.

Yu Oshii
"I don't know about that. I doubt I could know Shun better than his own sister."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No. I don't know Shun at all, really. I didn't know his test scores, and I didn't know he'd been confessed to, either."

Yu Oshii
"Then... you didn't know he had someone he liked?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Not a clue. I actually thought he didn't like anyone. What about you?"
Yu Oshii
"Hmm... Well, I've never heard him say it directly."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh...?"

From the way he put it, he'd probably figured out who Shun liked without Shun ever telling him directly.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Looks like you know him better than I do after all."
Yu Oshii
"I suppose."

With Oshii-kun's last response, our conversation about Shun came to an end.
We spent the rest of the walk making small talk, then parted ways at the school entrance.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm home."

……
……
There was no answer. But Shun's shoes were there.
Yeah... he's definitely still upset...
Better not poke the bear right now...
I'll wait until he's calmed down a bit, then explain myself—or rather, apologize.
I was quietly finishing up my assignments in my room when I heard a knock.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"Dinner."

Shun kept his words to a bare minimum before disappearing.
Clearly, he wasn't over it yet.
We sat down to dinner, the mood between us decidedly awkward.
When I happened to glance at the dish set in front of me, I almost laughed.
Fried chicken... That's so little!!!

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun."
Shun Anesaki
"..."

Nozomi Anesaki
"You brat."
Shun Anesaki
"..."

All I got in response was a sullen look.
Hoho... I see. That's how you want to play it. So you're going to resort to such petty tactics, are you?
Fine, then...
I'll give you a fair fight!

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ha!"

I speared a piece of fried chicken from Shun's plate with my chopsticks.
I popped it into my mouth, and Shun just stared at me, dumbfounded.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

He responded by jabbing his chopsticks into one of my pieces of fried chicken.
Heh... he's playing along now. I'm not going to lose.
I stole another piece of fried chicken from Shun's plate.
Shun immediately retaliated by stealing one of mine.
After we repeated this several times...

Shun・Nozomi
"..."

Ugh...
Maybe I'd eaten too much too quickly, because my stomach was starting to feel queasy.
Shun looked just as sick.
As for the result of our little contest, it was a draw. We'd both eaten the same number of pieces.

Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

...In the end, that little contest had accomplished nothing.
All we managed to do was exhaust ourselves, resulting in one incredibly pointless dinner.
And just like that, the day was almost over without Shun and me having a single proper conversation.
Sure, he'd probably get over his sulking eventually if I left him alone. But something about that didn't sit well with me.
After going back and forth in my head, I finally left my room and headed to Shun's.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun."

I knocked on the door.
There was, predictably, no answer.
I didn't bother waiting for a response and opened the door.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun was stretched out on his bed, reading an erotic magazi— …Nope. Just a manga.
When I got closer, he glanced over at me.

Shun Anesaki
"Don't barge into my room."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You've barged into my room without asking before, so we're even."
Shun Anesaki
"I thought you were asleep."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well, so did I."
Shun Anesaki
"People who barge into someone's room while they're sleeping are the worst."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Jeez, what a delicate little princess."

As we went back and forth over nothing, I snatched the manga out of Shun's hands.

Shun Anesaki
"…What?"

Shun sat up, looking annoyed.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Show me your mock exam results."
Shun Anesaki
"Uh..."

He clearly hadn't seen that coming, and his surprise was written all over his face.

Shun Anesaki
"Wh... No. I don't want to. Besides... how do you even know about the mock exam...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oshii-kun told me."
Shun Anesaki
"…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Show me."

Shun Anesaki
"No."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Why?"
Shun Anesaki
"...You'll get angry."

This one response was enough to tell me just how badly he'd done on the mock exam.
Shun looked away, clearly embarrassed, and I shrugged a little.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm not going to get mad. We will just review the questions you got wrong."
Shun Anesaki
"...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You were just going to pretend those questions don't exist, weren't you? I'll help you. Come on, let's go over them together."

With our parents away on business, I was the only one around to keep an eye on Shun's studies.
As his older sister, I couldn't just stand by and watch his grades hit rock bottom. I had to at least keep them at a decent level.

Shun Anesaki
"...Okay."

To my surprise, Shun nodded pretty readily and took his answer sheets out of his bag.
He hesitated for a moment before reluctantly handing them over.
I took them and skimmed through his scores in every subject.
...Wow.

Shun Anesaki
"...Don't get angry."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm not angry, but I'm kind of at a loss for words..."
Shun Anesaki
"…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You should be able to do better than this."

Not to brag or anything, but getting into our school isn't exactly easy. If he was capable of getting in, he should be able to pull a decent score on a mock exam.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Did you run out of steam after the entrance exams?"
Shun Anesaki
"Pretty much."

He replied without the slightest hint of concern.
Come to think of it, I remember seeing Shun at his desk pretty often while he was preparing for the entrance exams.
Now that he'd gotten into school, though, there wasn't even a trace of that effort.

Nozomi Anesaki
"At least make sure you don't fail any of your classes."

There wasn't much point in continuing to lecture him, so I decided to leave it at that and sat down at the table.
Shun obediently took the seat across from me and pulled out his stationery.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...About today..."

As we went over the first question, I decided it was time to bring up what had really been on my mind.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...I wasn't trying to eavesdrop."
Shun Anesaki
"...."
Nozomi Anesaki
"We were studying in the library when you guys suddenly came in... and I didn't really feel like I could just get up and leave."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... I ended up eavesdropping anyway, so I'm sorry. I really am."
Shun Anesaki
"...."

Shun silently spun his pen between his fingers, then sighed deeply.

Shun Anesaki
"Forget about it already."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You're not mad anymore?"
Shun Anesaki
"I'm not mad. ...Well, I'm still a little pissed off."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Aw... I already apologized. What else am I supposed to do...?"
Shun Anesaki
"...You don't have to do anything, Sis. I'll probably be over it by tomorrow anyway."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hmm...?"

Something about it still didn't quite sit right with me, but from the way Shun was talking, I figured there was no point in dragging the matter out any further.
I decided to take him at his word and quickly dropped the subject.

Nozomi Anesaki
"All right... this problem here. I think you didn't understand the question. Let's try solving it again from the beginning."
Shun Anesaki
"Sure."

Shun began scribbling in his notebook.
As I watched him, my thoughts drifted back to what had happened in the library earlier that afternoon.

Female student
"Is there someone you like...?"
Shun Anesaki
"There is."

Honestly, I still couldn't wrap my head around it.
Shun—my younger brother, sitting right there in front of me—actually having someone he liked? I just couldn't picture it.
I'd never seen the slightest sign of it. ...Then again, maybe I just hadn't picked up on it.
Oshii-kun seemed to have some idea, though. Maybe Shun was secretly giving off major "guy with a crush" vibes when I wasn't around.
What kind of girl does Shun like?
I was genuinely curious.
What kind of person did a guy like Shun, who's basically got everything going for him, end up falling for?
Someone as successful as him?
...I'm really curious.
I want to know.
The urge kept building until I realized that I'd been staring at Shun pretty intently.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis?"

Shun suddenly glanced my way, a puzzled frown crossing his face.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah. Um… What?"
Shun Anesaki
"Well... You looked like you wanted to ask me something."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Something I wanted to ask..."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah. What is it?"

What kind of girl do you like?
Could I actually ask him that...?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Say..."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...No, never mind."

Even siblings have lines we shouldn't cross.
And this was probably one of them.
If I were in Shun's place, I'd probably feel uncomfortable having someone pry into my love life.

Shun Anesaki
"You can't just stop halfway like that."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It wasn't anything important, so forget about it. Anyway, did you solve the problem?"
Shun Anesaki
"Not yet. Just give me another minute."

Shun turned his attention back to his notebook.
I shoved my curiosity to the back of my mind and concentrated on reviewing his mock exam.
Some time later, I glanced at the clock and realized it was almost eleven.

Shun Anesaki
"Are you going to bed, Sis?"

Shun checked the time too, putting his pen away as he spoke. Judging by his behavior, he'd already decided the study session was over, regardless of my answer.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. Let's leave it at that for today."
Shun Anesaki
"Today...? Wait, you mean there's going to be a next time...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Not interested?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Sure, whatever."

…Huh. I didn't expect that. I thought Shun would definitely say no.
Maybe he's finally had a change of heart about studying.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Then let's keep studying together."
Shun Anesaki
"Okay."

Shun nodded readily, and I headed for the door.

Nozomi Anesaki
"All right, I'm going to bed. Good night."
Shun Anesaki
"Ah, wait."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"About Yu..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yu? …Oh, Oshii-kun?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What about him?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...No, never mind."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You can't just leave me hanging like that."
Shun Anesaki
"It's annoying, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Is this your revenge for earlier?"
Shun Anesaki
"Well, it's nothing important, so don't worry about it. Good night."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm...?"

It was still bothering me, but I figured it was probably fine. I forced myself to let it go and left Shun's room.

Chapter 4: Shun's social circle

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, you've got your lunch, right?"
Shun Anesaki
"I did, I did."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Your PE uniform too?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yes, yes. You didn't forget anything yourself, did you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I prepared everything last night, so I'm all set."
Shun Anesaki

"Hmm. All right, then. Let's go."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hold on!"
Shun Anesaki
"Yes, yes. You're very, very cute."

Shun muttered it as he put on his shoes, sounding like he couldn't care less.
Damn it... He hasn't been putting much thought into it lately.
Come to think of it…

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, what kind of girl do you think is cute?"

The question just popped into my head, and I blurted it out.

Shun Anesaki
"...Huuh?"

Shun turned around with a dumbfounded look on his face.

Shun Anesaki
"Why? Out of nowhere?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... I'm just curious?"

I tilted my head, not even sure why I'd suddenly felt like asking him that.
Maybe it was because I was still curious about what kind of girl Shun liked, and the question had been lingering in the back of my mind.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Never mind. Sorry for asking something weird."
Shun Anesaki
"What the heck was that? I don't get you."

Shun turned back around and reached for the front door.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait!"
Shun Anesaki
"...What now?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you not mad anymore?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Yeah, yeah. I'm over it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good."

I smiled brightly, and Shun headed out the front door, looking a little uneasy.

I followed at a leisurely pace.
It was a rare morning when the two of us could head to school without being in a hurry.

???
"Shuuun! Miiiiss!!!"

We were just about to reach the school gate when someone suddenly called out to us.
I looked ahead and saw a group of first-year boys waving at me.
For a moment, I nearly backed off.
I didn't know why, but groups of boys like this had always made me uncomfortable.
It wasn't quite the same as being surrounded by the boys in my own class, even though that happened all the time.
Maybe it was because this was Shun's social circle. For some reason, I had always felt out of place around his friends.
Of course, I didn't let that show. Wearing my usual perfect "Nozomi Anesaki" persona, I approached them.
Then I spotted Oshii-kun in the group.
This made me a little relieved.

Male student
"What's up, Shun! Good morning, Miss!"
Shun Anesaki
"Hey."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good morning."
Male student
"Man, Shun, you're lucky. Getting to walk to school with your big sis and all."
Male student
"Plus she wakes you up every morning?! Dude, I'm jealous as hell."
Shun Anesaki
"Where do you guys get all this energy this early?"

Shun casually fended them off and continued on ahead.
The boys quickly caught up, falling into step beside him as they chattered away.
I had no intention of joining them, so I kept a little distance. Oshii-kun soon came over and quietly walked beside me.

Yu Oshii
"Good morning, Senpai."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Morning, Oshii-kun. These guys are already full of energy."
Yu Oshii
"They're like that all day. Doesn't matter if it's noon or midnight."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... to be young…"

We were only a year apart, but somehow it felt like there was a huge age difference between us.

Yu Oshii
"Haha, Senpai, you sound like an old lady."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?!"

Oh, no. I feel like I just let my mask slip for a moment.
Sure, Oshii-kun and I have gotten closer lately, but I'm getting way too comfortable around him.

Yu Oshii
"Sorry. That was pretty rude of me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no, no, it's fine..."

...Though it hit me harder than I'd like to admit.

Yu Oshii
"By the way, Senpai, thank you for yesterday."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Oh… Don't mention it. Sorry I didn't get to finish explaining it. Did you manage to solve that problem?"
Yu Oshii
"Actually, about that... I tried solving it myself after I got home yesterday, but I still got stuck halfway through."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, really...? I see. ...Then how about we finish it after school today?"

I offered it without a second thought. Oshii-kun's eyes widened in surprise.

Yu Oshii
"Uh... A-are you sure?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. I don't have anything else to—ah, shoot."
Yu Oshii
"?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I just remembered. I have a student council meeting today."
Yu Oshii
"Oh... okay..."

Oshii-kun's expression fell as his disappointment showed.
Thump.
Wait, no.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... I can make time after the student council meeting, if that's okay with you..."
Yu Oshii

"! You don't mind?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... but are you sure? Student council meetings usually take about an hour, so... you'd have to wait quite a while."
Yu Oshii
"No, no! That's totally fine! I don't mind waiting at all!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"R-really? Then... see you after the meeting?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes! I'd be happy to...!"

Oshii-kun suddenly broke into a broad smile.
Huh... What is this adorable creature?
What should I do? For some reason, my affection for Oshii-kun seems to have skyrocketed over the past few days.
He's genuinely kind, he's thoughtful, and he's probably far more mature emotionally than most people his age.
And then he does something like that, and suddenly my maternal instincts kick in.
Can I try to romance Oshii-kun?
...While I was busy indulging my shameless otome game fantasies, Oshii-kun hunched slightly and leaned closer to me.
The distance between us suddenly shrank, and my heart leaped.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-what?"
Yu Oshii
"...No... Um, this is kind of a change of subject, but... did you and Shun end up fighting over what happened yesterday?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, aah... No. He was sulking for a while, but he seems to have gotten over it."
Yu Oshii
"I see. That's good."

Suddenly, I realized things around us had gone quiet and looked up.
Shun and the three boys walking ahead had turned around and were watching us.

Male student
"Hey, look at Yu getting all friendly with Miss."
Male student
"What's with all the secret whispering? It's kinda sus."
Yu Oshii
"..."

Oshii-kun let out a sigh and stepped away from me.
I could only force a wry smile as the first-year boys began excitedly chattering among themselves.

Male student

"Much as I hate to say it, you two actually look really good together."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?!"
Male student
"Well, Yu's a top student, too. Damn, I'm jealous."
Male student
"Compared to him..."

The boys all looked over at Shun.

Shun Anesaki
"...What?"
Male student
"I seriously can't believe you're her brother."
Shun Anesaki
"...Huuh?"
Male student
"Look at that attitude! And this guy is the younger brother of an angel like her?"
Male student
"Who knew siblings could be this different?"

Looks like these guys don't know that Shun and I aren't blood-related.
It's not like we hide it or anything. We just never mention it unless someone asks, so there probably aren't that many people who know.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun fell silent, wearing an expression I couldn't quite read.
I was probably making the same face.
I was the one being praised in that conversation, but in reality, I was hardly the remarkable person they made me out to be.
The person I was at school was nothing more than a carefully constructed image, built through meticulous calculation.
Shun, on the other hand, could naturally find himself at the center of a group without having to do anything like that. If anything, I was the one who envied him.
Before long, we had arrived at the school entrance.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well then, I'm headed this way."
Yu Oshii
"Okay. See you later."

Oshii-kun gave me a quick wave goodbye.
The boys closed in around him, staring at him with deadpan, accusing looks.

Male student
"Hey, hey, what was that 'see you later' abooout?"

Male student
"What'd you and Miss plan for later?"
Yu Oshii
"Nothing. I was talking about sixth period."

...Sixth period? Not after school? What does he mean?
I couldn't think of anything he might be referring to, so I frowned in confusion. Then one of the boys clapped his hands, apparently having arrived at some realization.

Male student
"Oh, sixth period! Right, we'll see you again later, Vice Prez!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh?"
Male student
"Ahh, right. We're doing it indoors today, not outside."
Male student
"Crap. I think I forgot something."

The boys headed toward the shoe lockers, still chatting away about something I couldn't make sense of.

Yu Oshii
"Well then, I'll get going too."

Oshii-kun gave me a small bow and headed off after the others.
Shun was the only one left behind, staring blankly into space.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Uh? Ah, what?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... Everyone's left."
Shun Anesaki
"Ahh, you're right."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Why are you spacing out? Are you sleepy?"
Shun Anesaki
"...No, it's nothing. I'm gonna go."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay. See you."
Shun Anesaki
"Later."

Chapter 5: Joint class

Sixth period.

I finally figured out why the first-year boys had told me, "See you later," this morning.
Apparently, today's P.E. class was being held together with Shun's class.

Miho Orikasa
"It's not often that we have P.E. together with the first-years."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I heard their P.E. teacher is away on a business trip."
Miho Orikasa
"Ohh... Ah, isn't that your brother?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? Ah, you're right."

Following Miho's gaze, I saw Shun chatting happily with a few other students.

Miho Orikasa
"You Anesaki siblings are quite popular, huh."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Haha."

I forced a smile.
I don't know... even though I deliberately put myself in this position, I can't help feeling like it's quietly wearing me down.
Shun really is my opposite in that regard. He can be "popular" without having to worry about any of the baggage that comes with it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Must be nice..."

The words slipped out before I even realized.

Miho Orikasa
"Huh, what do you mean?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... No, it's nothing. The bell's gonna ring soon, so let's line up."
Miho Orikasa
"Mm, yeah."

Once we finished our usual exercises and stretches, the first- and second-years divided the gymnasium into two equal sections.
Despite sharing the class, we would apparently be doing different activities.
We were practicing volleyball sets while Shun and the other first years got ready for a basketball game.

Miho Orikasa
"They're playing basketball over there? Lucky..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Miho, do you like basketball better?"
Miho Orikasa

"No, not really. It's just that doing nothing but volleyball all the time gets a little boring."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, I get it."

I sent the ball back with a halfhearted set.
It looked like we weren't going to be playing any practice matches today.
We'd just been doing sets and receives on repeat, and honestly, it was getting pretty boring.
Then, after a while, a whistle echoed through the gym.
The first-years' basketball game finally started.
The gym instantly grew louder, and we all stopped practicing to watch the first-years play.

Female student
"Ohh. Isn't that Nozomi's brother?"
Female student
"Wow, he's really good at basketball!"
Female student
"He's still just as cute and cool as I remember."

Shun seemed to be popular with the second-year girls, too.
I had to concede that they had a point... I found myself agreeing almost as if I were a third party.
Shun is good at pretty much everything (except studying), but he's especially talented at sports.
Basketball is no exception. He moved across the court with light, nimble steps, handling the ball with ease.
Even putting aside my bias as a family member, I had to admit he looked genuinely cool.

Teacher
"Hey! You guys, focus on your own class!"

At the teacher's warning, all of us second-years went back to our boring ball drills.
Set, receive, spike...
Set, receive, spike...
We mechanically repeated the same monotonous motions, almost as though we'd fallen into a trance.
It was when we began yet another round of spike practice (I'd long since lost track of how many) that a particularly loud cheer rose from the first-years' side.
My eyes reflexively turned in that direction.
Shun stood outside the three-point line, ball in hand.
Oshii-kun and another boy were guarding him together, but Shun seemed completely unfazed. His gaze remained fixed solely on the basket.

Female student
"Shun-kuuuun! You gooot this!"
Male student
"Shun! Make the shot!"

Everyone was cheering Shun on like it was the most natural thing in the world.

And I was thinking…

Options:
(1) (Go for it, Oshii-kun!)
(2) (Go for it, Shun!)

(Go for it, Oshii-kun!)

Seeing Oshii-kun trying so hard to guard Shun, I found myself rooting for him.
As I silently cheered him on in my head...

Yu･Nozomi
"!"

I locked eyes with Oshii-kun.
At that very moment, Shun dipped low.
(Go to "Common")

(Go for it, Shun!)

I didn't say it aloud, but just like everyone else, I silently cheered Shun on in my head.
Under the intense gaze of everyone watching, Shun lowered his stance slightly.
(Go to "Common")

Common

And then...
The ball left Shun's hands, tracing a beautiful arc toward the basket.
With a satisfying "swish," it slipped cleanly through the net.

Female student
"Kyaa! Nice one, Shun-kun!!!"
Female student
"Yaay!"

The girls' excited squeals grew even louder.
Shun was grinning from ear to ear as he high-fived his teammates.
...Jeez... He made that look easy.
Damn, he was so cool.
I bet he just made a few more girls fall for him...
As I thought that...

Miho Orikasa
"Nozomi, watch out!!!"

I heard Miho's yell.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Bwuh?!"

Shock flashed across my face, as though I'd been slapped.
I realized, with surprising clarity, that I'd just taken a volleyball to the face. I had enough composure to process that much. That was about as long as it lasted.
Because the next moment...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-whoa!"

My balance was thrown off, and I started to fall to the ground.
I tensed my legs and hips, desperately trying to stop myself from toppling over.
Oh, no. I'm going down.

Nozomi Anesaki
"!!!"

I felt a strange crack from inside my right ankle.
The pain was so excruciating that a scream caught in my throat, and despite my futile attempt to keep myself upright, I collapsed to the floor.

Miho Orikasa
"Wha... Nozomi, are you okay?!"

Several people hurried over to me at once.
I slowly sat up and managed to put on a strained smile.

Nozomi Anesaki
"My right leg hurts pretty badly."
Male student
"I-I'm sorry, Anesaki-san... That was my ball..."
Female student
"Your aim is awful."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well… I wasn't exactly paying attention either..."
Miho Orikasa
"First things first, let's get you to the nurse."

I leaned on her for support as I carefully got to my feet on one leg.
After letting the teacher know, I left the gym with Miho.
The nurse was still treating my sprained ankle when the bell rang, marking the end of class.
Fortunately, I had no more classes for the rest of the day. Since there was no reason to rush, I took my time leaving the nurse's office.

Miho Orikasa
"How's your leg?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"The pain's better than it was earlier. I'm just glad it's only a mild sprain."

Still, it looked like I wouldn't be able to put any weight on my right foot for a while.

Yu

If you chose to cheer Yu
I was making my way down the hallway on crutches when I spotted Oshii-kun up ahead. When our eyes met, he came rushing over in a panic.

Yu Oshii
"Senpai! Are you okay?! Is your injury serious...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm okay. It's just a sprain."
Yu Oshii
"O-oh... that's good."

The tension left Oshii-kun's face.
Did he come all the way here just to check on me?
His kindness, as always, made my heart flutter a little.

Nozomi Anesaki
"By the way, I'm sorry about earlier."
Yu Oshii
"Pardon?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"We made eye contact, remember? I thought maybe that broke your concentration…"
Yu Oshii
"Ah... Shun was already in position to shoot by then, so I don't think I could've changed the outcome..."

Oshii-kun scratched his cheek, looking a little embarrassed.

Yu Oshii
"Two of us were guarding him, and I still couldn't do a thing... That was so pathetic."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's not true."
Yu Oshii
"Uh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I could tell you were really giving it your all. I thought you looked cool."
Yu Oshii
"...But that's exactly why it was so embarrassing. I was taking it seriously, and he still got around me so easily."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ahaha. No matter how it turned out, you looked cool trying your best. That's all that matters."
Yu Oshii
"...R-really?"

Oshii-kun was blushing.
...Maybe I praised him a little too much.
For some reason, I always found it easier to speak my mind around Oshii-kun.
The mood between us had grown just a little too awkward, leaving me fidgeting nervously, when I suddenly felt someone's eyes on me from the side.
It was Shun.

Shun Anesaki
"Hey."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, you came too, Shun."
Shun Anesaki
"...Is your leg okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, it's fine. Just a sprain."
Shun Anesaki
"Good."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's almost time for cleaning*, so you two should get back to class."
*Japanese students clean their school.
Yu Oshii
"Yes, understood."
Shun Anesaki
"...Okay."
Nozomi Anesaki
"See you later."

As I watched Oshii-kun and Shun walk away, Miho, who had been standing beside me, leaned closer with a mischievous grin.

Miho Orikasa
"Hey, hey, who was that guy just now?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oshii-kun? He's Shun's friend."
Miho Orikasa
"Oooh. You guys seemed kinda close."
Nozomi Anesaki
"HUH?! N-no, we didn't! No way."
Miho Orikasa
"You two seemed like you were in your ooown little world."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, not true."

She was just imagining things.
(Go to the next chapter.)

Shun

If you chose to cheer Shun
I was making my way down the hallway on crutches when Shun came running toward me from ahead.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun. What happened?"
Shun Anesaki
"Nothing... Just checking on your leg."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh… this. It looks kind of bad, but it's only a minor sprain."
Shun Anesaki
"Oh... Good."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Though, you should probably worry about yourself first. Your uniform is a wreck. Your shirt's barely buttoned, your tie's crooked, and your fly is open."
Shun Anesaki
"?! Uwah…!"

Shun hurriedly zipped up his pants.
I chuckled softly and gave him a couple of light pats on the shoulder.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Cleaning's* about to start, so don't be late. And fix your shirt and tie before you go."
*Japanese students clean their school.
Shun Anesaki
"...I know. See ya."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. Bye-bye."

Shun ran off.
Once he was out of sight, Miho burst out laughing.

Miho Orikasa
"That was so adooorable."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Shun?"
Miho Orikasa
"Mhm, mhm. He got all red while he was zipping up his pants."
Nozomi Anesaki

"...And that's adorable?"
Miho Orikasa
"No, I mean, he was so worried about his dear sister that he rushed over without even noticing his pants were still unzipped. That's pretty cute."

...Ahh. Now I see.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Now that you put it that way... I suppose he really can be cute sometimes."
Miho Orikasa
"Riiight? He's such a good little brother."

As I listened to Miho's heartfelt observation, I found myself reflecting on what Shun was usually like.
He had a terrible attitude and a mouth to match. He was pretty obnoxious in a lot of ways. But for all his faults, he always did what I asked of him, and if I was worried about something, he'd hear me out.
He'd even come running over just now because he was worried about me. He might not make it obvious, but he was actually quite kind.
Besides...
It wouldn't be an exaggeration to say I had Shun to thank for the blissful life I got to enjoy at school.
With that in mind, I found myself thinking that perhaps I ought to do a little more to show Shun how grateful I was.

Chapter 6: An unexpected question

After school, I slowly made my way toward the student council room on crutches.
As I passed by the entrance, I caught sight of Shun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun?"
Shun Anesaki
"Ah... Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What's up? You're just standing there staring into space."
Shun Anesaki
"Nothing... Are you heading home?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No. I'm staying at school a little longer."
Shun Anesaki
"Oh... Is that so?"

The look on his face was one of genuine surprise. Don't tell me...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Were you waiting for me?"

Shun Anesaki
"...No, well... You're injured and all. I figured I'd at least carry your things on the way home."

He mumbled the words, averting his eyes. I was a little touched.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I think this was my first time seeing a real-life tsundere."
Shun Anesaki
"?! Wh-what?! Never mind! Looks like you've got somewhere to be, so I'm going home."

And, in textbook tsundere fashion, Shun abruptly turned on his heel to leave.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun!"
Shun Anesaki
"...What?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you."
Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun stopped in his tracks, staring at me blankly. His face looked a little flushed, too.
Is he actually blushing? ...What is with him today? He is strangely cute.

???
"Anesaki-san."

Suddenly, I heard a voice call out from behind me.
I turned around to find Hoshina-senpai standing there with his usual bright smile.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hello, Hoshina-senpai."
Mizuho Hoshina
"You're heading to the student council room, right? If you'd like, we could go toge— Wait... what happened to your leg?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I sprained it a little during class..."
Mizuho Hoshina
"Oh, I see. Are you feeling okay? I'll carry your bag."

Hoshina-senpai took my bag from me like a gentleman. Everything he does is just so attractive.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... Thank you very much."
Mizuho Hoshina
"You're welcome. Shall we go to the student council room now?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"Yes. ...Shun."

When I turned back to Shun, he had the sulkiest look on his face.
...What, was he trying to tell me to stop fawning over Hoshina-senpai? It's not my fault. Hoshina-senpai is just too handsome.

Nozomi Anesaki
"See you."
Shun Anesaki
"...Yeah."

Shun grumbled something under his breath and trudged out of the entrance.
Good grief... Sometimes he is cute, and sometimes he is a pain. My little brother is a complicated guy.

Mizuho Hoshina
"All right, I think that's about it for today. Good work, everyone."
Treasurer
"Good work."
Secretary
"Good work, good work."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good work, everyone."

After the student council meeting ended, I said goodbye to Hoshina-senpai and the others and headed to the library.
When I entered, I found Oshii-kun studying quietly in the same spot as yesterday.

Yu Oshii
"Ah, Senpai."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry I kept you waiting."
Yu Oshii
"Don't mention it. By the way, how's your leg?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It doesn't hurt right now, so I'm fine."
Yu Oshii
"That's good to hear."

Oshii-kun stood up and pulled out the chair across from him for me.

Yu Oshii
"Please, have a seat."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you."
Yu Oshii
"You're welcome. Still, is your leg really okay? ...Could it be broken?"

Oshii-kun approached me with a worried look.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No, nothing like that. It's just a mild sprain."
Yu Oshii
"Oh... That's good. ...Actually, no. A sprain isn't really good, either."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really, it's not nearly as bad as it looks."

I leaned my crutches against the wall in the corner and carefully sat down in the chair. Oshii-kun returned to his seat and bowed his head apologetically.

Yu Oshii
"Sorry to make you come all the way here when you're already tired from student council work."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't worry about it. We don't really do anything that strenuous in student council."
Yu Oshii
"Is that so?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes."

If anything, student council meetings were more like a little therapeutic break for me. I got to spend plenty of time admiring Hoshina-senpai.

Yu Oshii
"...The student council president..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Yu Oshii
"No... It's just... This is kind of a weird question, but..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes?"
Yu Oshii
"Are you... dating him?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ahaha, no."

I immediately said no. I was pretty used to getting questions like that.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I've heard that rumor going around, but... we're really just the president and vice president."
Yu Oshii
"Ah... I see..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah."
Yu Oshii
"...Still, you two make a pretty good match."

...That was another thing I'd heard countless times before.
But... I had a feeling there was some other intention behind his words.
I stared at Oshii-kun, but he avoided my eyes.
Then he quietly laid out the test paper from the practice exam we reviewed the other day.

Yu Oshii
"Well then, shall we get started?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Okay."

I decided not to dwell on the little things.
I quickly put them out of my mind and focused on teaching.
I must have been incredibly absorbed, because the hours seemed to pass in the blink of an eye.
It was only when the school bell signaling the end of the school day rang that Oshii-kun and I finally set down our pens.

Yu Oshii
"Wow, it's already this late?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"We really got a lot of studying done, huh?"
Yu Oshii
"Sorry for keeping you here so long."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's fine. You pick things up really quickly, Oshii-kun. It's actually fun teaching you."
Yu Oshii
"That's because you're really good at teaching, Senpai."
Nozomi Anesaki
"And you're pretty good at flattering people, Oshii-kun."

The two of us left the library laughing together.
It had only been a few days since I met Oshii-kun, but we'd already gotten comfortable enough around each other to banter so naturally.
The truth is, I'm actually pretty shy around people.
I tend to be more nervous than I let on.
But for some reason, whenever I'm around Oshii-kun, I feel strangely at ease.

Yu Oshii
"Ah, Senpai. Let me carry your bag."

Oshii-kun effortlessly took my bag from me. Just like Hoshina-senpai, every little thing he did was so gentlemanly.
And then, by comparison...
Shun's grumpy little face materialized in my mind, and I couldn't help but laugh a little.

Yu Oshii
"? What's the matter?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Nothing... I was just thinking about Shun."
Yu Oshii
"About Shun...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's right. He was waiting for me at the entrance before I went to the student council."
Yu Oshii
"Waiting for you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. He said, 'You're injured, so I'll carry your bag.' Such a classic tsun— ...Well, he's just terrible at expressing himself. It was pretty funny."
Yu Oshii
"Oh..."

The tone of Oshii-kun's voice dropped slightly.
His usually gentle expression seemed a little more tense than before.
...I wonder what's wrong.
I nervously studied Oshii-kun's profile as he continued to face forward. When he finally spoke, his voice was unusually solemn.

Yu Oshii
"Um... can I ask you something?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes...?"
Yu Oshii
"Senpai... how do you feel about Shun?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

That was a completely unexpected question.
What was Oshii-kun planning to do with this information?
I couldn't quite figure out what he was getting at, so I decided to answer his question with a question of my own.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What exactly do you want to know?"
Yu Oshii
"...Well, I don't like beating around the bush either, so can I just ask you directly?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Go ahead."

Oshii-kun paused for a moment.
And then...

Yu Oshii
"Do you like Shun? Romantically, I mean."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Bwuf!"

I reacted pretty ungracefully, I have to admit.
But I mean, come on... you can't blame me, right?!

Nozomi Anesaki
"Why would you even think that?!"
Yu Oshii
"Is it strange?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Of course!"
Yu Oshii
"Why is that?"

Why?! How could he possibly need me to explain why?!

Nozomi Anesaki
"Because Shun is my younger brother, you know? He. Is. My. Brother!"

I couldn't have emphasized it more if I tried. For a brief moment, Oshii-kun's expression tightened, as though he found that irritating.

Yu Oshii
"Brother..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. You knew that already, right?"
Yu Oshii
"...Well... yes. Of course I know. You're the Anesaki siblings."
Nozomi Anesaki
"E-exactly... So if you already knew that, why would you ask me something like that...?"
Yu Oshii
"Well... You and Shun looked really close, so I just blurted it out without thinking."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... I guess we are pretty close..."

I felt like that exchange alone had taken a massive chunk out of my HP.
After letting out a deep sigh, Oshii-kun gave me a slightly apologetic smile.

Yu Oshii
"I'm sorry. That was a strange thing to ask."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It really was..."
Yu Oshii
"...'Brother'... I see... In that case... Please keep thinking of him that way. Always."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...?"

What was that supposed to mean? Something about his words felt... off.

I stared at Oshii-kun once again, but he merely smiled in a way that gave away nothing of what he was really thinking.

Chapter 7: On my way home

When we reached the entrance, Oshii-kun stood beside me holding my bag as I was putting on my shoes. He really is a gentleman.

Yu Oshii
"Is your leg really okay? Can you put your shoe on properly?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Oshii-kun, it's like you're my mom."
Yu Oshii
"Your mom..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hehe. I'm fine. It's really just a sprain."

First, I changed into my left shoe, then carefully slipped my injured right foot into the opening of my loafer...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ow...!"

A sharp jolt of pain shot through my ankle for a split second.
I reeled from the pain...

Yu Oshii
"Whoa! A-are you okay?"

Oshii-kun immediately caught me before I could fall.
...Phew, that was close.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry. And thank you."
Yu Oshii
"No... Um, actually, maybe I should walk you home after all?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? No, no, it's fine! Your house is in the opposite direction, right? That'd be a huge detour."
Yu Oshii
"True... But honestly, you're looking a little unsteady right now."
Yu Oshii
"I've decided—I'll walk you home."

He sounded so decisive, as though the matter were already settled, that continuing to protest seemed rather pointless.

Besides, I didn't really have a reason to say no. If anything, I kind of wanted to spend a little more time with Oshii-kun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay... I guess I'll take you up on that."
Yu Oshii
"Of course. I'd be happy to help."

The walk home with Oshii-kun was surprisingly comfortable.
Maybe it was because of his gentle, easygoing manner. Whatever the reason, I felt completely at ease around him.
And therein lay the problem: if I relaxed too much, it was all too easy for my real self to come out. So despite how comfortable the walk felt, I still had to be careful not to let my guard down completely.

Yu Oshii
"You're easier to talk to than I expected, Senpai."

That offhand comment from Oshii-kun made me tense up.

Nozomi Anesaki
"R-really...?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes. You're actually quite different from the impression I had of you."

What... exactly was he trying to say...?
Did he mean that I was more ordinary than he'd expected...?
If so, then the whole "brilliant, beautiful vice president" image I've built up is starting to fall apart...
...Uh-oh. I really need to get my act together.
I straightened my posture again, and Oshii-kun continued with the same gentle smile.

Yu Oshii
"I like you even more now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"

Oshii-kun was still smiling innocently.
I couldn't see any particular emotion on his face. So maybe there wasn't any deeper meaning to what he'd said.
Apparently, he liked me better when I was just being myself.
That was pretty nice.
No, actually… It made me really, really happy.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You're also easy to talk to, Oshii-kun."
Yu Oshii
"Really?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes."

I was tempted to borrow Oshii-kun's words and tell him, "I like you even more now," but I couldn't bring myself to actually say it.
Maybe Oshii-kun was the kind of guy who could effortlessly charm girls without even realizing he was doing it.
After we'd been walking along the route home for a little while, I spotted a small boy wandering around at the edge of the road.
He was probably an elementary school kid.
He seemed to be searching for something, repeatedly looking around the area.

Options:
(1) I wonder what's wrong.
(2) I'll leave him be.

I wonder what's wrong. (Shun)

I wonder what's wrong. He looks a little uneasy... I can't help worrying about him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oshii-kun."
Yu Oshii
"Yes?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Doesn't that boy seem like he might need some help?"
Yu Oshii
"Ah, yes. I think he's looking for something."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What if he's lost?"
Yu Oshii
"Hmm... That's definitely possible… Should we go talk to him?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, let's."

We approached the boy.
As soon as we stopped in front of him, he took a wary step backward.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hello. What are you doing?"

I asked with the gentlest smile I could manage. I tried to lower myself to his eye level, but the crutches made it difficult.

Boy
"..."

The boy glared at us with a grumpy expression. He kind of reminded me of Shun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you playing around here?"
Boy
"...No."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you looking for something?"

He gave a little nod.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What are you looking for?"
Boy
"...Mayuko."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Mayuko..."

Wait... what is that? Is it someone's name?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Your friend?"
Boy
"No."

He shook his head.

Boy
"My big sister."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ahh... your big sister. Were you with her?"
Boy
"...Yeah. But she just disappeared."

...So he's gotten separated from his sister.
Or maybe his sister was the one who got lost...
Either way, it didn't feel right to just leave him here.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Do you know where your home is?"

The boy tilted his head with a troubled look on his face. Apparently, he didn't know.
I looked to Oshii-kun standing beside me for help.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What should we do?"
Yu Oshii
"Hmm... I think we should take him to a police station."

Nozomi Anesaki
"I agree. If we're going there, we'll have to take a bit of a detour. You can head home, Oshii-kun."
Yu Oshii
"No. I'm coming with you. I'll walk you home."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Is it not going to be late for you?"
Yu Oshii
"No. It's not a problem."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Isn't my bag heavy?"
Yu Oshii
"Not at all."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're pretty strong, huh? I've got a bunch of thick study guides in here..."
Yu Oshii
"Ah, no wonder..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"So it is heavy."
Yu Oshii
"...No."

I couldn't help finding Oshii-kun's deadpan headshake amusing. I chuckled and reached for my bag.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry, but I think I'll carry it myself after all. Thanks for your help."
Yu Oshii
"It's really no trouble. I'll carry it. Besides, the boy looks bored, so we should get moving."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Ah, you're right."

The boy was kicking a stone by the roadside, clearly bored out of his mind.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Let's go to a police station together, okay?"
Boy
"...What about my sister?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm... I'm sure we'll be able to find her once we get there."
Boy
"...Okay. I'll go."

We slowly started walking, with the boy falling into step beside us.
He still had that same grumpy look on his face, which kept reminding me of Shun.

Image:
International exchange center "White Bridge"

On the way to the police box, we asked him a few questions and learned that he'd been on his way home from shopping when he got separated from his big sister.
Well... I could kind of see how that might have happened.
Apparently, he was a very curious kid. His eyes kept darting from one thing to another, and before we knew it, he'd wandered off the road.
Sometimes, we'd turn around only to find him standing still.
It was nerve-racking. Every time I looked away for even a moment, he'd somehow materialize in a completely different spot.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah! Watch out!!!"

A car drove past right beside the boy as he wandered into the road.
Thankfully, Oshii-kun quickly grabbed his hand and pulled him back before anything happened, but that was way too close for comfort...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Maybe we should keep him close..."
Yu Oshii
"Yes. I'll keep holding his hand."
Boy
"No."

The boy spat the word out and swatted Oshii-kun's hand away.

Yu Oshii
"Huh?"

The boy fixed Oshii-kun with an irritated glare, as though warning him to back off.

Yu Oshii
"Did I do something...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hahaha, I have no idea."

I was trying to come up with something reassuring to say to the visibly dejected Oshii-kun when the boy suddenly spun around.

Boy
"I want her."

He pointed straight at me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Me?"
Boy
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki

"You want to hold my hand?"
Boy
"Yeah."
Yu Oshii
"...Precocious brat."

...I could've sworn there was something vaguely ominous in Oshii-kun's voice just now. But surely that was just my imagination.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm... I'm on crutches, though..."

It'd be a little difficult for me to hold his hand.

Yu Oshii
"That settles it."

Oshii-kun took the boy's hand without giving him a chance to argue.
The boy struggled for a while, trying to pull free, but eventually seemed to realize he couldn't win against Oshii-kun's strength and settled down.

Nozomi Anesaki
"By the way, what is your big sister like?"
Boy
"She's ugly."
Yu・Nozomi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hey, you shouldn't say that about your sister."
Boy
"But I'm just telling the truth."

What a cheeky little brat… He reminds me of Shun when he was younger.

Boy
"I prefer you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? What do you mean?"
Yu Oshii
"I think he means he wants you to be his big sister."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Really?"

The boy nodded.

Yu Oshii
"Looks like he really likes you, Senpai."
Nozomi Anesaki

"But I didn't even do anything."
Yu Oshii
"He's just a precocious brat."

Apparently, that uncharacteristic way Oshii-kun had spoken earlier wasn't just my imagination.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You don't like your big sister?"
Boy
"No."

He was so much like Shun from back then... And just as that thought crossed my mind, a girl who looked about ten or eleven came running toward us.

Girl
"Takumi!!!"
Boy
"Ah, Big Sis."

The boy's face lit up for just a moment. For all his talk, it seemed he really did like his big sister.

Girl
"Takumi!"

The girl stopped in front of us, breathing heavily. She then roughly grabbed the boy's hand.

Girl
"You ran off again!"
Boy
"No, you're the one who left me!"
Girl
"Well, it's because you keep stopping everywhere!"

The girl angrily tugged at the boy's arm.

Boy
"Ow! Let go of me!"
Girl
"No."
Boy
"Cow!"
Girl
"Shrimp!"

The siblings started fighting.

As Oshii-kun and I watched them in stunned silence, the siblings only got more heated and began wrestling with each other.

Girl
"Anyway, we're going home!"
Boy
"No! Let go of me!!!"
Girl
"Stop being so stubborn!!!"
Boy
"No!!!"

The boy slapped the girl's hand away with all his might.
That seemed to be the last straw. She angrily stomped her feet and turned her back on him.

Girl
"Fine! Then I'm going home alone!"
Boy
"Go ahead."
Girl
"And don't come crying to me when you get lost on your own!!!"

She spat out those words and took off without so much as a second thought.
This was a problem.
I hurriedly tried to call after her, but just as I opened my mouth...

Boy
"Uu..."

The boy let out a tiny sob.
His face crumpled as he clenched his mouth shut, desperately trying to hold it in.
And then...

Boy
"Waaaaahhh!!!"

He started crying.

Yu・Nozomi
"..."

Caught off guard by the sudden outburst, Oshii-kun and I looked at each other.
Then we both snapped back to reality and hurriedly tried to calm the boy down.

Nozomi Anesaki
"C-calm down, okay? Please?"
Boy
"Waaaaahhh!!!"

Yu Oshii
"B-blerp-bleh-bleh…"

Oshii-kun suddenly pulled a hilariously stupid expression, but I wasn't sure whether it was appropriate for me to laugh, so I simply kept a straight face.
The boy, similarly, ignored Oshii-kun's desperate attempt to make him laugh and kept crying his eyes out.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Niiii."

I figured I might as well join Oshii-kun.

Boy
"UWAAAAAAAAAAAAAH...!"

…I think we only made things worse.

Boy
"Waaaah!!! Big Siiiiis...!"
Yu Oshii
"…I'll go get his sister. I'll be right back."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes. Please."
Yu Oshii
"Please wait here, Senpai."

But before Oshii-kun could move, a small shadow fell across the ground in front of us.

Girl
"..."

The girl had already returned. She must have been running the whole way, because she was breathing hard, her shoulders rising and falling rapidly.
She stepped in front of her still-bawling little brother and gave his cheek a little pinch.

Girl
"...You're too noisy."
Boy
"!!!"

The boy abruptly stopped crying.
When he recognized his older sister standing before him, his face crumpled again.

Boy
"B-Big Sis...!"
Girl
"Yeah, yeah."

With a resigned shrug, the girl vigorously wiped the tears from the corners of her brother's eyes with her palm.
Her touch was clumsy and rough, but the gentle look in her eyes as she gazed at him was unmistakably that of a big sister.
Once the boy finally calmed down, the girl bowed deeply to us.

Girl
"I'm sorry my little brother caused you so much trouble."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Not at all. Please be careful on your way home."
Girl
"Okay."

The girl reached for her little brother's hand. This time, he didn't try to pull away.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Bye-bye."
Boy
"...Bye-bye."
Girl
"Don't just say bye-bye. Thank them properly!"
Boy
"…Thank you very much."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're welcome."
Girl
"…Come on, we're leaving."
Boy
"Ow! Quit pulling me!"
Girl
"You're too slow."
Boy
"I run faster than you."
Girl
"Yeah, sure."

The girl and boy walked off, still bickering loudly on their way.
It was pretty cute, though, seeing how they kept their hands firmly clasped together the whole time.

Yu Oshii
"For all their fighting, they really do get along."

Oshii-kun watched them go with a wry smile. I smiled too and nodded in agreement.

Nozomi Anesaki
"That boy really reminded me of Shun."

Yu Oshii
"Huh? Shun?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"He used to have quite the attitude, too."

Well, he is still kind of a brat.

Yu Oshii
"Ohh… So did you two used to fight like that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"We did. And we were way more vicious than that."
Yu Oshii
"…Really? …That sounds kind of nice, actually."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh, the fighting? There was nothing nice about it… It was honestly frustrating."
Yu Oshii
"Hahaha. I'm an only child, so I guess I kind of envy people who have that experience."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Even if you had siblings, I can't picture you fighting with them."
Yu Oshii
"That may be true."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Anyway, shall we go home?"
Yu Oshii
"Sure."

We turned around and headed back the way we'd come.
A bicycle came speeding toward us from ahead. The rider was being pretty reckless, too distracted by their phone to notice what was around them.
They were on a collision course with Oshii-kun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oshii-kun, watch out!"
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Oshii-kun?"
Yu Oshii
"..."

Oshii-kun seemed to be lost in thought, his mind somewhere else entirely.
I quickly wedged my crutches under my arm and grabbed his hand, pulling him out of the way.

Yu Oshii
"Whoa?!"

It was a close call. The bicycle narrowly missed Oshii-kun, speeding past right beside him.

He blinked in surprise, then stared dazedly at the hand I was still holding.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You seemed pretty out of it… Are you okay?"
Yu Oshii
"Huh…? Oh, s-sorry! I was just lost in thought…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're going to wind up like that little boy."
Yu Oshii
"…Right. I'll be more careful…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Want me to hold your hand?"
Yu Oshii
"! Wh-what are you saying?! I'm not a child!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ahaha, I'm just kidding."
Yu Oshii
"Please... enough already."
(Go to "Conclusion.")

I'll leave him be. (Yu)

Since I didn't notice anything else unusual, I decided to simply leave him be.
(Go to "Conclusion.")

Conclusion

My house finally came into view.
Getting home took longer than expected because I was using crutches.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry, Oshii-kun. I made you stay out so late."
Yu Oshii
"Please don't worry about it. Is that your house, Senpai?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. Thanks for seeing me home. You don't have to carry my bag anymore."

I took my bag from him.
Oshii-kun gazed up at my house, then turned to me with an unusually solemn look.

Yu Oshii
"Do you live here with your family of four?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No. My parents are overseas for work right now."
Yu Oshii

"…Both of them?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. My mom went with my dad, so they're both away."
Yu Oshii
"Oh..."

Oshii-kun went quiet.
After a moment, he seemed to pull himself together and turned back to me.

Yu Oshii
"…Well then, I'll be going now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay. Take care on your way home, Oshii-kun."
Yu Oshii
"Of course. Goodbye."

After seeing Oshii-kun off, I opened the front door.
Before I could even say "I'm home," Shun poked his head out from the living room.

Shun Anesaki
"Welcome home. You're pretty late."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm back. It took me longer than usual because of my leg."

Once again, I slowly made my way along with my crutches before sitting down on the entryway floor.
After carefully removing both shoes, I turned halfway around while still seated.
I placed both hands on the floor, gathered my strength, and tried to push myself upright using just one leg.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hup—ugh…!"

I promptly lost my balance in dramatic fashion.

Shun Anesaki
"?! Woah?!"

I toppled right into Shun, who was standing in front of me.
Shun couldn't stay on his feet either. Still trying to catch me, he fell backward with me, and we went down like a pair of dominoes.

Shun Anesaki
"Ow...!"

A heavy thud echoed through the entryway, followed by Shun's groan. He must have landed hard on his nape and his back.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Woah, are you hurt?! ...Well, you obviously are."
Shun Anesaki
"Why would you try to stand up without your crutches?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well… I thought I'd be okay…"
Shun Anesaki
"Don't be reckless!"

Shun abruptly sat up.
I was still sitting astride him, and suddenly, the distance between us closed rapidly.

Shun・Nozomi
"..."

Our gazes locked, and for some reason, both of us froze.
We remained like that, staring at each other.
For some reason, neither of us said a word.
It was as if time itself had stopped, leaving us completely motionless.

Yu Oshii
"Do you like Shun? Romantically, I mean."

Nozomi Anesaki
"NO WAY!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"Bwah?!"

I brushed off Oshii-kun's outrageous question. By doing so, I apparently slapped Shun across the face.

Shun Anesaki
"What the hell?!"

I got off Shun, who was still yelling at me, and got to my feet using my crutches.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry."
Shun Anesaki
"Jeez... I just don't get you... Why did you slap me…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Just because?"
Shun Anesaki
"Are you kidding me…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I said I'm sorry. I didn't do it on purpose. It's just that your face happened to be right there."
Shun Anesaki
"...Man... Were you fantasizing about something again…?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Fantasizing..."

Do you like Shun? Romantically, I mean.

Nozomi Anesaki
"UWAAAHHHHHHHHHH!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"Whoa?! What was that?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry, I just need to go hide in my room and calm down…"
Shun Anesaki
"O-okay...? Dinner will be ready in 30 minutes."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Got it."

As I walked past Shun, I secretly cursed Oshii-kun in my mind.
Honestly... he planted some strange ideas in my head…

Chapter 8: Another question

After getting out of the bath, I sprawled out on my bed and booted up my game.
This was my favorite part of the day.
However...

Nozomi Anesaki
"I've already cleared all of Lord Wald's endings..."

I'd replayed the event scenes so many times that I practically had all the dialogue memorized, so I was starting to get a little bored.
Maybe I'll try a different character today…
Oh, come to think of it, there is one character whose route I haven't cleared yet.

Nozomi Anesaki
"A younger brother character..."

I wasn't really feeling it.
I'd never found the younger-brother archetype appealing. Maybe it was because I had a younger brother of my own.
Still… I wanted to fully complete the game...

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'll give it a shot…"

I pressed the button.
A moment later, there was a knock.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? What?"
Shun Anesaki
"Can I come in?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sure?"

Shun walked in, his hands occupied with notebooks, a pencil case, and various other things.

Shun Anesaki
"Are we not studying today...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh…"

I was caught off guard. I never expected Shun to suggest studying together.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What happened to you? Since when are you so eager to study?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh…? But yesterday you said you were going to keep teaching me, Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I guess I did..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Huh, you're not gonna?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, no! I will, I will! Let's do it!"

Since Shun was feeling motivated for once, I wanted to make the most of it and drill as much knowledge into him as possible before he changed his mind.
I sat up and tried to get out of bed, but...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ow!"

A sharp pain shot through my right ankle.

Shun Anesaki
"Oi, oi. ...What are you doing?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I forgot I sprained my ankle…"
Shun Anesaki
"Jeez. Hang on a second."

Shun left the room.
A few minutes later, he returned with a first-aid kit.

Shun Anesaki
"You'd better keep it properly supported for a while."

He sat down in front of me beside the bed.

Shun Anesaki
"Put your leg out."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

My leg…? For some reason… I felt kind of embarrassed.

Shun Anesaki
"...? Come on. Hurry."
Nozomi Anesaki
"O-okay."

I reluctantly held out my right leg toward Shun.
His fingers glided over the top of my foot.
A shiver went through me. An odd chill crawled up my spine.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Eek…!"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't touch me like that…!"
Shun Anesaki
"Wh-whaat…? What are you talking about?"

Shun gave me an incredulous look and touched my foot again.
A wave of shivers ran through me. This time, I distinctly felt goosebumps spread across my skin.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Stop! Stop, stop!"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's enough…! I'll do it myself, so let go of me!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"O-okay."

Shun quickly let go, perhaps taken aback by how forceful I was.
…Phew. I never realized having someone touch my foot could feel this uncomfortable…

Shun Anesaki
"Here, a pain-relief patch."

Shun quickly cut a piece of the patch and held it out to me. I took it from him and stuck it onto my ankle.

Shun Anesaki
"And here's some athletic tape. Make sure you secure it properly."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay."

Or so I said, but I wasn't really sure how I was supposed to secure it.
How did the nurse wrap it again?
I think it was something like this… and then this…

Nozomi Anesaki
"And… like this…? Huh...?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"You suck at this. Let me handle it."

Shun took the athletic tape from me.
Sensing that he was about to touch me again, I instinctively pulled my leg back.

Shun Anesaki
"Hey… give me your foot."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…But you're gonna touch me."
Shun Anesaki
"I can't wrap it without touching you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I know that..."
Shun Anesaki
"Did you make a fuss like this at school, too?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah…"

That made me stop and think.
I don't think I felt anything in particular when the nurse wrapped it for me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…It's the way you touch me. It feels kinda lewd."
Shun Anesaki
"I'm touching you normally."
Nozomi Anesaki

"No… I don't know how to explain it… Your touch is just too erotic."
Shun Anesaki
"You're an idiot."

Shun forcibly pulled my leg toward him.
Another shiver ran through me, and I bit down hard on my lip.

Shun Anesaki
"Uh… Why are you so tense…? You're making it look like I'm doing something weird."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You are."
Shun Anesaki
"*Sigh*... Whatever. Just hold still, okay?"

Shun firmly held my leg in place and began wrapping it with athletic tape.
His hands moved smoothly, securing my ankle with surprising ease.
I couldn't help but be impressed by his skill. It was almost as if he'd done this countless times before.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You're pretty good at this. Have you done it before?"
Shun Anesaki
"Hm? No, not really. It's not that hard."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ohh..."

Shun really is incredibly dexterous.
He's not only athletic, but also surprisingly skilled at delicate, meticulous tasks like this.
It's honestly a talent I envy. With skills like that, I doubt he'll ever have to worry about finding a job.
And the career Shun wants to pursue is...

Nozomi Anesaki
"A hairstylist..."
Shun Anesaki
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're aiming to become a hairstylist, right?"
Shun Anesaki
"? Why are you suddenly asking?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well... I just thought you are really suited for it."
Shun Anesaki
"…You think so?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah."

I found myself looking back on the old days.

Back in middle school. Otherwise known as my dark past.
I was a total otaku with a seriously dowdy look, and Shun was the one who taught me how to be fashionable.
If I'd stayed the way I was back then, I'm sure I'd still have been stuck at the very bottom of the school social ladder.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Why did you decide you wanted to become a hairstylist?"

I'd been curious about it for a while, so I decided to ask.
Shun tilted his head slightly as he finished up the tape.

Shun Anesaki
"...Dunno. Why was it again?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh… You're awfully vague about your own dream…"
Shun Anesaki
"I'm not that passionate about it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Shun Anesaki
"Ah… I mean… it's not like there's always some deep reason behind it, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah. …There, done."

Shun finished wrapping the tape.
I carefully got out of bed and took a seat at the table.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Thanks. Shall we study now?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"And since this becomes y, you can use the formula we just went over, right?"
Shun Anesaki
"Oh, you're right."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Now try solving it using that approach."
Shun Anesaki
"Got it."

Shun started working through the problem on his own.
With nothing else to occupy me, I found myself studying him absentmindedly.
His hair was fine and soft-looking, with a naturally tousled texture completely different from mine.

Apparently it was naturally wavy, yet somehow it looked great without any real styling. How unfair.
He's got that handsome look of a total womanizer. I think this is another way the difference in our genes really shows.
And then there was his athletic ability. His dexterity. His impeccable sense of style.
His overall specs were practically those of an otome game love interest.
He's a different type from Hoshina-senpai, but I suppose Shun could qualify as a 2.1D guy too.
It's easy to see why he's so popular.
Do you like Shun? Romantically, I mean.
Oshii-kun's words resurfaced in my mind.
I dismissed them with a mental scoff. What a stupid question.
But if Shun weren't my younger brother…
If he weren't my brother…?
Maybe I would have fallen in love with him—

Nozomi Anesaki
"There is no way!!!"

I blurted it out before I could stop myself.

Shun Anesaki
"What?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah… No, sorry. I was just thinking out loud."

Good grief… What on earth was I thinking…?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Anyway... were you able to solve it?"

I pushed those dangerous thoughts aside and switched my brain back into study mode.
Shun held out his notebook, looking a little unsure.

Shun Anesaki
"I don't really get this part."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah… this part? Oshii-kun got stuck on it today, too."
Shun Anesaki
"...Yu?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. I think you're probably approaching it the same way Oshii-kun did. This part is a little tricky, admittedly…"
Shun Anesaki
"…Sis, were you studying with Yu again today?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, yeah. After school."
Shun Anesaki

"…So that's why you came home late…"

Shun fell silent, twirling his pen between his fingers. It felt as though the air around us had suddenly grown colder, and I naturally stopped talking as well.

Shun Anesaki
"…Sis."

His pen came to a halt.

Shun Anesaki
"…What do you think of Yu?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"

Shun stared intently at me.
He looked so serious that I didn't quite know how to react. I found myself thinking back to my conversation with Oshii-kun earlier today.
I was pretty sure Shun wanted to know whether I liked Oshii-kun romantically.
Not this again… I thought, already half sick of the subject. But I took a moment to seriously consider his question.
Oshii-kun… as a romantic prospect…

Options:
(1) It's unthinkable.
(2) It's not entirely unthinkable.

It's unthinkable.

This is unthinkable.
I slowly shook my head.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Look… it's not like I like Oshii-kun or anything, okay?"
Shun Anesaki
"Uh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't mean I hate him. I just mean I don't have romantic feelings for him."

It's true that Oshii-kun is easy to talk to, and I feel really comfortable around him.
Sure, sometimes he gives me butterflies or makes my heart skip a beat, and occasionally I even find myself thinking I'd like to romance him. But that's only when I see him through my otome game goggles.
When I put that aside and think about reality, though, I have absolutely no desire to become romantically involved with him.

Shun Anesaki

"Hmm..."

Still looking unconvinced, Shun started twirling his pen again.

Shun Anesaki
"But still…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"It's different for him, right?"
(Go to "Conclusion")

It's not entirely unthinkable.

Well… Oshii-kun is kind, he's a gentleman, and every now and then, he does make my heart flutter.
I can't really say whether what I feel for him is romantic, but at the very least, I do have feelings for him that go beyond what I'd feel for an ordinary junior.
Above all, I feel completely at ease when I'm with him.

Shun Anesaki
"Huh… hey… seriously…?"

Shun's face drained of color as he watched me mull it over.
That reaction snapped me out of my thoughts, and I quickly shook my head.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well, there is nothing going between us right now."
Shun Anesaki
"Right now…? So that means it might happen eventually?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't know… maybe…"
Shun Anesaki
"Who do you like better, Yu or Lord Wald…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Lord Wald, obviously."
Shun Anesaki
"...R-right…"

Shun let out a sigh of relief. I felt a little uneasy about his reaction.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Would it be bad if I liked Oshii-kun?"
Shun Anesaki
"! No! Uh…it's not like I'd have a problem with it… I mean, it's not like I could stop you… but…"
Shun Anesaki

"I don't know… it'd just feel weird, you know…? Having your friend date your sister and all…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Aah."

I could understand where he was coming from.
If, for example, Miho started dating Shun, I'd probably feel pretty weird about it too.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well, that's not going to happen, so you can relax."
Shun Anesaki
"...Really?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It can't happen unless Oshii-kun is interested in me."
Shun Anesaki
"...He clearly is."
(Go to "Conclusion")

Conclusion

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"
Shun Anesaki
"I mean… surely you can tell."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, you're wrong."

I knew what Shun was getting at.
He meant that Oshii-kun had feelings for me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"There is no way."
Shun Anesaki
"…How can you be so sure?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't know… Just a feeling?"

It's true that Oshii-kun has been very friendly toward me.
In fact, we've gotten a little closer than I would've expected over the past few days.
But for some reason, I just can't believe there are any romantic feelings behind it.
I can't really explain it. It's just a feeling. If I had to put it into words…

Nozomi Anesaki
"It's an otome gamer's intuition."
Shun Anesaki
"There it is."

Shun snorted, openly mocking me. I'd never seen him react like that before.

Shun Anesaki
"That whole 'otome gamer's intuition' thing of yours? I'm telling you, it's completely unreliable."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wha… Why…?"

He glared at me, clearly annoyed.
What…? Why was he looking at me like that?

Shun Anesaki
"…2D world and reality are two completely different things."

Eventually, Shun forced out the words in a low voice and fell silent again.
…Ah… I get it now… Of course.
Everything suddenly clicked.
Shun has someone he likes.
Maybe things aren't going very well between them.
Even someone as inexperienced as me knows that relationships in the real world don't go as smoothly as they do in the 2D world.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Your sister is rooting for you, okay...?"
Shun Anesaki
"…Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'll be cheering you on from the sidelines! I hope everything works out for you!"
Shun Anesaki
"...? What are you talking about?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't worry. You've got a lot going for you. Just try saying a few sweet things to her, and I'm sure she'll fall for you in no time."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Ughhh… oh, come ON!!!"

Shun raked a hand through his hair in frustration, then started kicking his feet like a child throwing a tantrum.

Shun Anesaki
"I can't stand you, Sis!!! You're so annoying!!!"

Nozomi Anesaki
"What?!"
Shun Anesaki
"You're pissing me off! Just get out already!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um, this is my room, you know."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"I'm going to bed. Later."

Shun angrily shoved his study materials together and stormed out of my room.
…What was that all about…?

Chapter 9: A scene from our weekend

In the days that followed, Shun and I continued to have little spats like the one we'd just had, but otherwise, life went on much as usual.
A week later my sprained ankle had finally healed.
It was the weekend, and I woke up feeling absolutely terrible about myself.

Wald
"Nozomi… What a pity…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Lord Wald... I'm so sorry…"
Wald
"No... If this is truly what your heart has decided, then I shall say no more."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I know it's wrong… but...!"
Wald
"You've chosen your brother, haven't you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yes..."
???
"Dear Sister...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah..."
Wald
"Haha. Your beloved is calling for you. You mustn't keep him waiting."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Lord Wald… Farewell…!"
???
"Dear Sister...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait for me! I'm coming! My precious brother…!"

???
"Dear Sister...!"
Shun Anesaki
"Dear Sister!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait… IT'S YOU?!"

It was the worst way to wake up.
I was still breathing a little heavily as I checked the alarm clock.
Almost noon. I panicked for a second, then remembered it was the weekend.
I relaxed my shoulders and flopped around on the bed.
Still… what a horrible dream…
Could it be because I completed the younger brother route in WataPuri last night?
Ugh, seriously… Why did Shun have to show up?! Just because he's my brother doesn't mean he gets an invite!
The younger-brother archetype is definitely not my thing.
If anything, clearing the route only reinforced that. Lord Wald is still number one.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"…You awake yet?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh! Yeah, yeah, I'm awake!"

I answered in a slightly high-pitched voice, and Shun came into the room.
I breathed a sigh of relief when I saw him looking just like he always did.
Apparently, Shun's WataPuri counterpart had traumatized me a little.

Shun Anesaki
"It's already noon. What do you want for lunch? Cup noodles or something?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sure."
Shun Anesaki
"Okay. …But seriously, what are you wearing…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

I glanced down at my outfit, prompted by his reaction.
There was nothing unusual about it. I was just wearing my usual summer loungewear—a camisole and a pair of hot pants.
One of the straps had slipped off my shoulder, so I pulled it back into place. Shun responded with an exasperated sigh.

Shun Anesaki
"Man... you look so sloppy at home. Put some decent clothes on."

With that, Shun quickly left the room.
Honestly, this kind of thing happens all the time on our days off.
Shun complains that I'm too fixated on my appearance, but whenever I let myself relax, he turns around and calls me "sloppy."
I suppose what he really wants is for me to always look my best.
I grudgingly changed into something a bit more presentable and headed to the bathroom.
I washed my face and peered into the mirror… Oh no, my skin looks so dull.
Pat, pat, pat...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun."
Shun Anesaki
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wanna go to the mall with me after we eat?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? Do you need something?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I ran out of face masks."
Shun Anesaki
"You could just grab some at the convenience store."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I know, but my ankle's finally better. I figured I might as well go somewhere a little farther out."
Shun Anesaki
"Like you ever leave the house when you're healthy."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ugh… Come on. You don't have anything to do today anyway, right?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, yeah, fine… Though I guess I'm just there to carry your bags."

Shun grumbled to himself while eating his cup noodles.
Once we both finished eating, we got up from the table.

Shun Anesaki
"Call me when you're ready. I'll clean up here."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay."

One and a half hours later.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm ready!"
Shun Anesaki

"FINALLY!!!"

I got yelled at.

Shun Anesaki
"What the heck were you doing for an hour and a half?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What? Same thing I always do."

…Well, maybe I did put a little more effort into my makeup today.

Shun Anesaki
"Come on, Sis… you seriously spend way too long getting ready. Don't you think it's time you stopped?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, right. Then you'd just turn around and call me sloppy."
Shun Anesaki
"There's such a thing as going too far. You don't have to do all that. Just keep it simple."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What's wrong with that? You'd rather I look pretty too, wouldn't you?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."

He just went quiet, looking thoroughly annoyed. What exactly was he so bothered by?

Shun Anesaki
"…Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"Do you even enjoy it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Enjoy what?"
Shun Anesaki
"…All this dressing up. Doesn't it get tiring?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What? No… I mean, it's not really tiring. It's just become a habit."
Shun Anesaki
"…I see."

Shun headed for the front door, still looking grumpy.
What was going on…? I seriously couldn't figure him out.
Even with my otome game filter activated, I couldn't read Shun's mind at all.
This guy's route is way too difficult to clear.

Chapter 10: Shopping

I managed to get Shun out of his bad mood along the way, and we ended up walking around the mall together in fairly good spirits.

Shun Anesaki
"Is there anything else you need to get, Sis?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm… Oh, right. Can I take a look at some clothes?"
Shun Anesaki
"Ugh…"

As expected, he looked less than thrilled.

Shun Anesaki
"Can I just wait somewhere while you look?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Nope. You're coming with me."

I forcibly tugged Shun along by the arm and stepped into my favorite women's clothing shop. It looked like they already had their new fall arrivals out.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ooh, this is adorable. …Right?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, this one's nice too. ...Right?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"This one's pretty too. ...Right?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, yeah, yeah."

Whatever I said, he answered with a vague "yeah."
I grabbed two tops that caught my attention and held them up in front of me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Which one do you think is better?"
Shun Anesaki
"Either one's fine."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Either one? …But if you had to pick, which one?"
Shun Anesaki
"Just go with whichever one you like better, Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki

"Hmm…"

If I'm being honest, I really don't trust my own fashion sense.
I've done my fair share of research into fashion, but I still have no idea what actually suits me or how I'm supposed to put outfits together.
So I usually just copy outfits I've seen in magazines.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, you decide."

In the end, I figured I was better off leaving it to Shun, who actually has a good eye for fashion.

Shun Anesaki
"I already told you, either one is fine."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then pick the one that suits me better."
Shun Anesaki
"Both suit you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Jeez… Take this seriously!"
???
"I think this one suits you better."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

A hand suddenly appeared from behind me and took one of the tops.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oshii-kun!"
Yu Oshii
"Hello, Senpai. Hi, Shun."
Shun Anesaki
"Hey."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You startled me. Are you shopping?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes. Are you two shopping too, Senpai?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes."
Shun Anesaki
"I'm only here because I got dragged along."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, because you're not exactly going along!"

I glared at Shun, giving him my most disapproving expression.
Then I felt Oshii-kun watching me with an amused look.
…Ah!

This is bad, really bad. I let my guard down.

Yu Oshii
"…I think this one looks better."

He held up the top he'd taken from me and repeated his words.
There was no longer any doubt in my mind.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Then I'll go with that one!"
Yu Oshii
"Huh…? Oh… Are you sure?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I am, I am."

I wasn't really capable of judging which was better. I figured it was best to go with what someone else thought looked good.
Shun watched me take the top from Oshii-kun, his impatience becoming increasingly obvious.
It looked like he wanted to say something.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, what's wrong?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"I'm just gonna say it straight!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"W-woah?!"
Shun Anesaki
"I… I think this one is better!!!"

Shun quickly seized a dress from the rack and shoved it in front of me.
Ohh, it actually is pretty cute.

Yu Oshii
"...It's too short."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? It's fine. Sis has pretty slim legs, so something this length would look best on her."
Yu Oshii
"…In that case, I'd recommend this one."

Oshii-kun pulled out another dress.
Hmm… this one is cute too.

Shun Anesaki
"Yours is a little too plain."
Yu Oshii

"…I think something a little more modest like this suits our elegant Senpai much better."
Shun Anesaki
"Elegant?"

Shun snorted. Oshii-kun's eyes narrowed slightly.
...Uh... Things suddenly felt a little tense... Weren't these two supposed to be friends…?

Shun Anesaki
"Anyway, this one suits Sis better."
Yu Oshii
"No, this one looks better."
Shun Anesaki
"Come on, just imagine it. Picture Sis wearing this dress."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Not bad, huh?"
Yu Oshii
"Yeah… but it's still a no. The design makes it hard to notice, but it's actually shorter than her school uniform."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh, really?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes, really. …I'd still recommend this one."
Shun Anesaki
"The color's too dark."
Yu Oshii
"Then let's take this one."

Oshii-kun pulled out yet another dress.

Shun Anesaki
"Ah… yeah, not bad. It's not bad, but… I still like the first one better."
Yu Oshii
"...Your motivations are... pretty obvious."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? You said you liked it too!"
Yu Oshii
"I said it was good. That doesn't mean I think she should wear it."
Shun Anesaki
"If it's good, why not?"
Yu Oshii
"*Sigh*… Fine. Let's ask Senpai. She can decide which one she wants."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

Caught off guard by the sudden question, I instinctively straightened up.

Yu Oshii
"Which one do you like better, this one or this one? "
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uhh…"

I glanced between the clothes Oshii-kun and Shun were holding.
To be honest, they were both cute. I would've been happy with either one, but…

Options:
(1) Shun's pick.
(2) Oshii-kun's pick.
(3) I can't choose.

Shun's pick.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…I guess this one."

I pointed to the dress Shun was holding.
It wasn't really a matter of personal preference. I was simply following my usual habit of leaving my fashion choices to Shun.

Shun Anesaki
"Hooray!"

Shun looked positively triumphant, while Oshii-kun beside him slumped his shoulders in disappointment.

Yu Oshii
"If that's what you want, Senpai, then I suppose there's nothing I can do…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's not that I don't like yours. It's cute too."
Shun Anesaki
"This one's definitely better."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But I agree that it's pretty short..."
Yu Oshii
"Right?"
Shun Anesaki
"You always walk around half-naked at home. What's the big deal?"
Yu Oshii
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't make me sound like some kind of exhibitionist."
Yu Oshii
"You walk around... half-naked...?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"I do not!"

I firmly denied it, then shot Shun a warning glare.
"Nozomi Anesaki" was supposed to be the picture of grace and modesty, so I couldn't have him telling everyone about my sloppy appearance at home.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'll go pay for it."
Yu Oshii
"Okay..."
Shun Anesaki
"Sure."

Oshii-kun reluctantly nodded, while Shun was practically beaming.
I honestly couldn't figure these two out. Are they friends or not?
(Go to the next chapter.)

Oshii-kun's pick.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Then I'll go with this one."

I pointed to the dress Oshii-kun was holding.
I usually let Shun pick out my clothes for me, so I figured it might be nice to try something different for a change.

Shun Anesaki
"Aww…"

Shun let out a dissatisfied groan. Meanwhile, Oshii-kun broke into a happy smile.

Yu Oshii
"Really?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. This one's cute."
Shun Anesaki
"But this one's nice too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's true. I like that one too."
Yu Oshii
"But mine suits you better, Senpai."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-you think so...?"

He said it so matter-of-factly that I felt a little embarrassed.

Nozomi Anesaki

"I'll go pay for it."
Yu Oshii
"Okay."
Shun Anesaki
"..."

I ignored Shun's sulky expression and headed for the register.
I honestly couldn't figure these two out. Are they friends or not?
(Go to the next chapter.)

I can't choose.

I'm hopelessly indecisive when it comes to things like this.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm… They're both so cute. I really can't choose."

The moment I said that, Shun and Oshii-kun exchanged glances once again.

Yu Oshii
"So, what do we do?"
Shun Anesaki
"I still say this one."
Yu Oshii
"I told you, that's not an option. You should actually try imagining it yourself. Picture Senpai wearing this."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"Well?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Awesome."
Yu Oshii
"You're unbelievable..."
Shun Anesaki
"…But, yeah… I get what you're saying."
Yu Oshii
"...Right?"
Shun Anesaki
"Fine. We'll go with yours. But let's get it in this color."
Yu Oshii
"Aah. I agree with that."

Apparently, the two of them had finally reached an agreement.
Shun and Oshii-kun held up the same dress together and turned to me at the same time.

Shun・Yu

"This one."
Nozomi Anesaki
"O-okay..."

What happened to all that tension between them earlier…?
I honestly couldn't figure these two out. Are they friends or not…?

Chapter 11: My dark past

After that, the three of us headed over to the food court.
Shun and Oshii-kun were constantly at odds with each other, yet they always seemed to find some middle ground in the end.
It was kind of refreshing to see Oshii-kun, who's usually so mature, acting his age and being a little childish for once.
The three of us together almost made me feel like I had two younger brothers.
We were sitting around chatting over some tea when a cheerful voice suddenly came from behind me.

???
"Oh?! Is that you, Shun?!"
???
"Oshii is with him, too!"
Shun・Yu
"Huh?"

When I looked over, I saw a group of boys and girls in flashy outfits approaching us.
…I didn't recognize any of them. Maybe they are Shun's classmates?
I suddenly felt a little self-conscious and instinctively straightened up.

Shun Anesaki
"Wait… Inoue? Mizoguchi? Kazuki too? Kawashima and Yasuda… What are you guys doing here?"
Girl
"Kyahaha. 'What are you guys doing here?' Really? That's the first thing you ask after seeing us?"
Boy
"Actually, what are you guys doing here? Since when were you two so close?"
Boy
"Shun and Oshii hanging out together? That's a pretty rare sight."
Girl
"Ooh, it's a date! It's a daaate! Kyahahaha. This is freaking hilarious!"

.....
How should I put this…
Why are so many of Shun's friends this loud and energetic…?
Ahh, right… They're all social butterflies.

Then again, the people I hang out with might actually be pretty similar. I'm kind of amazed I manage to keep up with them…
I happened to look over at Oshii-kun, and our eyes met.

Yu Oshii
"..."

He responded with a somewhat weary smile.
I wasn't sure why… but I felt myself relax a little.
Apparently, one of the people in the group had noticed our little exchange of glances and was now eyeing me curiously.
I immediately grew even more self-conscious.
Do I look okay? Is everything in place? I really need a mirror.

Boy
"Is that Oshii's giiirlfriend???"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Girl
"Kyaa! Really?!"
Boy
"She's reaaaally pretty."

...Phew.
Wait, no.

Yu Oshii
"...We're not dating."

Oshii-kun answered for me, denying it outright.

Boy
"In that case..."

Everyone's eyes turned toward Shun.
He sat there with his usual grumpy expression, loudly sipping his cola.

Everyone
"She is Shun's—"
Shun Anesaki
"She's my older sister."

Shun cut them off before they could finish.
For a brief moment, an awkward silence hung in the air.

Boy
"...Huh? Really?"
Boy

"Uhh...?"

Another awkward pause followed.
What is this strange atmosphere…?
Huh...?
Come to think of it… why do these people not know that I'm Shun's older sister?
I thought it was common knowledge at our high school by now…
.....
No way... Are they from—?

Boy
"...Do you have two older sisters?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Huuh?"
Boy
"Because, like… if I remember right, Shun's sister..."
Boy
"She looked pretty lame, didn't she...?"

One of the girls discreetly leaned over to whisper something to the person beside her.
She was considerate enough to keep her voice low, but her words still reached my ears perfectly clearly.

Girl
"Ahhh!!! I remember her too!!! Shun's sister who looks nothing like him, right?!"
Boy
"They're not related by blood, are they?"
Girl
"Wasn't she, like, an otaku shut-in?! Oh my god, that's hilarious!!!"

Their laughter rang in my ears.
I lowered my head and silently clenched my fists in my lap.
It wasn't because I was upset.
I remembered my own embarrassing past better than anyone, and I'd already heard plenty of cruel, insulting comments like these back then. By now, I was used to it.
If anything, I could probably agree with everything they were saying.
I really was pretty gross back then. Even I couldn't come up with anything to defend myself with. ...And, well, I hadn't really changed much on the inside since then.
…Anyway, I wasn't particularly angry or sad about what they were saying now.
Despite that, I still couldn't bring myself to look up.
…Because I was terrified of seeing Shun's face.
So, once again, my eyes instinctively wandered toward Oshii-kun.

Yu Oshii
"..."

This time, our eyes didn't meet.
Just like me, Oshii-kun sat there with his fists clenched, staring down at the table.

I was a little surprised.
Why did Oshii-kun look so frustrated…?

Boy
"All right, then! Let's all hang out again sometime, like we used to in middle school."
Boy
"Hit us up sometime every now and then!"
Girl
"Bye-bye!"

Before I knew it, the conversation was over.
The moment the flashy group left, an uncomfortable silence settled over the table.
Not a single person spoke.
I was still too afraid to look at Shun, but I couldn't bear looking at Oshii-kun's pained expression either.
So, keeping my eyes fixed somewhere off to the side, I broke the silence with an awkward little laugh.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wooow, they were a lively bunch."
Shun･Yu
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um… we're done eating, so… should we get going?"
Shun･Yu
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey!"

I smacked the table.

Shun Anesaki
"Huh…? Oh, yeah."
Yu Oshii
"...That's right."

At last, the moment seemed to pass, and things started moving again.
We left the food court, and then parted ways with Oshii-kun at the shopping mall entrance.
On the way home, Shun was unusually quiet.
The most likely reason was the conversation he'd just had with his old middle school classmates.
…I wonder how he felt listening to all that.
Perhaps…
He was embarrassed…?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun."
Shun Anesaki

"...Hm?"

Shun, who was a few steps ahead of me, glanced back.
He had his usual grumpy look on his face, and seeing it reassured me a little.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't worry."
Shun Anesaki
"…Huh? What do you mean…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I bought some face masks today, and that toner everyone seems to love."

I always thought foundation was a little too much for a high schooler, but I figured I should start thinking ahead, so I decided to get it.
I even bought mascara that's supposed to make your eyes look bigger.

Nozomi Anesaki
"And I bought some new clothes, too."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm going to become even prettier!!! Before long, my beauty will have surpassed the galaxy itself and become literally immeasurable!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"..."

He gave me a completely unimpressed look.
…Yeah, yeah. I know what you're thinking: "Okay, narcissist."
Whatever. I don't care. If I'm pretty enough to be a narcissist, then I'd say that's a pretty good problem to have.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I won't cause you trouble ever again, so don't worry."

I repeated what I'd said before.
Shun just frowned and said nothing.
Lately, I'd been noticing that expression on his face more and more.
It was clear that he had some sort of grievance with me.
But Shun never actually said anything.
So I was still left wondering what was going through his head.

Chapter 12: Turning point

I woke up today without any problems, just like usual.
After going through my usual morning routine and dragging Shun out of bed, I returned to my room and found myself peering into the mirror again.
Hmm... My eyes still don't really pop... Perhaps a little more eyeliner would do the trick.

I traced another line along the edges of my eyes.
There. Much better.
Satisfied, I headed for the front door, where I found that Shun had apparently finished getting ready for school too.
He looked as sleepy as ever, his uniform just as disheveled.
And yet, somehow, none of that really detracts from him. I guess that's what happens when you're naturally blessed in the looks department.
Seriously, I'm jealous. Actually... "jealous" might be putting it mildly. I'm downright bitter.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Fix your tie."
Shun Anesaki
"...Yeah, yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Have you got everything?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Am I cute?"

I went through the usual line, just for the sake of it.
At this point, I wasn't expecting a proper answer anymore, but surprisingly, Shun stared intently at my face and said:

Shun Anesaki
"...Isn't your makeup a little heavy?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

Shun stepped right up in front of me.
With him staring at me from such close range, I suddenly felt incredibly self-conscious.

Shun Anesaki
"...Yeah. It's definitely too heavy. Around the eyes."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-you think so?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I kind of thought I looked better like this... Is it not good...?"
Shun Anesaki
"No... I wouldn't say it's no good. I guess I like you better the way you normally look."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

"I like you."

Nozomi Anesaki

"Waaaaaaah!!!"

I let out a shriek and impulsively raised my hand.

Shun Anesaki
"Whoa?!"

Shun swiftly ducked out of the way. Apparently, at some point, his Evasion stat had gone up.

Shun Anesaki
"That was close... Why'd you suddenly do that?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Because you suddenly started saying weird things...!"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh...? What did I even say?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Actually, now that I think about it, I guess it wasn't really that weird."
Shun Anesaki
"...Ah. Okay."
Nozomi Anesaki
"So... is my eye makeup really that bad?"
Shun Anesaki
"Well, I guess it's fine."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's such a half-hearted answer."
Shun Anesaki
"No, I mean, it doesn't look weird or anything. If you think it looks good, then that's what matters most, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I don't like the way you phrased that."
Shun Anesaki
"? Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I—"

I almost said, "I want you to say it's good." But I immediately swallowed the words.
The more I thought about it, the more I realized how inappropriate that would have been…
It might have been acceptable with a love interest in an otome game, but certainly not with my younger brother.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Never mind. Let's go to school."
Shun Anesaki
"...? Okay."

When we stepped outside, the sky was overcast. A warm, humid breeze swept past us.

Shun Anesaki
"...Achoo."

Then Shun let out a small sneeze. A moment later, I heard him sniffle.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Did you catch a cold?"
Shun Anesaki
"Hmm... I dunno."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Could it be because you've been sleeping with the AC on?"
Shun Anesaki
"That might be it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Jeez... You need to take better care of yourself. And don't pass it on to me."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, yeah."

I heard him sniffle again.
His voice sounded a little nasal, too. Maybe he really was starting to come down with a cold.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Take some medicine and get to bed early tonight, okay?"
Shun Anesaki
"But what about studying?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Do you want to study?"
Shun Anesaki
"Well... not particularly."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...If you're feeling well enough, we can do some studying."
Shun Anesaki
"...Okay."

Lately, it has become a regular habit for Shun and me to study together before bed.
So far, he has been taking his studies seriously, and I have actually come to enjoy our study sessions quite a bit myself.

Shun Anesaki
"...What about Yu?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? What about him?"
Shun Anesaki
"Are you studying with him again today?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No? We didn't really make plans."
Shun Anesaki

"Ohh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Is something bothering you?"
Shun Anesaki
"...No, not really."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Do you and Oshii-kun not get along?"

I asked about something I'd been wondering about for a while.
From the way they'd acted at the shopping mall the other day, I didn't get the impression that the two of them were exactly close.

Shun Anesaki
"Huh? No... I mean, I don't think so."
Nozomi Anesaki
" 'I don't think so'? That's a strange way to put it. It's your relationship we're talking about."
Shun Anesaki
"Well, it's complicated."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm..."

It seems that Shun and Oshii-kun have known each other for quite some time, so surely there were all kinds of things going on between them that I knew nothing about.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...You and Oshii-kun..."
Shun Anesaki
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"How long have you two known each other?"

I decided to ask about one more thing that had been on my mind.
Ever since I met Shun's friends from middle school, I hadn't been able to stop thinking about it.
Oshii-kun didn't join in on their conversation that time, but from what they were talking about, I could tell that they all knew each other.

Shun Anesaki
"...Probably since around fifth or sixth grade."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ohh.. You really have known each other for a long time."
Shun Anesaki
"True."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Back in middle school..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki

"...Were you ever in the same class as Oshii-kun?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Yeah."

A few seconds passed before Shun finally answered.
After a moment's hesitation, I decided to ask the question that had been weighing on me the most.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Does he... know about my past?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Who knows…? I have no idea."

Shun shook his head, then immediately followed up in a light-hearted tone:

Shun Anesaki
"It's not worth worrying about."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Shun Anesaki
"Does it really matter whether he knows about your past or not?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It matters quite a lot, actually."
Shun Anesaki
"Why? Why do you care so much about his opinion?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? It's not just about Oshii-kun... And anyway, why are you getting so mad?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."

There he goes with his sulky face again. Your sister doesn't understand you anymore, Shun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Fine, fine. I won't worry about anything anymore."
Shun Anesaki
"You clearly don't get it at all..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"If you want me to understand, then explain everything to me in detail so I can."
Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun fell silent.
Then he took a deep breath, as if he'd made up his mind about something.

Shun Anesaki
"Fine."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What's fine?"
Shun Anesaki
"...I'll tell you everything."

Shun stopped walking.
I stopped with him, and he looked me straight in the eye.
There was an incredible intensity in his gaze. What on earth is he about to tell me...?

Shun Anesaki
"I—!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Woah?!"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."

.....
He didn't say anything.
He opened his mouth, then closed it again.
After repeating this indecisive motion several times, Shun finally turned his whole body away.

Shun Anesaki
"...Never mind."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huuuh? After dragging it out this long, that's all you have to say?"
Shun Anesaki
"The timing's just too awkward. ...I'll tell you when we get home after school."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...All right..."

It must be pretty important if he was making such a big deal out of it.
What could it be...? I just hope it wasn't anything bad.

Male student
"Shuuun! Miiiss! Good morning!"

We ran into Shun's group of friends in front of the school gate again.

My eyes met Oshii-kun's.
We parted ways on an awkward note yesterday, and I couldn't help but feel a little on edge.

Yu Oshii
"Good morning, Senpai."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Morning..."
Yu Oshii
"The weather doesn't look very good today."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Oh, true, it doesn't. I didn't bring an umbrella, though. I wonder if I'll be okay."
Yu Oshii
"I hear there's a 30% chance of rain. But hopefully, it stays dry."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, hopefully."

Talking about such mundane things gradually put me at ease.
I still had plenty of worries and questions, but maybe, as Shun said, I shouldn't dwell on them too much.
Oshii-kun was still treating me well.

Nozomi Anesaki
"All right, see you guys later."
All the boys
"Goodbye!"
Shun Anesaki
"See ya."

I waved goodbye to Shun and the others and made my way to my shoe locker.
As I was taking off my shoes...

Yu Oshii
"Senpai."

Oshii-kun's voice called out from behind me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oshii-kun...?"

I was surprised. I assumed he'd gone off with the others.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What's the matter?"
Yu Oshii
"Well... Um, do you have anything planned after school today?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, not really."
Yu Oshii

"Then, uh... could I have some of your time again?"

Was it about studying? I immediately nodded.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, that's all right."
Yu Oshii
"Thank you very much. ...See you after school."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, see you."

I watched Oshii-kun leave.

Common route

Shun Anesaki
"Are you studying with him again today?"

I wonder what this is about. Is there some reason Shun doesn't want me studying with Oshii-kun?
Shun said he doesn't have anything against Oshii-kun, but...
Could it be that Shun sees him as a rival?
...Yeah, I suppose that's possible.
Oshii-kun is smart. He's at the top of his class, too. Maybe Shun is jealous of that.
If so… that would explain why Shun's been so diligently studying lately.
Still, even if that were true, it has nothing to do with me.
As far as I'm concerned, Oshii-kun is just a perfectly nice junior. I'm not taking sides between them.
(Go to the next chapter.)

Another

Then, as if replacing him, Shun showed up from the other direction.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, what happened? I thought you went ahead."
Shun Anesaki
"No... Were you talking with Yu?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Oh, yeah. We were talking about studying together again after school today."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? Again?"

Shun visibly grimaced.
I wonder what this is about. Is there some reason Shun doesn't want me studying with Oshii-kun?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Is that a problem?"
Shun Anesaki
"No... It's fine, but..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But?"
Shun Anesaki
"...I'm joining you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Shun Anesaki
"I'll study with you guys after school. ...That's okay, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's fine, but… why?"

I know he hates studying.

Shun Anesaki
"...I don't want to lose to Yu."

Shun muttered the words so quietly that I could barely make them out.
...I see. Oshii-kun is smart, and he is at the top of his class. Shun must have been jealous of that.
Maybe the reason things seem a little awkward between them is that Shun sees Oshii-kun as a rival.
For some reason, that thought made me smile, and I nodded enthusiastically.

Nozomi Anesaki
"All right. Then meet us in the library study room after school."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."

Normal end: The brother I'm proud of

Chapter title's is "Study session"

And then came the after-school study session.
Shun and Oshii-kun arrived at the library together, looking like good friends.

Shun・Yu
"..."

...I take that back. "Looking like good friends" might be a bit misleading.
Both Shun and Oshii-kun had a somewhat hostile air about them.
I thought Shun was the only one who saw Oshii-kun as a rival, but apparently Oshii-kun saw Shun as one too.
There is nothing wrong with healthy competition, but I wish they wouldn't make things so uncomfortable.
I put on a fake cheerful voice in an attempt to lighten the mood.

Nozomi Anesaki
"All right, let's get started!"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."
Yu Oshii
"Let's have a good study session."

The two of them sat down across from me.
Oshii-kun immediately opened up his workbook.

Yu Oshii
"Um, about this problem..."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh?"

Shun glanced over at Oshii-kun's workbook and widened his eyes in surprise.

Shun Anesaki
"We haven't even covered that yet, have we?"
Yu Oshii
"Not yet."
Shun Anesaki
"Are you studying ahead?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes."
Shun Anesaki
"Wow..."

Shun looked genuinely impressed. Then he flipped through his own notebook and his shoulders slumped.
It was probably still too early for Shun to be studying ahead... He was already struggling with material they covered quite a while ago.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Is there anything you need help with, Shun?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh…? Oh, uh... I'm... gonna study by myself for a while..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay. If there's anything you don't understand, just ask me."
Shun Anesaki

"...Yeah."

Shun looked more serious than I'd ever seen him and started working quietly in his notebook.
I kept him in the corner of my eye for a moment, then turned back to Oshii-kun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... where were we again?"
Yu Oshii
"Right here. Once you use this formula..."
.....
.....
.....

Nozomi Anesaki
"...and that's pretty much it."
Yu Oshii
"Ohh, I get it now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Does that make sense?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes. Thank you very much."

After writing the answer in his notebook, Oshii-kun tilted his head, looking a little worn out.
I glanced at the clock and realized that an hour and a half had already passed since we started studying.
Whenever I study with Oshii-kun, I tend to get so focused that I lose track of time.
...Come to think of it, Shun has been awfully quiet for a while.
I checked on Shun for the first time since the study session had started.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun was still diligently working on his notes.
That was surprising. Normally, he loses focus after half an hour and starts slacking off.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun."

I called his name.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

...Huh? He's not answering. Don't tell me...

Yu Oshii
"He's asleep."

Oshii-kun peered into Shun's face with an incredulous look.

Yu Oshii
"And he's still sitting perfectly upright..."

Shun had his eyes closed, somehow still holding his pen upright against the notebook.
I bet he falls asleep like this in class all the time...
It really is no wonder his grades are so bad. He's good at practically everything, but when it comes to studying, he's just hopeless...

Yu Oshii
"Senpai, what should we do?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm... There are thirty minutes left until school lets out… Maybe we should stop here for today?"
Yu Oshii
"I agree. Should we wake Shun up?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Ah, hold on."

Shun was fast asleep, his eyes tightly shut.
He looked so peaceful... His sleeping face was so innocent, nothing like his usual cheeky self...
The longer I watched him, the more I felt a mischievous urge stirring inside me.
I made sure not to make a sound as I slowly took a marker out of my pencil case.

Yu Oshii
"S-Senpai... don't tell me..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Shh..."

I held a finger to my lips and slowly crept toward Shun.

Yu Oshii
"...Are you sure? Won't Shun get mad...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's water-based, so it'll wash right off."
Yu Oshii
"I-I see..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Want to try it too, Oshii-kun?"
Yu Oshii
"Uh..."

He hesitated, but his eyes were practically sparkling with excitement.
Oshii-kun took a marker from his own pencil case and quietly edged closer to Shun.

Yu Oshii
"What should we draw?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I want to draw eyes on his eyelids."
Yu Oshii
"It's more difficult than writing '肉'* on his forehead..."
*lit. "meat", it's a japanese pop-culture joke referencing Kinnikuman's protagonist.
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'll draw the left eye. You handle the right one."
Yu Oshii
"Uh... I'm bad at this sort of thing... I wonder if I can make it look right."

Oshii-kun's expression turned serious. Wow... he's really getting into this.

Yu Oshii
"Actually, since he's looking down, it's a little hard to draw..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"True... Do you think we can tilt his head back?"
Yu Oshii
"Carefully..."

Cautiously, I tilted Shun's face upward.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun was still breathing softly in his sleep.

Yu Oshii
"...He isn't waking up."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Perfect. Let's do it while we can..."

I placed the tip of the marker against his eyelid. Shun's eye twitched slightly.

Yu Oshii
"Ah... shoot, I went over the edge."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Mine's all wobbly too..."
Yu Oshii
"This is... harder than it seems."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Let's start with the pupils..."
Yu Oshii
"Don't forget the eyelashes..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Pfft... Oshii-kun, yours is quite something..."
Yu Oshii

"Yours isn't half bad either, Senpai..."

.....
.....
.....

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Heh... hahahaha."
Yu Oshii
"This is... hah... pfft..."

We both suppressed our laughter. Turns out, even a guy like Shun can be rendered completely unhandsome with a few minor adjustments.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait, Oshii-kun... isn't your marker permanent...?"
Yu Oshii
"Uh..."
Yu・Nozomi
"..."
Yu Oshii
"Ah...!"

Oshii-kun let out a faint cry and quickly rubbed Shun's eyelid.
The ink wasn't completely dry yet, so it smeared and faded a little, but...

Nozomi Anesaki
"O-Oshii-kun... you're rubbing it way too hard..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Mm..."

Shun's eyes snapped open.
...Just as I thought.

Shun Anesaki
"...Huh?! W-woah, what the… My eye—"
Yu Oshii
"Ah, sorry, I rubbed it too hard. Is your eye all right?"
Shun Anesaki
"W-wait, hold on... What are you doing?"

Oshii-kun and I quickly hid the markers behind our backs before the confused Shun.
Apparently, Shun caught on right away. He jumped to his feet and looked at his reflection in the window.

Shun Anesaki
"AAAGH!!! Are you kidding me!? What the heck did you do?!"
Nozomi Anesaki

"S-sorry... You were sleeping so peacefully, I couldn't resist."
Shun Anesaki
"...I was sleeping? Wait, what time is it?!"

Shun jerked his head up and looked at the clock.
Then he lowered his gaze to his notebook, looking utterly devastated.

Shun Anesaki
"No way... I only finished three questions..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? When did you fall asleep?"
Shun Anesaki
"...About an hour ago... I think...?"

...Yep. Looks like his attention span really is only about thirty minutes.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Let's call it a day and head home."
Shun Anesaki
"You're kidding..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"We can finish the rest tonight."
Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun reluctantly began packing up his things. Beside him, Oshii-kun gave a sheepish little smile.

Yu Oshii
"Maybe you should wash your face first..."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? Ah, right. Damn it... This is water-based, isn't it...?"
Yu Oshii
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Heey! Just you wait!!!"

Shun threw out a weak little threat and stomped out of the library.
As we watched him go, Oshii-kun and I giggled together.
For all their bickering, it didn't seem like Shun and Oshii-kun actually hated each other. I was relieved.

We parted ways with Oshii-kun at the school gate, and Shun and I headed home side by side.
Shun was still sulking, his lips pressed into a tight line.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, I'm sorry, okay?"

Shun Anesaki
"...There's still a faint mark from where you used the permanent ink."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-it's fine, it's fine. You can barely tell unless you look closely."
Shun Anesaki
"Jeez... you turned my face into your drawing board..."

He muttered under his breath and fell silent.
He didn't really look angry so much as disappointed, and I started to feel a little bad.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry... Were you really that upset about it?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? Ah, no... I don't care about that anymore..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"...I barely got any studying done."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

Is that it?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Were you actually that serious about studying?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm... So you're really trying to keep up with Oshii-kun?"
Shun Anesaki
"Uh... w-well... He's pretty amazing, studying ahead and all..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're still struggling with middle-school material, though..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun faltered, then lowered his head awkwardly. Apparently, he was well aware of that.

Nozomi Anesaki
"But still... Oshii-kun is Oshii-kun, and you're you. You should just take things at your own pace."
Shun Anesaki
"If I take it easy, I'll never catch up... I don't understand half the stuff you and Yu talk about when you're studying."
Nozomi Anesaki
"If you keep at it little by little, you'll get there eventually."
Shun Anesaki
"Little by little..."

Shun let out a weary sigh.
For someone who can accomplish most things through sheer innate ability, there probably isn't anything more frustrating than having to put in effort.

Nozomi Anesaki
"It's okay, you don't have to push yourself that hard."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Obviously, you shouldn't fail your classes, but you don't need to work yourself to the bone just to compete with Oshii-kun."
Shun Anesaki
"...Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Because you're good at so many other things, Shun."

He's exceptionally athletic, and he's got an eye for art, too. If he were smart on top of that, it'd honestly be cheating.

Shun Anesaki
"But... I want to get good grades too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Why?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Because you get good grades, Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Me?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What's that supposed to mean?"

He wants to get good grades just because I do? It's almost like he's worried about what people think of me.
That's strange. That doesn't sound like Shun at all.
...Oh, but now that I think about it.

Male student
"Much as I hate to say it, you two actually look really good together."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?!"
Male student
"Well, Yu's a top student, too. Damn, I'm jealous."
Male student
"Compared to him..."
Shun Anesaki
"...What?"

Male student
"I seriously can't believe you're her brother."
Shun Anesaki
"...Huuh?"
Male student
"Look at that attitude! And this guy is the younger brother of an angel like her?"
Male student
"Who knew siblings could be this different?"

I remember Shun looking really uncomfortable during that conversation.
I wonder if he's been thinking about what was said about him that day ever since.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun."

I tried to sound encouraging.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You don't need to worry about how other people see you."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"People at school think I'm this perfect, capable girl who can do no wrong, but I know you're way more impressive than me, Shun."

To be honest...

Nozomi Anesaki
"I mean, I'm proud to have you as my brother..."

I got a little embarrassed, and my voice softened toward the end.

Shun Anesaki
"...Huh... whaa...?"

A faint blush spread across Shun's cheeks as well. Uh-oh… Maybe I encouraged him a little too much?

Shun Anesaki
"W-wait, what are you saying all of a sudden?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? I mean... you looked really depressed…"
Shun Anesaki
"I-I wasn't depressed or anything...! And, uh—what were we talking about again?! Jeez...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Good question. What were we talking about...?"
Shun Anesaki
"I don't even know anymore. You said something so embarrassing, I completely lost track."

Nozomi Anesaki
"W-well, anyway... My point is, don't let your grades get you down. You're good at so many other things."
Shun Anesaki
"Enough!!! S-stop it already! Seriously... this is so embarrassing...!"

Shun was practically fuming, his face bright red with embarrassment.
Then he marched ahead in huge strides, apparently determined to put the whole awkward situation behind him.

Shun Anesaki
"Okay, that's it! Let's just get home already!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sure."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Why'd you suddenly go quiet? Say something."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Uh... hmm... ah, right. Shun, didn't you have something you wanted to tell me?"
Shun Anesaki
"Uh... A-ah, yeah... Th-that..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. You can tell me now."
Shun Anesaki
"N-no...! Never mind, never mind. Forget it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What? Wasn't it something important?"
Shun Anesaki
"Not really... Don't worry about it... I'll tell you another time."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm?"
Shun Anesaki
"...What else can we talk about?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm, what else... Oh, we can talk about Lord Wald!"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What is with that face? You don't want to hear about him?"
Shun Anesaki
"No... It's fine. Go ahead. I'll listen to it as much as you want."
Shun Anesaki
"I'm the only one you can talk about this sort of stuff, after all."

Shun gave a resigned shrug, but his voice was gentle and warm.

He really is my pride and joy as a little brother.
He'd grown so much since the day we first met. As I watched him walk ahead of me, I quietly whispered, "Thank you."

Chapter 13: Déjà vu

And then came the after-school study session.
When I made my way to the library, I found it completely deserted. Oshii-kun wasn't there yet.
I took my usual seat in the back and laid out my study materials on the desk.
A moment later, I heard the door open.
Soft footsteps drew closer, and Oshii-kun appeared from behind the bookshelves.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oshii-kun."
Yu Oshii
"Ah, Senpai. Sorry, did I keep you waiting?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I haven't been waiting long."

I shook my head, then noticed something near Oshii-kun's right knee.
There was some kind of dark stain on it. ...Wait, is that blood?

Nozomi Anesaki
"What happened to you?"
Yu Oshii
"Huh? …Ah, this."

Oshii-kun glanced down at his right leg and smiled sheepishly.

Yu Oshii
"We had P.E. outside during sixth period. ...I got a little hurt."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, I see."
Yu Oshii
"I went to the nurse's office earlier, but the nurse wasn't there, so I just came back. That's why I'm a little late... Sorry."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't mention it... But are you sure you're okay?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes. It's just a scrape."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Can I take a look? Sit down over there."
Yu Oshii
"...Huh? Aah..."

Oshii-kun sat down in the chair.

I crouched down in front of him and rolled up his pant leg.
The wound on his knee was still fresh, with blood seeping from it. There was even sand stuck to it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You really just left it like that? You should at least wash it."
Yu Oshii
"I couldn't really be bothered."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're surprisingly carefree... Or maybe just kind of careless?"
Yu Oshii
"Haha... Maybe."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Just wait here for a moment."

I left the library and wet my handkerchief at the sink in the hallway.
Suddenly, I was struck by a strange sense of déjà vu.
What was it? Something like this had happened before.
Puzzled, I tilted my head and returned to the library.
I sat down in front of Oshii-kun again and pressed the damp handkerchief against the injured area.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry if this hurts."
Yu Oshii
"No, I'm fine."

I gently moved the handkerchief back and forth, washing the wound.
The strange feeling of déjà vu only grew stronger as I did.
It wasn't my imagination... I'd definitely been in this situation before.
But when...?
As I rummaged through my memories, I became aware of an intense gaze fixed on me.
I looked up and immediately froze.
Oshii-kun was looking at me with such tenderness.
And yet there was an aching sadness beneath it, a sadness so palpable that it almost made my chest tighten just looking at him.
I hurriedly turned my face away. At the same moment, warning bells began ringing in the back of my mind.
This was strange.
The expression he'd just given me didn't seem like simple "gratitude" or "admiration" toward a senior.
It was clearly the expression of someone looking at a person they held some kind of special affection for.
No way... Could Oshii-kun...?
Was Shun actually right...?
Does Oshii-kun actually like me...?

Yu Oshii

"Senpai? Is something wrong?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...It's nothing."

I didn't even realize I'd stopped moving my hand.
I quickly finished cleaning the wound, then took a Band-Aid from my bag and put it over the injury.

Nozomi Anesaki
"There, all done."

I kept my expression calm as I put some distance between myself and Oshii-kun.

Yu Oshii
"Thank you very much."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're welcome. ...Well, shall we study?"

I quickly returned to my seat.
Oshii-kun sat back down across from me and began getting his study materials ready.
I stole a quick glance at his face.
...Normal. He looked just like his usual self.
Maybe I just misread the expression on his face earlier.
Could it be that I was just letting my otome-game filter get the better of me...?

Yu Oshii
"Could you help me with this question today?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? Oh... this one. I see. Even you couldn't figure it out."
Yu Oshii
"? Senpai, have you seen this question before?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I've been helping Shun with his studies lately. We actually went over this exact problem just the other day."
Yu Oshii
"Wait... Shun's been studying?"

Oshii-kun's surprised reaction made me chuckle. Apparently, everyone knows Shun as the guy who can't stand studying.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun's actually been studying pretty hard lately."
Yu Oshii
"Ohh...? Did something happen?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"This is just my guess, but... I think it's because he doesn't want to lose to you."
Yu Oshii
"Huh? Me?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. That's just my guess, though. I think he's probably jealous of how well you do in school."
Yu Oshii
"No way."

Oshii-kun gave a sardonic smile.

Yu Oshii
"I don't see how Shun could possibly envy me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh...? Really?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes. I mean, it's Shun we're talking about."
Yu Oshii
"People may envy him, but I don't think it would ever be the other way around."

There was a slight edge to Oshii-kun's words.
Could it be... that Oshii-kun feels some kind of rivalry toward Shun, too?

Yu Oshii
"I... envy Shun."

He murmured it in a low voice.
There was something heavy in the way he said it, as though his words carried a deeper meaning.

Yu Oshii
"Unlike me, he's good at sports."
Yu Oshii
"He's a quick learner, naturally talented, and can make anything look effortless."
Yu Oshii
"Ever since elementary school, he's always been the center of attention, surrounded by people in his class."
Yu Oshii
"He's popular. Everything he does draws people's attention. He doesn't even have to do anything for people to follow him."
Yu Oshii
"He's got everything anyone could ever ask for."

The more Oshii-kun spoke, the more emotion crept into his voice.
Part of me was surprised, while another part related to what he said.
After all, I'd had the very same thought countless times. That I envied Shun.

Yu Oshii
"My grades are nothing compared to that. They're practically worthless. That's something you can overcome with enough effort."
Yu Oshii

"Shun's proof of that, isn't he? He can do it if he puts his mind to it. He barely studied at all, yet he got into this school without breaking a sweat..."
Yu Oshii
"Seriously… how does someone like him even exist...?"

A dry laugh echoed through the quiet library.
When I fell silent, unsure how to respond, Oshii-kun gave an awkward laugh, as if trying to play things off.

Yu Oshii
"I'm sorry... That was pretty pathetic of me..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no... It's not true. I... I understand what you're saying..."
Yu Oshii
"...Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I... I envy Shun, too. He's good at everything, he's popular... He's the complete opposite of me."
Yu Oshii
"...What are you talking about? Anesaki-senpai, you're just like that too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I'm really not... I'm nothing like that."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oshii-kun... You know what I used to be like, right?"
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"...I know."

Ah, I knew it.
That strange sense of déjà vu I'd felt earlier... I couldn't remember the details, but I was sure I'd met Oshii-kun before.

Yu Oshii
"Senpai... it seems you don't remember me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I'm sorry. I feel like I'm so close to remembering, but I just can't..."
Yu Oshii
"...The first time I met you was when I was in my first year of middle school, and you were in your second."

Second year of middle school... That was right in the middle of my dark past.
As I silently cringed at the memory, Oshii-kun slowly began to tell me the rest of the story.

Chapter 14: Our first meeting

When I was in my first year of middle school, Shun and I were in the same class.
There were always people gathered around him, but I never joined them.
It wasn't that we didn't get along.
But it wasn't like we were particularly close, either. We were just ordinary classmates.
It had been that way ever since I first met Shun in elementary school.
Back then, I didn't have any strong feelings toward him.
Well… I suppose there were times when I envied him a little.
But he was someone from a completely different world than mine, after all.
To be perfectly honest, I didn't care what kind of person Shun was or what he did.
It had nothing to do with me.
But after we entered middle school, my mother suddenly started taking a strange interest in Shun.
"Get better grades than Shun." "Outshine Shun." "Beat Shun at something, anything."
She kept saying things like that to me over and over.
At first, I figured she was just using me to compete with Shun so she could satisfy her own pride, so I didn't pay much attention to it.
But when that went on for long enough, I couldn't help but start paying attention to Shun.
So I worked hard at my studies.
It was the only thing I had any chance of beating Shun at. Sports, music, art and even popularity.
In every area, Shun was blessed with talents that were completely beyond my reach.
Little by little, I began to develop an inferiority complex toward him.
It was probably unfair to Shun, but I just couldn't stop envying him.
It happened during the second term.
At the school sports festival, I was selected as one of the four runners for our class relay.
I was the third runner.
That meant I would receive the baton from Shun.
To cut to the result, our class came in last.
Everything went smoothly at first.
We got off to a fairly good start, and eventually the baton reached Shun.
Naturally, Shun ran exactly as well as everyone expected.
He overtook the runners in front of him one after another, taking the lead with ease.
When he passed the baton to me, we had already built up a comfortable lead over second place.
I was running the corner, and nobody was expecting anything special from me.
Shun had already put us in a winning position, so all I had to do was run normally.
And yet, I couldn't even manage something that simple.
I slipped on the turn and fell.
I scraped my knee badly, and the pain was so intense that I couldn't get back on my feet right away.
By the time I finally managed to stand, everyone had already passed me.
I couldn't make up the lost ground after that, and my class ended up finishing dead last.
When I returned to the stands, I was met with accusing stares from everyone in my class.
"We had first place." "Shun worked so hard for us." "You ruined everything Shun did." "Go apologize to Shun."

Shun. Shun. Shun…
That was all anyone could talk about.
I was sick of it.
I left the stands and went to the nurse's office.
Nobody cared about my injury, not even the first-aid students, so I had no choice but to take care of it myself.
The nurse's office was empty during the sports festival.
I couldn't be bothered to go looking for a teacher, so I gave up on treating my injury and went back outside.
That said, I didn't have it in me to return to the stands, so I wandered around aimlessly for a while.

???
"Hey…"

I heard a voice behind me.
It was a girl one year older.
…That was how I met you, Anesaki-senpai.

Yu Oshii
"...Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"...Can I help you...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Um… your knee…"
Yu Oshii
"Huh? Aah..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"The teacher is over at the tent..."
Yu Oshii
"...Oh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Aren't you going to treat it?"
Yu Oshii
"Uh... no… I mean, it's not really that serious…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Really…? You've scraped it pretty badly… It's bleeding quite a lot, too."
Yu Oshii
"Is it…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. …Come over here for a second."
Yu Oshii

"...Oh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"For now… rinse your leg off here."
Yu Oshii
"...Okay."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…You don't have a towel or a handkerchief or anything?"
Yu Oshii
"No, I don't."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Then… you can use mine, if that's okay…?"
Yu Oshii
"Huh…? I mean, if you don't mind…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Hold out your leg."
Yu Oshii
"Okay..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Does it hurt?"
Yu Oshii
"No."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Keep the handkerchief pressed against the wound so it stays moist, and have the first-aid staff at the tent finish treating it."
Yu Oshii
"Uh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I… don't have any bandages or anything with me right now."
Yu Oshii
"Oh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well, then…"
Yu Oshii
"Uh, wait… what am I supposed to do with your handkerchief…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Oh, you can just keep it. You don't have to give it back."
Yu Oshii
"Huh...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…See you."
Yu Oshii
"Yes… thanks..."

Yu Oshii
"That was it. That was the only time I ever spoke to you in middle school."
Yu Oshii
"After that, I didn't see you again until we started high school."
Nozomi Anesaki

"..."
Yu Oshii
"...You really don't remember?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...No."

…I remember now. Yes, that really did happen.
That day, I watched the relay from my class's stands.
I remember Shun taking the lead, too. …And I remember the student who fell afterward.
I suppose I spoke to Oshii-kun on nothing more than a whim.
After the relay was over, I happened to look in his direction and saw him there.
I couldn't just ignore him wandering around with blood running down his leg, so I called out to him.

Yu Oshii
"…I suppose that was when I first became curious about you."
Yu Oshii
"You were pretty blunt in the way you spoke, but your touch was unexpectedly gentle. I think that's why you stuck with me."
Yu Oshii
"At the time, I didn't know that Shun had an older sister."
Yu Oshii
"So it never even occurred to me… that that's who you were…"
Yu Oshii
"…But I learned the truth later that very day."
Yu Oshii
"I imagine you remember that as well…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Yes."

I remember what happened that day. I remember it clearly, like it happened just yesterday.
It's one of the most painful memories from my dark past.

Chapter 15: A bitter memory

It happened during the lunch break at that sports festival.
My parents had asked me to bring Shun his lunch box.
To be honest, I wasn't exactly thrilled about it.
Shun and I weren't close back then. In fact, it wouldn't be an exaggeration to say we could barely stand each other.
It had been about six months since our parents remarried and we started living together.
During that time, Shun and I barely spoke at home, hardly even saw each other, and went out of our way to avoid interacting.
It wasn't as though anything had happened between us.
We were both at a sensitive age, and neither of us had any idea how to adjust to a stranger who had suddenly become part of our family.

Shun was especially unruly back then. He was exactly the kind of troublemaker I couldn't stand.
From Shun's perspective, I imagine I was just a plain, awkward, creepy otaku... The kind of person he wanted absolutely nothing to do with.
We couldn't have been more different.
Living under the same roof wasn't going to make us get along.
Even at school, Shun and I went completely out of our way to avoid each other.
We acted as though we were strangers. It was an unspoken agreement between us.
Under those circumstances, suddenly approaching him as his family and handing him his lunch was pure torture.
I tried refusing, but my parents wouldn't hear it.
They probably couldn't bear watching us remain so distant, so they tried to create an opportunity for us to interact.
Reluctantly, I made my way to Shun's class's stands.
Shun was right in the middle of a lively group of popular kids, laughing and joking around.
Naturally, I was tempted to turn around and leave.
I already knew from experience that the mood would become painfully awkward the moment I stepped into their circle.
And yet, I took that step forward.
Looking back now, maybe some part of me wanted to change my relationship with him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun."

Figuring I had nothing to lose, I called my younger brother by his name for the first time.
Shun turned around as though jolted, his expression one of utter disbelief.
It was hardly surprising.
His stepsister, whom he hadn't properly spoken to in six months, had suddenly shown up and called his name.
I could feel the air around us grow cold.
Just as I expected, the entire group suddenly fell silent.
I held out the lunch to Shun beneath the wary gazes of the lively first-year students.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Here's your lunch."
Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun didn't answer. He was still too stunned to react.
Instead, the boy beside him whispered, "Who's she?"
That was enough to set the chatter going again.
On one side was the popular, outgoing guy; on the other, an otaku girl at the very bottom of the school social hierarchy.
Perhaps they found our mismatched pair amusing. Before long, I could hear quiet snickering all around me.

Male student
"Hey, hey, Shun. Who's thiiiis?"

Male student
"Is that your giiirlfriend?"
Male student
"No way! Really?! This is hilarious!!!"
Male student
"I can't believe it!!!"
Male student
"So this is your type, huh, Shuuuun?"

The whole group burst out laughing, and that finally seemed to snap Shun out of it.

Shun Anesaki
"She's not."

He muttered gruffly, then roughly snatched the lunch from my hands.

Shun Anesaki
"That's my... sister..."

Shun said the words in a small, strained voice, as though he were desperately trying to justify himself.
I still remember his expression that day perfectly.
Humiliation. That was all it seemed to convey.
Shun had always been one of the popular kids, and I suppose my existence was the first stain on his reputation.
I hurried away from the scene. I felt absolutely miserable.
The insults directed at me certainly hurt.
But more than anything, I couldn't stand seeing the embarrassed look on Shun's face.

Chapter 16: A calm confession

Nozomi Anesaki
"So you were there that day too, Oshii-kun..."
Yu Oshii
"…Yes. Honestly, I was shocked. I never imagined that the senpai who had just treated my injury would turn out to be Shun's older sister."

Oshii-kun paused, then resumed, his voice slightly more intense.

Yu Oshii
"…That was the first time I felt genuine disgust toward Shun."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"
Yu Oshii
"I still remember the hurt look on your face that day… I was terribly angry with Shun for making you look like that, and with the people around him as well."
Yu Oshii

"I think… that was when I fell in love with you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"I love you, Senpai."
Yu Oshii
"I love you so, so, so much… more than I know what to do with."

Despite the passion in his words, his delivery was utterly calm and detached.
There was even a hint of resignation in his voice.
That was why I couldn't answer him right away.
I didn't know what Oshii-kun wanted from me.

Yu Oshii
"Senpai."

A dull, metallic clatter rang out as Oshii-kun rose from his place.
He slowly walked toward me.
He stopped right in front of my chair and gazed down at me.
When I instinctively tensed up, Oshii-kun gave me a faint smile.

Yu Oshii
"Did I startle you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Uh... no... um... I..."
Yu Oshii
"Yes?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I-I'm sorry..."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...It's just... I don't really see you that way..."
Yu Oshii
"…I know."

Oshii-kun smiled gently. His reaction suggested that my answer was exactly what he'd expected.

Yu Oshii
"I know… I know that I could never be with you…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh...?"
Yu Oshii
"I've already accepted that. I was content just watching you from afar."

Oshii-kun sounded as though he were trying to convince himself of it.
He wouldn't meet my eyes, instead staring off into the distance as he quietly continued.

Yu Oshii
"It's okay. I've made peace with it. There's nothing I can do about it anyway."
Yu Oshii
"So even if you never come to love me, Senpai, that's okay."
Yu Oshii
"…It's just…"

Oshii-kun's eyes narrowed slightly. His gaze turned cold as he looked at me.

Yu Oshii
"I can't forgive Shun."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh...?"
Yu Oshii
"It doesn't matter who you fall in love with."
Yu Oshii
"But Shun... I can never accept him."

Suddenly, Oshii-kun leaned forward, closing the distance between us.
I instinctively drew back in my chair.
He grabbed my wrist.
His face was suddenly inches from mine.

Yu Oshii
"When I saw you for the first time in high school, I was surprised."
Yu Oshii
"Senpai… you're pretty different from how I remember you. Your eyes… Is that makeup? You don't normally look like this."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"…Is it because of Shun?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"Did he make you this way?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No."

I quickly shook my head. Shun wasn't making me do any of this.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm doing it because I want to."

Yu Oshii
"And why do you want to?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's..."

"I want you to say it's good."
Suddenly, the words I'd been about to say this morning surfaced in my mind.
It hit me.
Could that be it? Was that really the main reason…?

Yu Oshii
"...As I thought, it's because of Shun."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh...?"
Yu Oshii
"You think about Shun more than anyone else."

The wrist he was gripping creaked painfully.
Oshii-kun's quiet intensity overwhelmed me, leaving me unable to do anything but stare at him.

Yu Oshii
"Why Shun?"
Yu Oshii
"It could have been the student council president."
Yu Oshii
"Why did it have to be Shun, of all people?!"

There was a brief silence.
Then Oshii-kun spoke again, smiling bitterly.

Yu Oshii
"I'm so jealous of him."
Yu Oshii
"He's blessed with so many talents. He has everything I want."
Yu Oshii
"He effortlessly gets everything I'll never be able to have."
Yu Oshii
"Even you..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Wait. Hold on."

At last, I was able to speak.
Oshii-kun had clearly misunderstood something, and I had to set him straight.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oshii-kun… Shun and I aren't like that."
Yu Oshii

"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"And Shun would never feel that way about me."
Yu Oshii
"…Why do you think that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You know Shun already has someone he likes."
Yu Oshii
"Have you never considered that it might be you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Never."
Yu Oshii
"Why not?"

Why? Isn't it obvious? Just think about the facts.

Nozomi Anesaki
"We're siblings, for one thing."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun only sees me as his older sister."
Nozomi Anesaki
"And I see Shun..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"As my younger brother."

Then I saw something fierce stir in Oshii-kun's eyes.
Desperation, hesitation, anguish. All of those feelings flashed across his face at once.

Yu Oshii
"Brother..."

Oshii-kun let out a strained groan.

Yu Oshii
"Then I…"
Yu Oshii
"I will…!"

Something hot brushed against my collarbone with a sharp sting.
It was his lips.
I stared in disbelief at the sight before me, and then my eyes met Oshii-kun's as he lifted his head.
There was something twisted in his look.
With a desperate expression on his face, Oshii-kun moved even closer.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No…!"

I cried out in a hoarse voice.
This was bad.
We were so close that I could feel his breath against mine.
I instinctively shut my eyes and cried out again.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oshii-kun...!"

Chapter 17: Weak grip (Yu)

I couldn't breathe.
I couldn't even open my mouth.
What was happening to me?
All my senses had gone numb, and I couldn't move a muscle.

Yu Oshii
"Senpai."

Oshii-kun whispered in a hoarse voice. This time, a distinct warmth touched my lips.
It was a cautious… kiss.
Oshii-kun was kissing me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"!!!"

I instinctively raised my hand to push him away, but I couldn't.
Oshii-kun was holding my wrist.
His hand was trembling with fear.
I should have been able to easily pull free. And yet for some reason, I couldn't escape Oshii-kun's weak grip.

Yu Oshii
"..."

Oshii-kun slowly pulled away.
His eyes wavered as he stared at me, as if he were looking at something he couldn't bear to face.

Yu Oshii
"...I love you."

His second declaration of love was far more passionate than the first one.
Yet it somehow sounded less like a confession and more like a pained groan. A strange, protective feeling stirred within me.

Yu Oshii
"I love you, Senpai."

He pulled me into an embrace, clinging to me like I was his only refuge.
I could feel Oshii-kun's voice, his breathing, his whole body shaking. I was overcome by the urge to hold him back.
But I managed to resist the impulse and took a breath of the humid air.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oshii-kun… I… I still…"
Yu Oshii
"I understand."

He cut me off. Oshii-kun tightened his embrace, preventing me from saying anything more.

Yu Oshii
"I understand… that you don't feel that way about me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"…Can I ask you it one more time?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What…?"
Yu Oshii
"Do you really see Shun as nothing more than your brother?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yes, that's right."

Shun and I aren't blood-related.
Even so, he is without a doubt my little brother.

Yu Oshii
"…Then… would you give me a chance?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Yu Oshii
"You can take it one step at a time. Could you start looking at me differently?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"…I'm begging you, Senpai…"
Yu Oshii
"I just… I can't help loving you."
Yu Oshii
"I want to become someone special to you."

He held me so tightly I thought my bones might crack.
And yet, it felt strangely feeble, like he would pull away the moment I pushed back.
…I still didn't know whether I could come to see Oshii-kun in a romantic way.

Even so, I didn't have the heart to turn him away. I hesitantly wrapped my arms around his trembling back.

Normal end: An inexplicable feeling

A couple of months later.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun! I'm off."

When I called out from the entryway, Shun came down the stairs. He was rubbing his eyes, still dressed in his pajamas.

Shun Anesaki
"…Huh? Sis, are you going somewhere…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I told you about this yesterday."
Shun Anesaki
"Oh, did you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Jeez… You weren't paying attention, were you? …More importantly, what do you think of this dress?"

I did a quick spin to show off my outfit.
Shun yawned loudly, looking completely uninterested.

Shun Anesaki
"Looks fine."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…What a half-hearted response."

But whatever. Shun wasn't the person I wanted to impress today.

Shun Anesaki
"Where are you off to?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"The library."
Shun Anesaki
"…Huh? By yourself?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No. …With Oshii-kun."

A vague sense of embarrassment and guilt made my voice trail off.
Shun slowly opened his eyes, as though he had just woken up.

Shun Anesaki
"…Huh? With Yu?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah."
Shun Anesaki
"Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm going to help him study."
Shun Anesaki
"…During summer break? Really?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well… yeah. Apparently, there are some parts of his summer homework that he doesn't understand."
Shun Anesaki
"Hmm…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You'd better get your homework done too. Summer vacation's almost over."
Shun Anesaki
"...Fine, fine."
Nozomi Anesaki
"See you later."

My phone vibrated as I walked out the door. It was a message from Oshii-kun.

Yu Oshii
“I'm sorry, I'll be about two minutes late.”

…Two minutes?
It was hardly a serious delay, yet I found his thoughtfulness oddly endearing.
I really like this serious side of him.

Yu Oshii
"Sorry, Senpai…! I kept you waiting…!"

Oshii-kun appeared at our meeting spot one minute late. He must have run here; he was quite out of breath.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You were only a minute late. It's really nothing, so don't worry."
Yu Oshii
"But… you must have been waiting here longer than that, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Only for about five minutes."
Yu Oshii
"*Sigh*... I'm sorry… I was planning to get here before you…"

After taking a moment to catch his breath, Oshii-kun looked at me with a serious expression.

Yu Oshii
"Oh, by the way… that outfit… is it the one you bought the other day?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes. The one you picked out for me. …What do you think?"
Yu Oshii
"…You… look really good in it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"R-really…?"

Oshii-kun's sincere compliment made my heart beat a little faster.
He always had something positive to say to me, but none of it ever felt like empty flattery.
There was always a genuine sincerity to his words.
That was why I felt like I could always be my true self around him.

Yu Oshii
"Shall we get going, then?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah!"

The hours passed as we studied at the library, and before long, the sky begun to set.
We finished up what we were working on and left the library.

Yu Oshii
"Senpai, do you have anything planned after this?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, nothing really."
Yu Oshii
"In that case, how about we wander around for a bit?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Is there somewhere you want to go?"
Yu Oshii
"No, I don't have anywhere in mind. How about you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm… not particularly…"
Yu Oshii
"Then let's just go for a walk."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sounds good."

We walked side by side.
When Oshii-kun's hand brushed against mine,
I reflexively pulled my arm back.

Yu Oshii
"..."

Oshii-kun also looked a little awkward as he put a few inches of space between us.
…I wasn't rejecting him. I was simply more aware of him now.
Nothing really changed in our lives after Oshii-kun's confession.

I didn't suddenly start spending more time with him, and our conversations were perfectly ordinary, well within the bounds of a normal senior-junior relationship.
Of course, neither of us made any attempt to get physically closer.
It was almost as if he'd never confessed to me at all, and our relationship simply carried on as before.
Still, as the days passed, I became increasingly aware that my feelings were slowly changing.

Yu Oshii
"Oh… Senpai, look, they're selling crepes."

Oshii-kun broke the awkward silence.
I followed his gaze and saw a crepe truck parked along the street.

Yu Oshii
"Are you hungry?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Actually… yeah. I guess all that studying made me hungry."
Yu Oshii
"Would you like a crepe?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, I'd love one."

With our crepes in hand, we resumed our walk through the city.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Did you get the strawberry one?"
Yu Oshii
"Ah, yeah. Strawberry custard. What about yours…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Mine's seafood."
Yu Oshii
"Seafood…"

Oshii-kun's cheek twitched.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Do you hate seafood?"
Yu Oshii
"I don't really hate it... I'm allergic to it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, really?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes. I can't have shrimp. Fish and shellfish are fine, though."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see… I had no idea."
Yu Oshii
"…Do you have any allergies, Senpai?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I don't think so."
Yu Oshii
"Any foods you don't like?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm… I can't really think of anything I don't like."
Yu Oshii
"Ohh, I see. Then what's your favorite food?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Pudding, I guess."
Yu Oshii
"Aah, I like pudding too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I didn't know you had such a sweet tooth. That's kind of surprising."
Yu Oshii
"Is it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Just a little."

Come to think of it, I hardly knew anything about Oshii-kun.
Most of the conversations we'd had up until now had been about studying, school, or other mundane things. Little more than practical small talk.
I imagine he knew just as little about me.
And yet, I felt completely at ease whenever I was with him. Maybe it was because he knew what I had been like in the past, or maybe it was something else entirely...
I found reassurance in the thought that Oshii-kun would accept me no matter what kind of person I was.
Even now, as we walked together in silence, I wasn't the slightest bit uncomfortable.
As someone who was fundamentally introverted, I couldn't help but find it strange that I could be so at ease with someone I barely even knew.
I couldn't quite put a name to this feeling.

Yu Oshii
"...Senpai?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."

I snapped back to reality and found Oshii-kun looking at me with a puzzled expression.
Apparently, I'd been watching him quite intently.

Yu Oshii
"Do you want to try my crepe?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, no…! Not at all!"
Yu Oshii
"If you want some, I don't mind sharing…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no, no, really! It's not that. I'm not that much of a glutton."

Yu Oshii
"Ahaha, all right."

Oshii-kun smiled cheerfully and took a bite of his crepe.
I absentmindedly followed the movement with my eyes, and he turned his attention back to me.

Yu Oshii
"…Are you sure you don't want some?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... No?"
Yu Oshii
"Then… Do I have something on my face?"

Oshii-kun looked a little restless. Ah, of course… He must feel awkward eating while I'm staring at him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry, it's nothing—oh, hang on."

Looking more closely, I noticed some whipped cream on Oshii-kun's cheek.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You've got some cream on your face."
Yu Oshii
"Uh... where?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Your left cheek."
Yu Oshii
"…Here?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"A little lower."
Yu Oshii
"Lower…"

His finger slid over the whipped cream.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Pfft."
Yu Oshii
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You just smeared it."
Yu Oshii
"Uh..."

Amused by Oshii-kun's flustered attempts to remove the cream, I took a handkerchief from my bag.

Then I quickly wiped the whipped cream from his cheek. He froze in surprise.

Yu Oshii
"..."

A blush slowly spread across Oshii-kun's cheeks.
His reaction caught me off guard, and my own face began to feel hot, so I quickly drew the handkerchief away.

Yu・Nozomi
"..."

For a while, we just looked at each other.
Somehow, everyone else had disappeared, leaving only the distant chirping of cicadas to fill the silence.
Oshii-kun's eyes slowly slipped shut.
I followed his lead and slowly closed mine as well.
I was still a little hesitant. But I couldn't say I didn't want it.
The soft pounding of my heart was undeniable proof that I was starting to think of Oshii-kun as someone special.

Yu Oshii
"..."

Oshii-kun's hand touched my neck.
I squeezed my eyes shut and braced myself, only to feel something brush past just beside my lips.
When I opened my eyes, Oshii-kun was right there, his face just inches away. Neither of us moved. For a moment, it felt as though time had stopped.

Yu Oshii
"…Is this really okay?"

I awkwardly nodded, and immediately afterward…
Oshii-kun tilted his head slightly, and our lips met.
……
…I didn't know why,
but his lips felt like they were trembling. Even his fingertips, resting against my neck, felt cold.
The same thing happened when he first kissed me.
He was frightened of something.
Perhaps, just like me, there was a part of him that still held back.
I desperately wanted to ease his fear, so I pressed my lips against his, answering his kiss.
Something hot welled up inside my chest.
I no longer knew if this was love, or some other feeling altogether.

Chapter 17: Another discovery (Shun)

My wrist was trembling.
Mine? No. It was not mine.
The hand clutching my wrist was trembling. Oshii-kun's hand.
I slowly opened my eyes.
His eyes met mine, still burning with fierce emotion.
Frustration... But even more prominent than that were resignation and regret.

Yu Oshii
"Yu..."

Oshii-kun's voice quivered.
A moment of silence passed.
Even the faint sound of his breathing seemed to waver.

Yu Oshii
"Call me 'Yu,' please."
Yu Oshii
"And..."
Yu Oshii
"Please don't call Shun your brother."

It was a desperate plea, laden with years of feelings he had kept buried.
Oshii-kun released my wrist and took a deep breath, as though he had finally resolved himself to what he was about to do.

Yu Oshii
"That day at the sports festival... I made another discovery."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Another discovery…?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes."

Oshii-kun stepped away from me and reached for the bag he left on the desk.
He took something out of it and turned back to me.
A handkerchief?

Yu Oshii
"Do you remember this...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"
Yu Oshii
"It's the handkerchief you used to treat my injury that day."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah..."

When I looked more closely, I noticed a faint reddish stain on it.

After the sports festival, I took the handkerchief home with me.
I couldn't bring myself to throw it away, so after giving it a quick rinse, I put it in the laundry basket.
That night, my mother came rushing into my room, looking utterly distraught.
She thrust the handkerchief in front of me and demanded to know where and how I'd gotten it.
Then came a barrage of questions: "Are you in contact with the owner of this handkerchief?" "How much do you know, and what exactly do you know?" ...and so on.
My mother's panic was strange, to say the least.
I couldn't understand what had caused it, nor could I make sense of what she was trying to accomplish with all those questions.
The whole thing struck me as very odd, so I questioned her in turn.
"Do you know the owner of that handkerchief?"
My mother couldn't answer right away.
A heavy silence continued. Then my eyes happened to catch something on the handkerchief in her hand.
A name. It was written in black marker.
That was when I first learned your name. But at the same time, something felt wrong.
"Nozomi Kimura," it read. The name wasn't "Anesaki."
After a long, long silence, my mother took a deep breath. It seemed she'd made up her mind.
And then she told me something that was almost impossible to believe.
"Kimura" had once been her surname,
and the owner of the handkerchief was her daughter.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"

Wait. What did he just say?

Nozomi Anesaki
" 'Daughter.' "
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oshii-kun's mother... is my... mother...?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes."
Nozomi Anesaki

"Huuh...?"

What is he talking about?
If Oshii-kun's mother is my mother...
Then that means...
Oshii-kun is...

Yu Oshii
"I'm your..."
Yu Oshii
"Your biological younger brother."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You're kidding."

I couldn't help but laugh in disbelief.
What the heck? What kind of plot twist is that? What kind of game is this?

Yu Oshii
"You don't believe me?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Of course I don't..."
Yu Oshii
"I don't blame you. I couldn't believe it either."

Oshii-kun nodded, his expression completely serious.
He didn't look like he was joking.
But that didn't make it any easier to accept what he was saying as the truth.

Nozomi Anesaki
"But... but still... I never heard anything about having a biological sibling... Not once..."
Yu Oshii
"That's to be expected. Your father... that is, my biological father... most likely has no idea that I exist."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What?"
Yu Oshii
"Apparently, my mother found out she was pregnant with me only after she and your father had separated."
Yu Oshii

"After the divorce, my mother changed her family registration and moved here. She gave birth to me here and has raised me on her own ever since."
Yu Oshii
"Meanwhile, your father took you in and lived on his own, knowing nothing about my mother's pregnancy or where she had gone."
Yu Oshii
"...Isn't that right?"

I gave an awkward nod.
As far back as I could remember, my father and grandparents were the only people in my life.
My father never explained why I didn't have a mother.
I don't think he'd intentionally kept it from me.
Knowing his rather carefree nature, he probably just couldn't be bothered to talk about it.
I hadn't felt the need to press him for answers, either. I had little interest in things that had happened before I was old enough to remember them.
Toward the end of my first year of middle school, my uneventful life suddenly took a new turn.
My father abruptly announced, "I'm getting married."
He only gave me the vaguest explanation of how he'd arrived at that decision. In short, he'd "met someone nice while away on a business trip."
I wasn't particularly enthusiastic about it, but I had no particular reason to object, either. So I decided to quietly go along with my father's decision.
From there, everything happened in a blur. Before I knew it, I was living with my new family here, and more than three years had passed.

Yu Oshii
" 'Kimura'... that's your father's original surname, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, that's right... When they were discussing the remarriage, they decided to use Shun's mother's surname."

That was a handkerchief I used back when I was still a "Kimura."

Nozomi Anesaki
"I see... So that's how Oshii-kun's mother realized who I was…"
Yu Oshii
"Yes. …Though my mother apparently already knew that Shun's mother was your father's new wife."
Yu Oshii
"They had actually known each other for some time."
Yu Oshii
"They apparently became friends through their children's elementary school PTA activities. I suppose they got along because they were both single mothers."
Yu Oshii
"They hardly saw each other after me and Shun graduated, but when they happened to meet in town, my mother learned of her marriage."
Yu Oshii

"It was in the middle of an ordinary conversation that my mother realized Shun's mother was marrying her former husband."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Oh... I-I see..."

That's... a lot to take in…

Yu Oshii
"Apparently, my mother didn't tell her anything. Well, naturally. There was nothing to be gained by revealing the truth."
Yu Oshii
"It'd been more than ten years since their divorce, and they'd both long since moved on with completely separate lives. She wasn't going to interfere."
Yu Oshii
"But... it seems she still carried some resentment from the divorce. My mother doesn't like your father very much."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Oh. I see..."
Yu Oshii
"Yes. Apparently, her insistence that I compete with Shun was an expression of her desire to compete with her former husband. ...Pretty childish, if you ask me."
Yu Oshii
"...She told me to stay away from you and not to tell anyone what I'd learned."
Yu Oshii
"Of course, I had no intention of doing that. I hate trouble. I didn't want to get dragged into my parents' disputes, nor did I want to see a family fall apart."
Yu Oshii
"However..."

Oshii-kun took a breath, then looked at me again, his eyes filled with conflicting emotions.
My chest felt tight.
Still, I couldn't look away from him.

Yu Oshii
"I didn't know what I was supposed to do."
Yu Oshii
"I didn't really care about my parents' quarrels. I was surprised to learn about my biological father, but he was a stranger to me. I wasn't really interested in him."
Yu Oshii
"But I couldn't stop thinking about you."
Yu Oshii
"I think I fell in love with you when we first met. But by the end of that very same day, it became a love that could never be."
Yu Oshii
"Still, I couldn't simply put those feelings behind me."
Yu Oshii
"After I learned that you were my biological sister, my affection for you only grew stronger."
Yu Oshii

"I couldn't tell whether my feelings were romantic, or whether they came from the bond we shared as family."
Yu Oshii
"Either way, I could never have what I wanted. It was something that would always remain beyond my reach."
Yu Oshii
"I grew more and more envious of Shun. ...Though perhaps 'envy' doesn't quite capture it. I even came to resent him."
Yu Oshii
"He's good at sports, he's got natural talent, and people admire him. Shun has everything I could ever want."
Yu Oshii
"And if he wanted to... he could even have you."
Yu Oshii
"Every time I saw you looking at Shun, it made me angry. Every time you smiled at him, I felt utterly miserable."
Yu Oshii
"And every time you called Shun your 'brother,' I..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...!"

Oshii-kun's face drew close to mine again.
Caught off guard, I couldn't even close my eyes this time.
The motion was almost like he was going to bite me.
Our lips nearly touched.

Yu Oshii
"I... I don't know what to do anymore..."
Yu Oshii
"What can I be to you…?"

Oshii-kun slowly pulled away, unable to meet my eyes.

Yu Oshii
"I'm sorry... I don't even know what to make of myself anymore."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Uh..."
Yu Oshii
"...I need some time to clear my head."

Oshii-kun gathered his belongings, took his bag, and fled out of the library.
.....
My mind felt hazy. I still couldn't quite take in what had happened.
No... It's not that I didn't understand Oshii-kun's story. At first, I'd found it impossible to believe, but now I was convinced that every word of it was true.
And yet, it still didn't feel real.
Oshii-kun is my younger brother.
My biological brother.

My brother by blood...
.....
It still felt like I was dreaming. And yet, strangely enough, that knowledge seemed to settle neatly into my heart.
The fact that I'd never found it strange how close Oshii-kun and I had become.
The fact that I'd been able to accept his affection toward me as something perfectly natural.
The fact that I always felt at ease in his presence.
Maybe all of it was because we were connected by blood... Somehow, it just seemed to make sense.

Chapter 18: Impulse

It started raining just as I left the gate.
Not good. If I don't hurry, I'll be soaked by the time I get home.
For now, I forced all those thoughts out of my head and quickened my pace.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm home."
Shun Anesaki
"Welcome back. Wait, you're absolutely drenched."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It started raining while I was on my way back."
Shun Anesaki
"Hmm, you were at school for a while."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Were you studying with Yu?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Uh... I guess…"

...Oh no. I looked away without meaning to. I probably looked like I was hiding something...

Shun Anesaki
"...Oh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I wasn't sure whether I should tell Shun about what I learned today.
Wouldn't that... just ruin everything?

Just as Oshii-kun said, and as my biological mother wanted, I had no intention of tearing apart the family I had now.
I'd finally managed to build a close sibling relationship with Shun, and our family had settled into a comfortable rhythm.
There was no point in causing unnecessary conflict.
But... after learning all this, could I really keep treating Oshii-kun like any other junior at school...? Honestly, I wasn't sure.
I still couldn't quite grasp the fact that Oshii-kun was my biological brother. But I could no longer see him as a complete stranger, either.

Shun Anesaki
"...Did something happen?"

Apparently, my hesitation showed on my face.
I shook my head, putting those thoughts aside.
For now, I decided to put the matter on hold. This involved the whole family. I needed to be more careful before deciding what to do.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No. I'll go change."
Shun Anesaki
"Okay..."

Ugh... I'm absolutely drenched. Even the camisole I'm wearing underneath is damp and clammy. It's disgusting.
I grabbed some dry clothes and headed for the changing room.
I stripped off my wet uniform and camisole, then dried myself from head to toe with a bath towel.
Come to think of it, my hair was soaked, too. I removed the tie and let it down, then began roughly drying it with a towel
when I suddenly heard the door open behind me.
I spun around and locked eyes with Shun, who looked absolutely stunned.
...And, just to be clear, this wasn't even the first time something like this had happened.
I'd run into Shun once before, right after he got out of the bath.
And there'd even been a time when I accidentally walked in while he was changing.
Ever since then, we'd both been more careful about using the washroom while the other was bathing.
But enough about that!

Nozomi Anesaki
"Why did you come in?!"

I quickly pulled the bath towel around myself.
Shun blinked, seemingly snapping back to reality, then started flailing his hands awkwardly.

Shun Anesaki
"I came in to wash my hands!!! What are you doing here?! Weren't you changing in your room?!"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Whatever! Just get out!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"Okay, okay! I'm leaving! I'm leaving, I'm leaving, I'm leaving!!!"

Shun backed away, apparently in such a panic that he made some weird movement, slipped, and...

Shun Anesaki
"Ow!!!"

...fell onto the floor with a painful-sounding thud.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey, are you okay?!"
Shun Anesaki
"Y-yeah... I'm fine... I'm fine. Just put some clothes on..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, you get out first."
Shun Anesaki
"...Right..."

Shun sat up, rubbing his head, but then suddenly froze.
He was staring at me, looking puzzled and suspicious.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Where are you looking, pervert?"
Shun Anesaki
"...No, it's just... what is that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...That?"
Shun Anesaki
"That... on your neck."
Nozomi Anesaki
"My neck...?"

I looked down and immediately noticed something strange.
There was an unnatural red mark on my collarbone.
This was...

Nozomi Anesaki
"!"

I quickly covered my collarbone with my hand.
This was... the mark Oshii-kun had left.
The warmth of his touch on my collarbone came flooding back to me, and I could feel my face heating up.

This was bad... I was making my reaction far too obvious. If I wasn't careful, Shun would start digging for answers.

Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Yu?"

I flinched.
...Ugh, why was I so incapable of putting on an act when it mattered most?

Shun Anesaki
"...Hmm."

Shun was getting more and more upset.
It wasn't quite his usual sulky expression.
It was much colder, with none of his usual joking attitude.

Shun Anesaki
"...Tell me. Are you dating him now?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"O-of course not."
Shun Anesaki
"Then what is that? Did he force himself on you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

It wasn't untrue. But I still hesitated to simply nod.
I'd learned about the complicated emotions behind Oshii-kun's impulsive actions.
And it wasn't as though I couldn't understand those feelings.
I just couldn't think of myself as the victim.

Nozomi Anesaki
"It was basically an accident... Don't worry about it."
Shun Anesaki
"What do you mean, an accident? What are you hiding?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No... I'm not hiding anything."
Shun Anesaki
"Idiot."

He shot me down, his voice thick with irritation.

Shun Anesaki
"I'm asking how it happened."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I told you, it was an accident."
Shun Anesaki
"Then tell me exactly what this 'accident' was."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...No. I don't want to talk about it."

There was no way Shun would be satisfied if I tried to dodge the question. I had to make it clear that I simply wasn't going to talk about it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Look... you don't have to worry about any of this, Shun. I'm not going to talk about it, so just drop it."

Shun immediately frowned. His irritation was clearly getting worse.

Shun Anesaki
" 'Just drop it'? Are you serious?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Shun Anesaki
"After finding out this much, you really think I can ignore it?"

Shun's voice became more and more heated. I was swept up in the force of it and found myself unable to answer.

Shun Anesaki
"What's with that face? You seriously still don't get it?"
Shun Anesaki
"Honestly... this so-called 'otome gamer's intuition' of yours really isn't worth much."
Shun Anesaki
"Why can't you understand...?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Would you understand if I did the same thing Yu did?"

Suddenly, Shun grabbed me by the shoulders.
The bath towel slipped halfway down. Before I could even react, Shun leaned in toward my neck.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...!"

I felt a sharp prick of pain, like a thorn had pierced my skin.
Then the same sensation came against my neck again and again.

Nozomi Anesaki
"W-wait... Shun...!"

This time, his lips closed around my skin with unexpected gentleness.
His hot breath grazed my neck.
A shiver ran through me.
A strange sensation welled up from somewhere deep inside me, and I desperately grabbed Shun's sleeve, trying to resist.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun... wait...!"
Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun silently lifted his head.
The look of desire in his eyes took my breath away.
Since when? Since when has Shun been looking at me that way…?
And when did I start—?

Shun Anesaki
"Sis…"

Shun slowly leaned his face toward mine.
An intense, suffocating heat filled the air, making my head feel hazy.
I couldn't muster any strength.
This is bad. I can't let this continue.
I still have to...

Shun Anesaki
"...Can I?"

Just before our lips met, Shun whispered the words in a voice that sounded almost feverish.
It wasn't reason holding him back. There was something in his voice that allowed no room for protest.
I was so overwhelmed by the moment that I almost nodded.
But...

Nozomi Anesaki
"No!!!"

I used every last bit of strength I had to shove Shun away.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun stared at me in shock.
I quickly readjusted my bath towel and hurriedly started talking.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Get out!"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Now...!"
Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun bit his lip, then abruptly got to his feet and stormed out of the room.
The heated atmosphere dissipated all at once.
I slowly exhaled and closed the door to the changing room.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I couldn't think straight.
I'd been hit with one intense rush of emotion after another, and I still hadn't been able to process either of them.
But... there was one feeling I could grasp clearly.
I felt truly fulfilled right now.
I couldn't say the realization didn't confuse me. That's why I pushed Shun away earlier.
But... ah... I understand now... So that's what it was...
When did I fall in love with Shun...?

I finished changing and stepped out of the changing room.
The house was eerily quiet, with nothing but the sound of the rain echoing through it.
Where is Shun...? Maybe he is in his room.
I wasn't ready to talk to him yet.
I knew avoiding him wasn't going to solve anything, but I didn't want to see him until I'd sorted out my feelings.
Taking care not to run into Shun, I hurried into my room.
I collapsed face-down onto my bed and replayed the events of the day in my mind.
...Yeah. I still couldn't think straight.
Maybe I should do some studying to clear my head…
……
Ugh... I don't feel like it...
Then maybe I could play an otome game and escape reality...
...No. I don't really feel like doing that, either.
I wonder if I'd feel a little better after sleeping...
Listening to the soothing sound of the rain, I slowly closed my eyes.

Chapter 19: The winter rain

I suddenly stirred awake. The rain was still pouring down relentlessly.
What time is it…?
I checked my phone and was slightly surprised by the answer.

It was already 8PM. Apparently, I slept for quite a while.
…More importantly, what is Shun up to?
We usually have dinner at around 7PM. The exact time varied, but it was rarely this late.
Maybe he was eating alone. Perhaps he still couldn't bring himself to face me.
I cautiously peeked into the living room.
There was no sign of anyone. The lights were off, too.
I guess he is still holed up in his room…
…So what should I do? If he can't face me right now, I don't want to force him.
But we can't keep going like this forever.
I need to talk with him properly…
I also have to tell him how I feel.
I stood in front of Shun's room and took a deep breath.
I didn't know what expression to make, but I gathered my courage and tried knocking.
……
No reply.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Shun?"

……
Still no answer.
Is he sleeping, or is he intentionally not responding…?
I hesitated for a moment, then opened the door slightly and peered into the room through the gap.
His room was dim. Maybe he really was sleeping.
I shifted my gaze toward the bed.
…What? It's empty…?
I turned the light on and went inside.
Shun was nowhere to be seen.
The room was completely silent, save for the rain outside and the faint ticking of the clock.

Nozomi Anesaki
"No way..."

I immediately took my phone and called Shun's number.
A few seconds later, I heard a vibrating sound in the room.
He left his phone behind. His wallet was on the desk too, so by the looks of it, he went outside without anything.
…Or perhaps he just impulsively ran away.
It was already pitch black outside. The rain was still heavy.
Where is Shun? Is he okay…?
He doesn't have his phone nor wallet, so there is nothing he could use to pass the time.
Did he really not want to see me that desperately…?
He wasn't planning to run away from home, was he…?

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Ugh…!"

I grabbed my umbrella and rushed outside.
I had no idea where he'd gone, so I decided to look around the places he usually went.
But there was no sign of him.
I was really worried about him. Where could he be…?
He didn't have any money on him, so he couldn't have gone to a store.
Then… Maybe he was at his friend's house…?
…That could be it.
I'm a little jealous of people like Shun. They always have someone they can turn to when they need help.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I suddenly came to my senses.
What was I even trying so hard for?
Something similar had happened before.
It was December, near the end of the second semester of middle school.
After the day of the Sports Festival, my relationship with Shun had been steadily deteriorating.
He used to act as though I didn't exist, but afterward, he started openly showing his hostility toward me.
Whenever we crossed paths in the hallway, he'd glare at me, click his tongue in irritation, and, to top it all off, mutter, "Gross."
I never showed it, but honestly, I was seething with anger.
Sometimes I even wanted to hit him.
However, I always held myself back and avoided a direct confrontation with Shun, until one evening…
I received a call from Mom.
"It's raining, so could you grab an umbrella and pick Shun up at the station?" she asked.
Apparently, Shun had gone to another school that day for his club activities.
It started raining while he was on the train home, and he ended up stranded at the station.
He'd called Mom for help, but she was still stuck at work, so I was the only one available to go get him.
I wished he'd just go home by himself, even if he got soaked.
Why did I have to take care of this brat?
But I had no choice but to agree.
This was Mom's request, so I knew I couldn't refuse.
Reluctantly, I headed to the station through the rain.
But when I got there, I couldn't find him anywhere.
"That's weird," I thought. Mom said he was already supposed to be waiting for me.
I waited another twenty minutes,
but he never showed up.
The rain grew heavier, and the temperature seemed to drop with every passing minute. My frustration with Shun only intensified.
I turned on my heel to leave. I'd had enough of waiting for him.
Nevertheless, I was still a little worried and decided to take a detour on the way home.
Maybe he'd found somewhere to take shelter from the rain.
…Turned out that was not the case.

While I was looking for him, Mom called.
"Shun is already home, please come back."
Apparently, he hadn't waited for me at the station. He went to a friend's house instead, borrowed an umbrella, and headed home.
Still irritated, I headed home, where I found Mom scolding Shun at the entrance.

Mom
"Why didn't you wait for her to pick you up?"

Shun didn't answer her, but I already knew the answer.
He thought I was embarrassing. He didn't want his friends to see me.

Mom
"Apologize to your sister."

Mom's harsh tone didn't seem to affect Shun at all. He remained silent, his expression sullen.
That's enough, I thought. He clearly wasn't sorry.
There was no point in forcing him to give me a formal apology. It would only make things more awkward.
I decided to leave and quickly made my way to my room, passing by Mom and Shun.
But just as I was about to leave, Shun finally spoke.

Shun Anesaki
"I don't want to think of her as my sister."

In that instant it felt as though everything that had been building up inside me suddenly burst all at once.
I immediately turned around and grabbed Shun by the collar.
Even though Mom was standing right there, I slapped him with all the force I could muster.

Shun Anesaki
"…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…"
Shun Anesaki
"…What… are you doing…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…"
Shun Anesaki
"Hey!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Shut up!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…"
Shun Anesaki
"…"
Nozomi Anesaki

"…I hate you…"
Shun Anesaki
"…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I hate you so much…!"

Nozomi Anesaki
"...That brings back memories…"

Looking back, Shun and I really couldn't stand each other. Our relationship was pretty much beyond repair.
And here I was, searching for Shun again.
…Maybe Oshii-kun was right.
In one way or another, Shun had always been at the center of my thoughts.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Let's go…"

I tightened the grip on my umbrella handle and pushed off the ground again.
This time, I'll return home with Shun no matter what.

Chapter 20: The summer rain

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hm?"

I came to an abrupt stop at the sight before me.
Someone was sitting on a bench in the park.
In the middle of this downpour? Alone? That was strange...
Could it possibly be Shun...?
...No, no. Surely not.
Granted, Shun's academic achievements left much to be desired, but he wasn't stupid. He wouldn't do something this nonsensical.
Still, just to make sure, I walked toward the figure.
It was dark, and the rain obscured my vision, but...
That silhouette… Huh? No way...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun?!"

It really was him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What are you doing?!"

Sitting here all alone, without even an umbrella in this rain?!
I hurried over to him.

He was soaked from head to toe, his head hanging limply.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey! Shun?!"
Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun didn't answer. He didn't even raise his head.
Is he still bothered by what happened earlier? Maybe he's upset with me.
It's awkward for me too, obviously. But this really isn't the time for that.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, we're going home."

I angled my umbrella toward him to keep him out of the rain and spoke sternly.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

He didn't respond again.

Nozomi Anesaki
"We're going home!"

I grabbed Shun's arm and tried to pull him up.
Then my eyes widened in surprise.
His arm was unnaturally hot.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun?!"

I lifted Shun's head so I could get a better look at him.
…He was pale. His dull eyes were unfocused.
The moment I touched his forehead, I knew he had a fever.
Come to think of it, Shun had looked unwell since this morning.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, are you okay?!"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"If you can hear me, say something!"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you dead?!"
Shun Anesaki
"...Obviously not…"

At last, Shun let out a weak, feeble voice.
Thank goodness. I could finally breathe a sigh of relief.
But he was clearly in bad shape. We couldn't keep standing around like this.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Can you walk a little? I'll get us a taxi right away."
Shun Anesaki
"...Yeah. I think I can manage..."

I helped Shun to his feet and supported him as we headed for the park exit.
The sound of his strained breathing grated on my ears, making me feel short of breath myself.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, are you okay?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."

It seemed even speaking was too exhausting for him. Shun could only give me a weak nod.
He didn't have the strength to walk on his own anymore, leaning heavily against me and leaving me to support his entire weight.
God, he is heavy. Every step took a tremendous amount of effort.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Come on, Shun. You can do it."
Shun Anesaki
"...Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"We're almost there."

We just needed to get out of the park and reach the main road. Then we could catch a taxi.
If he were healthy, it would only take about five minutes. But in his current condition, I had no idea how long we'd be stuck out here… It was starting to feel like an incredibly long journey.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Whoa…"

My legs suddenly gave way.
That was close. I almost lost my grip on Shun.
I steadied him again and continued onward, carefully placing one foot in front of the other.

Nozomi Anesaki
"*Sigh*..."

We somehow made it out of the park, but by then, I was gasping for breath.
How much farther was it to the main road…?
…No. There is no point in thinking about it. I just have to keep moving…

I took a deep breath and forced my trembling legs forward.
Shun said nothing, his head hanging low.
Suddenly, I felt an overwhelming urge to cry.
And then…

???
"Senpai…?"

I turned around and saw Oshii-kun standing there, looking a little lost.
For a moment, my mind went back to what happened in the library after school, and I didn't know how I was supposed to act around him.
Maybe he felt the same way, judging by how he avoided looking at me as he spoke.

Yu Oshii
"…Is something wrong?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…I want to get to the taxi stand, but… Shun…"
Yu Oshii
"Huh?"

Oshii-kun's eyes fell on Shun, and he quickly rushed over.

Yu Oshii
"What happened to Shun?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"He has a fever. He can't even walk on his own…"

I was honestly reaching my limit too. My arm trembled under Shun's weight.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Oshii-kun's expression turned serious as he stepped over to help support Shun.
The pressure on my body immediately eased. I let out a long sigh and bowed my head to Oshii-kun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you..."
Yu Oshii
"…Don't mention it. Let's go."

Oshii-kun and I set off together.
With him sharing Shun's weight, each step came much easier than before, and we gradually picked up speed.

Chapter 21: Brother

Yu・Nozomi
"..."

The silence lingered.
There was so much I wanted to say, so much I knew I had to say, but no matter how hard I tried, I couldn't find the words.
Oshii-kun was probably struggling with the same thing. I didn't know why, but somehow, I just knew it.

Yu Oshii
"...Um..."

Just as the taxi stand finally came into view, Oshii-kun broke the silence.

Yu Oshii
"What happened to him?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...We... had a little argument."
Yu Oshii
"..."

Perhaps he had some idea of what had happened, because Oshii-kun fell silent, looking conflicted.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun was already feeling sick in the morning, but apparently he ran out of the house without even taking an umbrella."
Nozomi Anesaki
"He was at the park, completely soaked."
Yu Oshii
"I see… That must have been rough."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Honestly… He's such a handful, this—"

..."brother of mine."
That was what I had been about to say, but the words caught in my throat.
Brother. Brother?
Shun was my younger brother.
Then what exactly did that make Oshii-kun, who was now standing beside me?
What was I supposed to call this person who was bound to me by blood as closely as anyone could be?
I stared blankly for a moment before turning toward Oshii-kun.
He was looking at me too.
Then he gave me a faint, resigned smile.

Yu Oshii
"You always give your all when it comes to Shun."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

That might be true.
Ever since I met Shun, I've been completely at his mercy.

Yu Oshii
"Shun must be… special to you in so many ways."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yes."
Yu Oshii
"...If I'd been by your side from the moment I was born..."
Yu Oshii
"Could I have... become someone special to you?"

He murmured the words so softly they were almost drowned out by the sound of the rain, then looked away.
The relentless rain, too heavy for the umbrella to shield him from, soaked his hair, which looked remarkably similar to mine.
We reached the taxi stand.
Once I settled Shun into the taxi, I turned to face Oshii-kun again.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you for helping me."
Yu Oshii
"Of course."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well then..."

I was about to turn away, but something made me stop.
I looked at the face before me again.

Yu Oshii
"..."

Is he crying…?
Or perhaps the drops of rain dripping from his wet hair were simply running down his cheeks.
Either way, it was such a heartbreaking sight that I instinctively reached out to Oshii-kun.

Yu Oshii
"..."

Oshii-kun's shoulders trembled.
I gently wiped his wet cheek with my palm and simply said what first came to mind.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Make sure you don't catch a cold."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Be careful on your way home."
Yu Oshii
"...Okay."

Oshii-kun's face crumpled, just like the boy we'd met before.
I couldn't shake the feeling of helplessness that had overcome me, so I turned my back on Oshii-kun and got into the taxi.

We finally made it home.
The sound of the rain faded into the distance, and everything suddenly seemed quiet.
All I could hear instead was Shun's shallow breathing beside me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, we're home."
Shun Anesaki
"…Mm…"

Shun slowly opened his eyes.
Thank goodness, he was still conscious.
I put an arm around his shoulders and supported him as I helped him sit down on the floor.
He still had just enough strength to move on his own, and, though still hazy, he took off his shoes.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Can you walk?"
Shun Anesaki
"…Probably."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay, then let's get you changed."

I took Shun to the dressing room and handed him something to change into.

Shun Anesaki
"…Help me."

Shun casually asked me to do something absolutely outrageous.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Huuuh? You want me to help you change?"
Shun Anesaki
"…Yeah. It's too much effort…"
Nozomi Anesaki

"What are you saying? You have to take off everything, top and bottom. You'd be completely naked, you know. Are you thinking straight?"
Shun Anesaki
"…Oh… Right."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Jeez… Pull yourself together. I'll wait outside. Call me when you're finished."
Shun Anesaki
"Okay."
Shun Anesaki
"Sis… I'm done."

A few minutes later, I heard Shun's weak voice.
When I opened the door, Shun was standing there looking like he could collapse at any moment.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Whoa... Are you okay...?"
Shun Anesaki
"Barely…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Can you still walk?"
Shun Anesaki
"…I can make it to my room."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Do you need my help?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah…"

I supported Shun again as we made our way to his room.
We were only a few meters from his bed.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, we're at your bed."
Shun Anesaki
"...Okay."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Come on, lie down and get some rest."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Shun?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey? Woah?!"

My field of vision suddenly shifted upward.
Shun fell, leaning his full weight on me, and I ended up collapsing onto the bed with him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"W-wait a second…!"

He was heavy. Shun's body pressed against me was also burning hot. His heat was making me feel warm too.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Move. Come on, get off me."
Shun Anesaki
"…I'm just… too exhausted…"

Shun's voice was faint and weary.
Apparently, he didn't have the energy to move anymore. So I was going to have to escape on my own.
…Well, what else can I do? Sorry, Shun, but I will have to shove you off.
I was just about to…

Nozomi Anesaki
"Eek?!"

But suddenly, Shun's arm slipped around my waist.
He pulled me into a tight hug.
W-wait… um… weren't you feeling too tired to move?!

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Sorry."

Shun finally released me, forcing the words out in a weak murmur.
I pushed against him a little, and he rolled off me without any resistance.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Phew..."

I finally managed to get off the bed.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…Are you okay?"

I checked on Shun, who was lying there completely limp. He nodded with a blank look on his face.

Shun Anesaki
"…I'm just gonna… sleep…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Okay. …Oh, hang on. I'll get your medicine."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hey? Shun?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."

The only response I got was the soft sound of his breathing. He'd fallen asleep almost immediately.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...*Sigh*..."

I suddenly felt myself relax.
I rested my upper body against the bed, and before long, drowsiness came over me.
The rain falling outside. The ticking of the clock. Shun's quiet breathing.
Their steady rhythm only lulled me further into sleep.
Ahh… this is… kind of nice…
I'm sleepy… so sleepy…
.....
.....

Chapter 22: Slumber

Cough, *cough*.
Someone is coughing loudly.
…Who is that?
Cough.
It's coming from the room next door.
...Aah. It's him[shun]. Did he catch a cold?
Hahaha. Serves him right. That's what he gets for going home on his own yesterday without waiting for me.
What a weakling.
Meanwhile, I'm perfectly fine.
Cough, *cough*.
.....
Cough, *cough*, *cough*.
…Ugh… How annoying.
Should I slam my fist against the wall?

…Would he get pissed? Maybe he'd come over and hit me.
Well, I don't really care. I'll just hit him back as hard as I can.
Cough.
By the way, yesterday felt really good.
I can still vividly feel the sensation of my palm when I slapped him across the cheek.
And the look on his face afterward. What a ridiculous expression. Absolutely priceless.
Apparently, he's considered attractive or something, but he looked anything but handsome then.
I almost wish someone else could see it.
…Too bad I don't have any friends to brag about it.
Cough, *cough*, *cough*.
.....
Cough, *cough*.
…Seriously, this is getting annoying.
Come to think of it, what time is it? …Oh, it's already noon.
I really need to stop doing this. I always end up sleeping until noon on my days off.
I should get up already.

Nozomi Anesaki
(…No one's here. Dad and Mom must be at work again today.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(…Hmm? There's a note here.)

“Nozomi-chan, it looks like Shun isn't feeling well, so please take care of him. I'm counting on you. P.S. I've left some medicine for him. There's a note inside the bag with instructions on how to take it.”

Nozomi Anesaki
(...Huuh? What is she talking about? You've got to be kidding me. Does she seriously still think she can somehow fix things between me and Shun?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(No way. No, no, no. Absolutely not.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(I gave Shun a pretty good smack yesterday, and honestly, it felt like that was the final nail in the coffin for our relationship.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(And obviously, I'm not apologizing. Why should I? I'm not the one who's in the wrong.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Considering the way he's treated me all this time, he had that coming.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Well, what should I do now? Maybe I'll play a game.)

Cough, *cough*.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Tch."
Nozomi Anesaki
(What is his problem? I swear he's doing this on purpose.)

Cough... *cough*.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Cough...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Jeez...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Can you keep it down?"
Shun Anesaki
"...*Cough*... *cough*..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Huh? Wait, what? He actually looks pretty sick.)
Shun Anesaki
"…Hk… haaah…"
Nozomi Anesaki
(…Uh… Is he worse off than I thought…?)
Shun Anesaki
"...*Cough*, *cough*, *cough*, *cough*."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...W-wait… Are you okay…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
(...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(…Jeez… Fine. I guess I can't just leave him like this... I'll bring him his medicine. That's all…)
Nozomi Anesaki
(I'm not doing anything else for him.)
Nozomi Anesaki
"…I'll leave some water and your medicine here."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(…Seriously? He's ignoring me? Hmph… Well, I guess that's just how he is.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Whatever. I've done my part. I'll get out of here.)
Shun Anesaki
"…Ngh…"
Nozomi Anesaki
(…Hm? Did he say something?)
Shun Anesaki
"…Ugh… ngh…"
Nozomi Anesaki
(Wait… His face looks awful.)
Nozomi Anesaki

(Don't tell me he's going to throw up?!)
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait…! Not yet!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"…Uuugh…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Waah, waiiit!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
(I need a bag!!! Where's a bag?!)
Shun Anesaki
"…I… can't…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"?! W-wait—!!!"

.....

Nozomi Anesaki
(...*Sigh*...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...That was terrible...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(I instinctively caught it with my own clothes...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(W-well... whatever... At least the room didn't get dirty...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Okay. I think I've cleaned most of it up…)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Did you take your medicine?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You know, you could at least answer me."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...He glared at me. Seriously? What's his problem? He's getting on my nerves.)
Shun Anesaki
"...ful."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?
Shun Anesaki
"...Awful."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Huuh? What was that? Me, awful? That's what you're worried about right now?)
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see. Sorry, I guess."
Nozomi Anesaki
(D●e!)

Shun Anesaki
"...Ah. That's not..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? What?"
Shun Anesaki
"...I feel awful, so I don't really want to... talk."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Are you going to throw up again?!"
Shun Anesaki
"...Maybe..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait! If you're gonna throw up, use this! Here, into the bag!"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Are you going to?"
Shun Anesaki
"…I don't know… But I don't feel well…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…If you feel sick, just let it out."
Shun Anesaki
"…Mm…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(…Should I rub his back…?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(…He might find it annoying. …But he looks like he's really suffering…)
Nozomi Anesaki
(…Just a little…)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Well?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(…Oh. He's quiet…)
Nozomi Anesaki
"…It's okay. Go ahead. I'll hold the bag open."
Shun Anesaki
"…Mm."

Nozomi Anesaki
"...*Sigh*..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(…That's twice now. And I even got some on my hand this time…)
Nozomi Anesaki

(It's okay... it's okay... it can't be helped... it can't be helped...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Ugh... Jeez...!)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Honestly... my brother is—)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...such a handful.)
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Still feeling sick?"
Shun Anesaki
"No… I feel a lot better now."
Nozomi Anesaki
(…Yeah. He definitely looks better than he did before…)
Nozomi Anesaki
"Did you take your medicine?"
Shun Anesaki
"…Not yet."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Can you do it yourself?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What about food?"
Shun Anesaki
"…I don't think I can eat yet."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then just take your medicine for now."
Shun Anesaki
"...Okay."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Did you take it?"
Shun Anesaki
"…Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Why don't you get some sleep?"
Shun Anesaki
"…I will…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki

"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(…Is he asleep…?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(What should I do? Is it really okay to just leave him like this…?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(…I guess I should keep an eye on him for a little while longer… It'd be a problem if he threw up again…)
Nozomi Anesaki
(…*Sigh*… I'm exhausted…)
Nozomi Anesaki
(This is bad… I'm starting to get sleepy…)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Ahh...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(…I think I'm going to fall asleep…)

.....
.....

Shun Anesaki
"...s."
Shun Anesaki
"...is."
Shun Anesaki
"Sis...?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Are you asleep...?"

I slowly drifted back to consciousness.
When I opened my eyes, I found myself in Shun's familiar room.
But...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"

Seeing Shun lying on the bed and looking at me caught me by surprise.
When did he become so grown-up?
.....
…Oh, right. That was a dream just now…
For some reason, it made me feel nostalgic…

Shun Anesaki
"…Sis…? What's wrong…?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"…Nothing… I must've dozed off."

I checked the clock. 11:00 p.m. Looks like I'd been asleep for around two hours.

Nozomi Anesaki
"How are you feeling? You still seem to have a fever…"
Shun Anesaki
"…Yeah, but… I'm feeling a lot better…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see. …Do you want something to eat?"
Shun Anesaki
"…No, I'm good."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…By the way, what were you doing at the park?"
Shun Anesaki
"…I just… didn't know how to face you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"So… I just walked around for a while…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Without an umbrella?"
Shun Anesaki
"I only realized it was raining after I left…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Idiot."
Shun Anesaki
"…Shut up."
Nozomi Anesaki
"And then?"
Shun Anesaki
"…I killed some time by going into convenience stores and stuff."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You didn't have your wallet, did you?"
Shun Anesaki
"I didn't realize that until after I left the house, either."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're a complete idiot."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"And then what? You had nowhere else to go, so you went to a park? In the pouring rain? What were you thinking?"
Shun Anesaki
"…Well… I was trying to find somewhere to hide from the rain, but I started feeling really exhausted…"
Shun Anesaki

"There was a park right there, so… I thought I'd sit down for a while…"
Shun Anesaki
"…And then I couldn't move."

...Yeah.

Shun・Nozomi
"What an idiot."

Our voices overlapped. Even Shun couldn't really argue with that one.

Shun Anesaki
"…I'm glad you came, Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…It's funny. You used to hate having me around."
Shun Anesaki
"…Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You used to call me gross, remember?"
Shun Anesaki
"...I do."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You made fun of me with your friends, too. Called me a shut-in otaku and everything."
Shun Anesaki
"…Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You… really hated me back then, didn't you?"

Shun silently nodded.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…So what changed?"

That was a question I was asking myself, too.
I used to hate Shun as well.
I never thought we'd ever become close.
And I certainly never imagined... that I'd fall in love with him.
And yet…
When did my feelings for Shun change?

Chapter 23: Memory 1

Nozomi Anesaki
(...*Sigh*... School again today...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(The weekend went by so fast.)
Nozomi Anesaki

(...Mainly thanks to Shun.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(I wonder how he's doing now.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Whatever... It's none of my business.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(I did all that for him, and I didn't get so much as a thank-you yesterday.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...I'm an idiot for expecting something like that.)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I'm off."
Mom
"Take care."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Shun... Is he still asleep? He wasn't even there at breakfast.)
Mom
"What's the matter, Nozomi-chan?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Oh... well... it's just… Shun..."
Mom
"Ah, him. He's still not feeling well, so I'm having him stay home today."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(He's still not feeling well...)
Mom
"Thank you for taking care of him yesterday."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Y-yeah..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Well, Mom*someone* thanked me... But still...)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Well then, I'm off."
Mom
"Okay. Have a good day."

Teacher
"Today, we'll be practicing reading in English."
Teacher
"Take turns reading the English passage on page 17 of your textbook with the person sitting next to you."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Crap... This is the worst-case scenario...)
Male student
"What?! Really? This sucks."
Male student
"Hahaha, Anesaki's sitting next to you! Lucky you!"
Male student

"Yeah, right! Switch with me!"
Male student
"No way."
Male students
"Gyahaha!"
Nozomi Anesaki
(...)

Teacher
"Oh, Anesaki-san? You don't have a partner?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I'll just watch the others..."
Teacher
"I see. Then why don't you pair up with me?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Okay..."
Students
"...Hehehe..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...)

Image:
School motto: "Be healthy, be upright, and keep a pure heart."

Male student
"It's boring without Shun today."
Male student
"For real."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...! Could those be Shun's friends...?)
Male student
"Ah... Hey. Isn't that Shun's sister over there...?"
Male student
"...Yeah, I think so. I remember she looked something like that."
Male student
"Whoa... She's, like, a total otaku. Gross."
Male student
"Imagine having a sister like that. Ugh."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm home...!"
Shun Anesaki
"?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Why is he here? Wasn't he supposed to be sick...?)

Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Never mind. Ignore him, ignore him. I'll go straight to my room.)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...*Sigh*..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...I'm exhausted... Today was even worse than usual...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...I just... can't take it anymore...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...I don't want to go to school...)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...*Sob*..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Ngh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
(...What? Who is it?!)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Wh-who is it...?"

.....

Shun Anesaki
"...It's me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Shun?! Why? What for? What's going on?)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Wh-what...?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Can I come in?"
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Wh-what does he want...?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(F-first, I should wipe my face... I hope my nose isn't all red...)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Y-yeah... Come in."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki

"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Th-this is so awkward... What does he want? Why is he here...?)
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Wh-what is it...?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Well... Did something happen?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"
Shun Anesaki
"Your eyes look... a little red."
Nozomi Anesaki
"!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
(Great... He noticed I'd been crying...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...And why did he have to point it out? Couldn't he just keep quiet and ignore it? He's so insensitive...!)
Nozomi Anesaki
"Nothing happened. It's none of your business."
Shun Anesaki
"...If you say so."
Nozomi Anesaki
"So? What is it? Why are you here? If you don't have anything to say, then get out. And weren't you supposed to be sick?"
Shun Anesaki
"...No, I'm feeling a lot better now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm. Good for you."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Yesterday..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Well..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki

"...Th-thank you..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...HUH?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
(Wait... "Thank you"? Did he really just say that? Shun?!)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Wh-what...? Why...? Why?!)
Shun Anesaki
"...And... the day before yesterday."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Uh...?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Sorry... for just leaving like that."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Wait... Huh? He actually said "sorry"... Right...?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(N-no way... Shun actually apologized...)
Shun Anesaki
"...That's all. ...See ya."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Wh-what... was that...?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(I can't believe it.)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...That was so creepy."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Today's classes are... Japanese, math, social studies...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(That's a relief. Doesn't look like there's any group work.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Ah... Come to think of it, I'm on class duty today, aren't I...?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(*Sigh*... I really don't feel like going... I want to skip school...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(But it would be unfair to the other student on duty... There's so much stuff to take care of...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(I really should go...)
Shun・Nozomi
"Ah..."
Nozomi Anesaki

(Shun's up early today. ...Oh, right, morning practice. Still, he shouldn't push himself so hard. He's just recovered.)
Shun・Nozomi
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Actually... why does this feel so awkward...?)
Shun Anesaki
"...Sorry... for just leaving like that."
Nozomi Anesaki
(What happened yesterday...? I didn't just imagine him saying that, did I...?)
Shun Anesaki
"...What are you staring at?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"! N-nothing!"
Shun Anesaki
"...Hmph. ...I'm off."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Just as obnoxious as ever...! What happened yesterday must've been a hallucination.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...I hate him. I really, really hate that guy...)
Teacher
"That concludes homeroom. Goodbye."
Students
"Goodbye."
Teacher
"Those on class duty, don't forget to clean up, take out the trash, and fill in the class log."
Nozomi Anesaki
(The class log... Oh, right. The other student has it…)
Male student
"Anesaki-san."
Nozomi Anesaki
"! ...Y-yes?"
Male student
"I've got cram school today, so would you mind handling the cleaning? I already did the class log."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... Ah, y-yeah... Okay. Thanks."
Male student
"Okay then, see you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Wait, "thanks"...? What am I even saying?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Filling out the class log is the bare minimum, and besides, he hasn't done anything else for class duty today...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Not to mention...)

Male student
"Hey, Nishida. What did Anesaki say?"
Nishida
"She said she'd do the cleaning."
Male student
"Hahaha, seriously?"
Male student
"Then let's get out of here already. I wanna go to the arcade."
Nishida
"Idiot, keep it down. She'll hear you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(I can hear you loud and clear...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Whatever. It's pretty much what I expected.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(I'd much rather be on my own anyway.)
Nozomi Anesaki
"Phew..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(That should do it for cleaning. Now I just need to take out the trash...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(I-it's so heavy...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Why is there so much trash today of all days...?)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...*Sigh*..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(I'm exhausted... I should take a little break.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Ah.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(The soccer club is practicing...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(If I stay here, Shun might see me. I'd better get to the incinerator quickly.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Man... this is really heavy...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(I don't want to come to school on my duty days anymore... It's not like the other person is going to do their share anyway.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Ow, my arms are killing me... I should take another break—huh...?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Shun...!)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Huh? Wh-what is he doing here? Doesn't he have practice?)
Nozomi Anesaki

(Whatever, I need to hide somewhere before he sees me...!)
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wah?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
(Just great... I knocked all the trash out...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(I need to pick it up quickly...!)
Shun Anesaki
"...What are you doing?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
(He saw me...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Why is he talking to me...? He usually just ignores me...)
Shun Anesaki
"…Hey?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... I-I... I'm on duty today..."
Shun Anesaki
"Aah. ...Huh? You're doing this alone?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yes."
Shun Anesaki
"...Are you the only one on class duty?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...No... I mean... Whatever. Why does it matter to you? It's none of your business."
Shun Anesaki
"...Hmm..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...He probably wants to make fun of me... Can't he just leave already?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Because this is... so humiliating...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Wait...)
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?!"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? What's wrong?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What are you doing...?"
Shun Anesaki
"What do you mean...? I'm picking up the trash."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Why...?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Is there something wrong with that?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"N-no..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Of course there's nothing wrong with that... In fact, I'm grateful for the help. It takes some of the work off me... but...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(N-no... This is wrong. Shun isn't supposed to do things like this. It's creepy. So creepy, so creepy...!)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Stop."
Shun Anesaki
"What?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't pick it up."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Don't you have practice right now?"
Shun Anesaki
"We're on a ten-minute break."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's been ten minutes already. The soccer team started practice again a while ago."
Shun Anesaki
"It's not a big deal if I'm a little late."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I'm gonna be fine... This is my responsibility. I'll take care of it myself."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey, are you listening?"
Shun Anesaki
"Quit talking and keep moving."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wha—?"
Shun Anesaki
"There. All picked up."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(He's fast...! When did he even...?)
Shun Anesaki
"This is for the incinerator, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yeah, it is..."
Shun Anesaki
"I'll take it there for you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, this is my responsibility. I have to do it."
Shun Anesaki

"All right. Then I'll help. You carry that side."
Nozomi Anesaki
"H-huh...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
(What is he even saying...? Am I hallucinating again...?)
Shun Anesaki
"Hey. Hurry up, or I'm taking it myself."
Nozomi Anesaki
"W-wait! You can't...!"
Shun Anesaki
"Ah! hey, don't shake it! The stuff's gonna fall out again."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then just let go! I'll carry it myself...!"
Shun Anesaki
"There's no way you can carry this alone. It's pretty heavy even for two people."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm fine. I carried it all the way here by myself."
Shun Anesaki
"Whatever. Come on, let's go."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Why...?"
Shun Anesaki
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
(Why is he suddenly being so nice to me...? I don't get it...)
Male student
"Shuuun!"
Shun・Nozomi
"!"
Nozomi Anesaki
(Someone's coming this way...! One of Shun's friends...?)
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Oh... That look...)
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I'll take it myself!"
Shun Anesaki
"?! Hey!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Stop it! Just go!"
Shun Anesaki
"Wh-what?! I'm trying to help you here!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I never asked for your help. You're being a nuisance."
Shun Anesaki

"...Fine. Whatever. Then handle it yourself."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I will."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
(...Tch... She's barely even steady on her feet. ...She's gonna get hurt.)
Shun Anesaki
(I'm trying to help her, and she calls me a nuisance...? That really pisses me off.)
Male student
"Heyyy, Shun!"
Shun Anesaki
"Hm... A-ah, yeah. What is it?"
Male student
"Are you planning to rest all day? The practice match is starting."
Shun Anesaki
"Oh, my bad."
Male student
"By the way, weren't you with someone just now?"
Shun Anesaki
"! N-no... Not really..."
Male student
"Hmm? Ah, whatever. Let's go!"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."
Shun Anesaki
(...)
Shun Anesaki
(...I'm the worst...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Finally, I'm done taking out the trash... I'm exhausted...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Okay... All that's left is the class log. He said he'd written his part already, so I should be able to finish this quickly.)
Nozomi Anesaki
Nishida: It was so cold today, and I was feeling sleepy.
(...Huh? What's this? It's practically all blank. He only filled in his thoughts' sections.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(So basically, he dumped the whole thing on me... What a jerk...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Ugh... This is getting annoying. Maybe I should report him to the teacher.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Thoughts: "Nishida-kun didn't do any of his class-duty work today, so I had to clean the classroom and take out the trash all by myself. It was exhausting.")
Nozomi Anesaki
(...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(This is ridiculous. I'll remove it...)

Nozomi Anesaki
(...Hm? What's going on outside? It's kind of loud.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Oh... The soccer team is playing a match.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Wow... Shun is really good at it.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(He looks like he's having such a good time... He never smiles like that at home...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(I see... It's because I'm around that he doesn't smile like that...)
Shun Anesaki
"That's my... sister..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(That time, too.)
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(And just now.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Whenever I'm around, he always looks so unlike himself...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Then why did he go out of his way to talk to me...?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Why did he try to help me...?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Maybe I shouldn't have called him a nuisance...)
Mom
"Shun, Nozomi-chan, dinner's ready."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm coming!"
Shun・Nozomi
"Ah..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Wh-what should I do...? Should I say something...? But what would I even talk about...?)
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Ah...! He's leaving.)
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wait...!"
Shun Anesaki
"...Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Um... well..."
Shun Anesaki
"...What?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"About what happened earlier..."
Shun Anesaki
"Earlier?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"When you tried to help me carry the trash... um... thank you..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...U-ugh... M-maybe I shouldn't have said anything after all...)
Nozomi Anesaki
"W-well, see you!"
Shun Anesaki
"Uh... y-yeah..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...I-I was so nervous...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(But still... I feel a little better now that I said it...)

Nozomi Anesaki
(Okay... I think that's enough studying for today...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Wow, it's gotten pretty late. There's an anime on right now. Might as well watch it.)

.....

Male student
"Whoa... She's, like, a total otaku. Gross."
Male student
"Imagine having a sister like that. Ugh."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Nishida
"She said she'd do the cleaning."
Male student
"Hahaha, seriously?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"That's my... sister..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...*Sniff*... *sob*..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Enough... Screw school...)

Nozomi Anesaki
(...I'll just stay home.)
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
(...She's crying again.)
Shun Anesaki
(...Ugh... This is annoying... These walls are way too thin...)
Shun Anesaki
(I should just go to bed...)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...U-uh..."
Shun Anesaki
(...Sigh... I wish she'd just go to sleep already...)

Chapter 24: Memory 2

After that, I started missing school more and more often.
It started with one absence a week, but gradually that number increased, until by the end of the third term, I was missing more days each week than I attended.
After spring break, I started my third year of middle school, and by then, I had stopped going altogether.
Things had gotten even worse after we were assigned to new classes, and I had completely lost the will to keep going.
Instead, I immersed myself in self-study at home.
I still intended to go on to high school.
But I absolutely refused to go anywhere those people from my middle school would be.
So I decided to aim for the most prestigious private high school in the area.
I'd heard that hardly any students from my middle school were admitted each year.

Mom
"...Nozomi-chan?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yes?"
Mom
"...Are you skipping school again today?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah..."
Mom
"...I see..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(I'm sorry, Mom...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Well... time to study.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Huh, it's already this late...?)
Nozomi Anesaki

(I made really good progress today. If I keep this up, getting above the cutoff should be easy.)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Phew..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(I'm tired... Maybe I'll take a little break.)
Shun・Nozomi
"...Ah..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Shun... I didn't realize he was back.)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Welcome back."
Shun Anesaki
"...Yeah. I'm home."

I couldn't pinpoint when it started, but somehow Shun and I started speaking to each other normally.
Even when we'd run into each other in the hallway, he no longer glared at me or clicked his tongue, and he stopped calling me "gross."
At first, I was a little confused by how much his attitude toward me had softened, but honestly, I was relieved.
I didn't want him to hate me, after all. We were going to be living together for a long time to come.
Ideally, I wanted us to become close… Or, if not that, at least I wanted us to be comfortable around each other.

Shun Anesaki
"...You skipped school again today?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? ...Yeah."
Shun Anesaki
"Are you gonna be okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"? What do you mean?"
Shun Anesaki
"Your attendance."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Aah... It's middle school. I don't need perfect attendance to graduate."
Shun Anesaki
"No, I mean your school record. It'll affect your chances of getting into high school."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I've been studying pretty hard, so I'll be fine. I'll make up for my school record with my entrance exam score."
Shun Anesaki
"...Hmm. Well, if that's the case, then okay."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Is he actually worried about me...?)
Shun Anesaki

"...By the way..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"Why don't you go to school anymore?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
(He's asking me that now?)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Because I don't want to go, obviously."
Shun Anesaki
"Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"What do you mean, why…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
(Is he seriously asking me that? Is he stupid?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Hmph. Then I'll spell it out for him.)
Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't have any friends. People make fun of me when I go to school. They call me gross and an otaku. That's why."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You'd rather I stayed home too, wouldn't you? Now you can be more at ease."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Anyway, I'm going back to studying. Bye-bye."
Shun Anesaki
"...Okay."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
(...I thought so... it's like that in her class, too...)

Shun Anesaki
"Morning."
Male student
"Oh, Shun. Good morning."
Male student
"Yo!"
Shun Anesaki
"What's up? What's everyone so excited about?"
Male student
"Listen to this! Kishida got a girlfriend!"
Shun Anesaki

"Huh? Seriously? Who's she?"
Male student
"You're gonna be surprised. Kana Mizumoto from Class 2."
Shun Anesaki
"Kana Mizumoto...? Who was she again?"
Male student
"Wow, that's cold. You seriously forgot her? You two were classmates in your first year!"
Shun Anesaki
"Mizumoto... Ah. Ohh, yeah, her. ...Wait, seriously?"
Shun Anesaki
(Mizumoto… she is that really plain-looking student who reminded me of Sadako... She struck me as someone that girl[my sister] would get along with.)
Male student
"Hahaha! Looks like you reacted the same way, Shun!"
Male student
"Right?! Pretty shocking, huh?!"
Shun Anesaki
"Wait… seriously, though? Satoshi had a thing for Mizumoto?"
Male student
"Mizumoto's gotten really cute since summer break."
Shun Anesaki
"Ohh, really?"
Male student
"I guess she got a make-over for the second semester. She looks totally different."
Male student
"Hey, look. Speak of the devil. There's Mizumoto."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? That's Mizumoto...? Really? Did she always look like that?"
Male student
"Pretty amazing, huh?"
Male student
"Think she got plastic surgery?"
Male student
"Nah. See, Kishida's family owns a hair salon, right?"
Shun Anesaki
"Ah, yeah. That's right."
Male student
"Apparently, Mizumoto got her hair cut there during summer break."
Shun Anesaki
(A hair salon...)
Male student
"Whoa, seriously? I can't believe someone can change that much."
Male student
"Girls are scary, man."
Male student
"Kishida started dating her right after that. He's way too obvious."
Male student
"Didn't he always say, 'Personality is what matters to me'?"

Male student
"Hahaha! No way! That's freaking hilarious!"
Male student
"What about you, Shun?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? What?"
Male student
"Didn't some girl confess to you recently? You're not gonna date her?"
Shun Anesaki
"Eh, I don't really like her."
Male student
"So what's your type?"
Shun Anesaki
(My type...)
Shun Anesaki
"...I dunno."
Male student
"What kind of response is that?"
Male student
"Come to think of it, you rejected Shirakawa too."
Male student
"Dude, how could you turn down Shirakawa-san? She's so cute!"
Male student
"Maybe Shun's got weird taste in girls."
Shun Anesaki
"Huuh? What the heck does that mean?"
Male student
"Maybe you like girls who are like your sister?"
Male student
"Gyahahaha! You mean that otaku girl?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Hey. Knock it off."
Male student
"Ah, sorry, sorry. I was just kidding."
Male student
"I haven't seen your sister at school lately. Is she still alive?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Who cares about her anyway?"
Male student
"You guys still hate each other, huh?"
Male student
"I mean, it's understandable. She's kind of... you know."
Male student
"Hahaha, exactly. She's an otaku, and she's gross."
Shun Anesaki
"...Hey."
Male student
"Hm?"

Shun Anesaki
"Stop saying stuff like that."
Male student
"Huh? Saying what?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Calling her an otaku and gross."
Male student
"Huh? What are you talking about? You used to say that yourself."
Shun Anesaki
"I know that..."
Male student
"Wait, what? Don't tell me you actually fell for your sister?!"
Male student
"Whoa, that's so messed up!"
Shun Anesaki
"It's not like that!"
Male student
"Hey, hey, why are you getting so defensive?"
Male student
"You're no fun. Can't you take a joke?"
Shun Anesaki
"...*Sigh*... I'm going to the bathroom."
Male student
"All right, later."
Shun Anesaki
"...Tch."
Shun Anesaki
(What the hell is wrong with them... They piss me off...）

Nozomi Anesaki
"Thank you for the meal."
Shun Anesaki
(Oh, crap. I better hurry up and eat too.)
Mom
"What's with the rush, Shun? Slow down and chew your food properly."
Shun Anesaki
"Thanks."
Shun Anesaki
"...Hey!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"?! Wh-what? What do you want?”
Shun Anesaki
"...Well... uh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Why don't you get your hair done?"
Nozomi Anesaki

"Huuuh...?"
Shun Anesaki
(...Crap... Was that too sudden? ...Ugh... This is getting embarrassing...)
Nozomi Anesaki
"Where did that come from...?"
Shun Anesaki
"W-well... I don't know, just a thought...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What kind of explanation is that? I don't get it."
Shun Anesaki
"It's just... my friend's family has a hair salon..."
Shun Anesaki
"I figured they could probably do your hair cheap... Maybe...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hmm..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No."
Shun Anesaki
"...Huh? Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I don't want anything to do with your friends."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"And I hate salons anyway. If I went, I'd die of embarrassment."
Shun Anesaki
"That's ridiculous..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No. Absolutely not. I'm not going. I don't even want to leave the house! Bye."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
(What was that...? Damn it...)

Male student
"Hey, Shun. Wanna hang out at my place after school today?"
Shun Anesaki
"Ah, sorry. I've got something to do today."
Male student
"Oh, really?"
Male student
"Don't tell me you finally got a girlfriend?!"
Shun Anesaki
"Idiot. See ya."
Shun Anesaki
"...Ah."

Shun Anesaki
(Yu. Come to think of it, we haven't really talked at all since we got put into different classes.)
Shun Anesaki
"Yo."
Yu Oshii
"Oh... Shun."
Shun Anesaki
"Long time no see."
Yu Oshii
"That's true. Are you going somewhere?"
Shun Anesaki
"I'm heading over to Kishida's place."
Yu Oshii
"Ohh..."
Shun Anesaki
"What about you?"
Yu Oshii
"I'm going to cram school."
Shun Anesaki
"Still a total nerd, huh?"
Yu Oshii
"...It's not like I have anything else to do."
Shun Anesaki
"Hmm. Well, good luck."
Yu Oshii
"Yeah. ...Oh, wait a second."
Shun Anesaki
"What is it?"
Yu Oshii
"You... have an older sister, right?"
Shun Anesaki
"Uh... Yeah... What about her?"
Yu Oshii
"Well, I was just wondering how she's been."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
(...Fine...? Can I really say she's fine? She's holed up at home all the time... That's not exactly healthy.)
Yu Oshii
"Is something wrong?"
Shun Anesaki
"Ah, no… Yeah, I mean... I guess she's doing all right."
Yu Oshii
"Hmm..."
Shun Anesaki
"But why are you asking about her?"
Shun Anesaki

(It's not like Yu even knows her personally, right...?)
Yu Oshii
"Well... I haven't really seen her around school lately, so I was just a little curious."
Shun Anesaki
"Aah..."
Shun Anesaki
(Just how famous is she, anyway...?)
Shun Anesaki
(I guess that's understandable... She really stood out, and not for good reasons.)
Shun Anesaki
"She's not sick or anything."
Yu Oshii
"I see. That's good. See you."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah. Later."

Shun Anesaki
"Hey."
Satoshi Kishida
"Oh, Shun. You came. Long time no see."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, been a while. Sorry for showing up so suddenly."
Satoshi Kishida
"No, it's fine. But what's with the sudden request? You want me to teach you how to cut hair?"
Shun Anesaki
"Well… I don't know. Just felt like it."
Satoshi Kishida
"Hmm? Well, whatever. I'll go get Mom."
Shun Anesaki
"Is she at work?"
Satoshi Kishida
"No, my sister's handling it right now, so it's no problem."
Shun Anesaki
"Oh, okay. That's good."

Kishida's mother
"Oh my, Shun-kun! You're actually pretty good at cutting hair!"
Shun Anesaki
"…Uh, you think so?"
Kishida's mother
"Yes! I'm surprised at how quickly you picked it up! Why don't you come work for us someday?"
Shun Anesaki
"Haha… no, I…"
Satoshi Kishida
"Shun's seriously got a knack for this, huh?"
Kishida's mother

"You'd better learn to do this well yourself soon."
Satoshi Kishida
"Okay, okay."
Shun Anesaki
"Um… would it be okay if I came by again sometime?"
Kishida's mother
"Of course! Come whenever you like."
Shun Anesaki
"Thank you very much."
Mom
"Nozomi-chan! Dinner's ready!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah, okay. I'm coming."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Huh? Shun's not here again?)
Mom
"Shun's been coming home late lately… I wonder what he's been up to. His club activities should've ended by now…"
Nozomi Anesaki
(...He probably got himself a girlfriend or something.)
Mom
"Well, let's eat before it gets cold."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. Thank you for the meal."
Shun Anesaki
"I'm home."
Mom
"Oh, there he is. Finally."
Shun Anesaki
"…Sorry. I'm late."
Mom
"Good grief… We were about to finish dinner without you."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(…? What's up with him? He keeps sneaking glances at me…)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Well, whatever… I'm done eating, so I'll go.)
Shun Anesaki
"Thanks for the meal."
Shun Anesaki
"…Oh, wait."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Huh? Me?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah. Um… I've got something to talk to you about, so I'll come to your room later."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Uh..."

Nozomi Anesaki
(...Wh-what is this? Why is he being so serious all of a sudden…? This is kind of scary…)
Mom
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Even Mom looks surprised…)
Shun Anesaki
"…So, yeah. That's the deal."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Y-yeah, okay…"

Nozomi Anesaki
(Shun… I wonder what he wants…)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Ahh… I can't relax. I'm so restless…)
Nozomi Anesaki
(I'll just play a game until Shun gets here.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(…I finally gave an otome game a try…!)
Nozomi Anesaki
(And this is actually really fun… Hehe. Ahh, I can't wait to see what happens next! Okay, let's play!)
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hehehe…"
Nozomi Anesaki
(Oh no! I can't stop grinning…!)
Nozomi Anesaki
(What do I do…? My heart's pounding like crazy!)
Nozomi Anesaki
(All the guys are so nice to me…! And they keep telling me I'm cute…)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Ahhh, this is so nice…! I wish I could be the heroine too.)
Nozomi Anesaki
(If I could become as cute as her… That would be nice, wouldn't it…)
Nozomi Anesaki
("Always smiling and cheerful"… huh. That's difficult…)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...*Sigh*..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Wait, no! I can't get distracted! I need to focus on Jun-kun's confession!)
Nozomi Anesaki
(…WAAAAAAAH! I CAN'T TAKE IT! Jun-kun is so handsome! I love him!!!)
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hehehe!"

Shun Anesaki
"Hey. I'm coming in."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"…Why are you grinning like that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…I-I'm not…"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(UGHHHH!!! What is this guy doing?! Why is he just barging in all of a sudden?!)
Nozomi Anesaki
(It was just getting good!!! Jun-kun just told me he likes me!!!)
Nozomi Anesaki
(He is the worst!!! Seriously, the absolute worst!!! Ever heard of reading the room?!)
Shun Anesaki
"…W-were you in the middle of something…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"YES! I was very much in the middle of something!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"…Ah… Should I… come back later?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Whatever. It's fine."
Shun Anesaki
"…Sorry."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I said it's fine. …So? What do you want?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Well… uh…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah?"
Shun Anesaki
"…Let me cut your hair."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
(…M-my hair?! What is he talking about?!)
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Why are you suddenly asking that?"
Shun Anesaki
"…Is that a no?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"I mean, I don't know… But why? Are you up to something?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh...? No. It's not like that."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then no."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Because I don't know what you're after."
Shun Anesaki
"What I'm after…? I'm not after anything."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then you don't need to cut my hair."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Oh. Speechless, huh? I knew it. He's definitely up to something.)
Shun Anesaki
"…I-I just… want to cut it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"
Shun Anesaki
"...I said I WANT to cut it!!! Is that such a big deal?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-whaaa…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
(Whoa, he's getting angry?! What is happening?! I don't understand him at all! Scary…)
Shun Anesaki
"…I… I… want to become a hairstylist someday."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Huh? Oh… So that's your dream?"
Shun Anesaki
"…Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm... Really?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh… I see. Well… I guess that's okay."
Shun Anesaki
"Then… let me cut your hair. I need someone to practice on."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Uh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...If that's what this is about, then I guess I can see why...)
Nozomi Anesaki
"…You've never done this before, have you? What if you screw it up?"

Shun Anesaki
"It's not my first time. I've been practicing. It'll be fine."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ohh… You've actually been practicing?"
Nozomi Anesaki
(Huh. He's more serious about this than I thought. I guess he really does want to become a hairstylist…)
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm… Okay, then… You can do it."
Shun Anesaki
"! Really?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. I don't mind, but you'd better do it properly."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, yeah, I will. Hang on while I get things ready."
Nozomi Anesaki
(…He seems awfully happy about this… Well, whatever…)
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Are you really sure you can do this? Don't mess it up, okay…?"
Shun Anesaki
"I told you, it'll be fine."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Hmm… I'm still worried…)
Nozomi Anesaki
(He wouldn't actually deliberately ruin my hair… would he…?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(…Ugh. The more I think about it, the more I feel like he might. Now I'm nervous…)
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(…Hm? Are his hands shaking…?)
Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun...?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Wh-what?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Are you nervous?"
Shun Anesaki
"…A little."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Seriously? Why?"
Shun Anesaki
"Because you kept going on and on about how I'd better not mess up…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Wow... He actually wants to do a good job…)
Nozomi Anesaki

"I-it's fine. Don't worry about it. Just do whatever you think is best."
Shun Anesaki
"...Okay..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Oh… He's gentler than I expected…)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Having someone touch my hair like this… It feels nice, but… it's kind of giving me goosebumps…)
Shun Anesaki
"…Does it hurt?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, not at all…"
Shun Anesaki
"Your hair's pretty dry."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-you're so rude! You don't have to say that!"
Nozomi Anesaki
(Seriously, he is so insensitive...!)
Shun Anesaki
"…You know that treatment Mom uses? You should start using it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Does it actually do anything?"
Shun Anesaki
"Well… it's better than nothing."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Hmm…"
Shun Anesaki
"Okay… I'm gonna cut it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…G-go ahead."

Nozomi Anesaki
(W-woah… That's quite a lot of hair on the floor… He cut off that much…?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(I-I hope this is okay… It's not coming out weird, is it…?)
Shun Anesaki
"Can I cut your bangs too?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, I guess…"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki

(…I don't really know where I'm supposed to look…)
Nozomi Anesaki
(Now that I'm seeing him up close like this… Shun actually has a pretty nice face…)
Nozomi Anesaki
(He must be popular with girls… Actually, there's no way he isn't popular… Must be nice…)
Shun・Nozomi
"!"
Nozomi Anesaki
(…Ugh, we made eye contact…)
Shun Anesaki
"Woah, crap…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? What? What happened?"
Shun Anesaki
"…I messed up a little."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?! What did you do?!"
Shun Anesaki
"D-don't worry, don't worry! I can still fix it…!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"P-please be careful!"
Shun Anesaki
"Okay, okay…! Just keep looking down."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Why?"
Shun Anesaki
"It's hard to do this when you're looking at me…!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh. Oh, okay… I get it…"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Shun Anesaki
"...And... done."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Really?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah. Pretty much."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-you actually did it?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yep."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You didn't mess it up, did you?"
Shun Anesaki
"I think it turned out fine. Wanna look in the mirror?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Uh... Ah... I-I'm kind of scared..."
Shun Anesaki
"It doesn't look weird, I swear."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You think so...?"
Shun Anesaki
"Look."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Ugh... I-I'm scared...)
Shun Anesaki
"Come on, take a look."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...O-okay... Deep breath... I can do this...)

Peek.

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"W-wow..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Well?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-you're actually really good at this..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Everything feels so much lighter...! Maybe I don't look so shaggy anymore, either...!)
Shun Anesaki
"Right? Looks pretty good, huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Y-yeah... It's kind of amazing..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(If I'm being honest... I think I look a little cuter now...!)
Shun Anesaki
"...Is there anything you're not happy with?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hmm... What do you think, Shun...?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh...? Me?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. ...Do you think it looks good?"
Shun Anesaki
"W-well... I'm the one who cut it, so... of course I think it looks good."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I see... Hehehe..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(For some reason... that makes me kind of happy.)
Shun Anesaki

"...Do you like it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah... Yeah!"
Shun Anesaki
"...Hmm... In that case..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"Will you go back to school now?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? No."
Shun Anesaki
"Why not?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I told you already. I don't like going because people call me lame and gross."
Shun Anesaki
"You don't look lame anymore, and you're not gross, either."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Still no. I just... don't wanna go outside. Like, at all."
Shun Anesaki
"...You're a complete shut-in, huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"So what?"
Shun Anesaki
"So it's bad. Really unhealthy."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Then I'll be unhealthy. Who cares?"
Shun Anesaki
"You're going to high school, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah. Of course I am."
Shun Anesaki
"How are you gonna manage that if you keep living like this?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I'll go once I start high school. I will."
Shun Anesaki
"Can you really? You've spent practically a whole year hiding in your room."
Nozomi Anesaki
(He's right... I know that's true, however...)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...But... I really, really don't wanna go back to middle school..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Then…"
Nozomi Anesaki

"...?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Let's go somewhere this weekend."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh? Where?"
Shun Anesaki
"Dunno. Anywhere. A shopping mall nearby or something."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Wait... just you and me?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Why?"
Shun Anesaki
"You stay at home even on weekends, don't you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Because I don't want to go outside..."
Shun Anesaki
"Exactly. So let's get you used to going outside, little by little, before high school."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...He does have a point... but...)
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What's gotten into you?"
Shun Anesaki
"What do you mean?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You really don't mind going out with me?"
Shun Anesaki
"...N-no… Why would I?"
Shun Anesaki
"Besides, you don't mind going out with me either, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh? No! Of course not! What are you even saying?"
Shun Anesaki
"I don't mind either!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Th-then let's go! Together!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah!!! Let's go!!! Together!!!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"This is gonna be so much fun!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"I'm so looking forward to it!!!"

Chapter 25: Memory 3

Nozomi Anesaki

(U-ugh... A shopping mall... It's been forever since I've been somewhere like this...)
Nozomi Anesaki
(There are so many people... I hate this... Do I look okay? Is my outfit weird...?)
Shun Anesaki
"What are you so nervous about?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"W-well... Do I look weird?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? What exactly do you mean?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Just... everything? Don't I look weird?"
Shun Anesaki
"Not really."
Nozomi Anesaki
"... But my clothes are kind of lame, right?"
Shun Anesaki
"Uh... well, kinda."
Nozomi Anesaki
(I'm gradually getting used to Shun's lack of tact...)
Shun Anesaki
"Buy some new ones. Mom gave you plenty of money, didn't she?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Will you help me choose?"
Shun Anesaki
"Uh... Okay, I guess..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Which one do you think is better?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? You're asking me?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Because I don't really understand this kind of thing."
Shun Anesaki
"I don't either."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But you're planning to become a hairstylist, aren't you?"
Shun Anesaki
"That has nothing to do with clothes."
Nozomi Anesaki
"But aren't all hairstylists fashionable?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey, Shun, you pick one for me."
Shun Anesaki
"...*Sigh*... Jeez..."
Shun Anesaki
"…Fine. Then this one… and this one."
Nozomi Anesaki

"…Ohhh… So this is the kind of thing you like."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh?! Wh-what the heck? You're the one who asked me to choose! If you don't like my picks, choose for yourself!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I never said I didn't like them…"
Nozomi Anesaki
(I wonder if I can actually pull this off… Isn't it a little too fashionable…?)
Shop assistant
"Would you like to try them on?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"?! Uh, I-I... I... Um..."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, go ahead. Try them on."
Shun Anesaki
"This one, this one… and this one too, please."
Nozomi Anesaki
(H-he added another one?!)
Shop assistant
"Of course. Please follow me."
Nozomi Anesaki
(AAAAAH...!)

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(…I-I actually put it on…)
Shop assistant
"How does it fit?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Th-the size is okay…"
Shop assistant
"It suits you so well! You look adorable!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh, r-really...?"
Shop assistant
"Yes! Your boyfriend thinks so too, right?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no, no, no! You've got it wrong! He's my younger brother…!"
Shop assistant
"Ohhh, I see. You two are pretty close."
Shun・Nozomi
"..."
Shop assistant

"So, what do you think of this one?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Sh-Shun, what do you think…?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? Me?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah…"
Shun Anesaki
"…Well, I picked it out for you... Of course I think it looks good."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Really? Then I'll buy it."
Shop assistant
"Thank you very much for your purchase!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Hehehe."
Nozomi Anesaki
(I ended up buying quite a lot. Maybe… this sort of thing isn't so bad.)
Shun Anesaki
"You seem like you're enjoying yourself."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Yeah. It's kinda fun."
Shun Anesaki
"Hmm… That's good."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Um… Shun?"
Shun Anesaki
"Hm?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I… might want to go shopping… again."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-you said you'd help me until I got used to going out, didn't you?"
Shun Anesaki
"R-right."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Th-then… come shopping with me again…!"
Shun Anesaki
"…Sure. I don't mind."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Yay…!)

Shun Anesaki
"Hey, are you still not ready?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Not yet. Give me a little more time."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Okay… I think my hair looks pretty good.)

Nozomi Anesaki
(It's getting so much smoother lately. I'm glad I listened to Shun.)
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry to keep you waiting!"
Shun Anesaki
"…Haven't you been taking way too long lately?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Really?"
Shun Anesaki
"You used to be ready in like five minutes."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I've started paying more attention to my appearance. So? How do I look today? Does anything look weird?"
Shun Anesaki
"No. You look fine."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good! Then let's go."
Elderly man
"Oh, hello, Nozomi-chan."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah! Hello."
Elderly man
"Is that boy over there... your boyfriend?"
Shun Anesaki
"Uh... no..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ahaha, no. He's my younger brother."
Elderly man
"Ohh, so you're her little brother? Well, aren't you lucky. Having such a wonderful big sister."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Elderly man
"Come visit us at the facility again sometime. Everyone would be happy to see you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, I'll come visit again."
Shun Anesaki
"…Who was that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I think it was about two weeks ago. He got lost at that intersection, so I took him to the nursing home near the station. "
Shun Anesaki
"Ohh."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Hehe."
Shun Anesaki
"What are you grinning about?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"He called me a 'wonderful big sister.' "

Shun Anesaki
"Huh. Good for you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What's with that tone? You were blushing too. "
Shun Anesaki
"…I wasn't blushing."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Sure, sure. You definitely weren't blushing."
Shun Anesaki
"I told you, I wasn't!"

Nozomi Anesaki
"I bought a ton of spring clothes."
Shun Anesaki
"You really did. Isn't it a little too much?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's not. Once I start high school, I'll have to put even more effort into how I dress."
Shun Anesaki
"Hmm. But are you sure you're ready for the entrance exams? You've been playing games pretty often lately."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm studying properly. Games are just something I do to unwind."
Shun Anesaki
"Ohh."
???
"Oh, Shun?"
Shun・Nozomi
"Huh?"
Satoshi Kishida
"Yo!"
Shun Anesaki
"Oh, hey, Satoshi."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Huh…? Wh-who's this guy…? Is he one of Shun's friends…?)
Nozomi Anesaki
(O-oh no… I-I want to hide…)
Satoshi Kishida
"What are you doing? Shopping?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah. You too?"
Satoshi Kishida
"Yep. My sister dragged me along."
Shun Anesaki
"Haha. Sounds rough."
Satoshi Kishida
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(Ugh… H-he's looking over here… Wh-what do I do?)

Satoshi Kishida
"...Is that your girlfriend?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Shun Anesaki
"Ah. No, no."
Nozomi Anesaki
(…What's he going to say…?)
Shun Anesaki
"That's my sister."
Nozomi Anesaki
"!"
Nozomi Anesaki
(H-he actually called me… his sister… in front of his friend…)
Satoshi Kishida
"...Huh? ...Uh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Satoshi Kishida
"…I get it. That's nice."
Nozomi Anesaki
(…? What's nice?)
Satoshi Kishida
"She's really cute. I wish I could trade sisters with you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Shun Anesaki
"…Idiot."
Satoshi Kishida
"All right, I'm off. My sister's waiting for me."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah. Later."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Th-that guy just now… he's your friend, right?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…I see…"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…He said I was cute…"
Shun Anesaki
"…Good for you."

Nozomi Anesaki
"…Yeah."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Are you blushing?"
Shun Anesaki
"…Huh? I'm not blushing."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…But your face was a little red earlier, wasn't it? Actually, it's still red."
Shun Anesaki
"Shut up!"
Nozomi Anesaki
(…So he really was happy to hear it…?)
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Hehe."
Shun Anesaki
"Stop grinning like that…!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey, can we look at some more accessories?"
Shun Anesaki
"What?! You're still buying stuff?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Just one more!"
Shun Anesaki
"…I'm kinda tired. Can I go sit on that bench for a bit?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No. I want you to pick one for me."
Shun Anesaki
"…*Sigh*… Jeez…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…It's gotten pretty dark already."
Shun Anesaki
"That's winter for you. It gets dark early."
Nozomi Anesaki
"That's true."
Nozomi Anesaki
(It's already January…)
Nozomi Anesaki
(This past year went by so fast…)
Shun Anesaki
"Sis? What's wrong?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Hm? Oh, I was just thinking… spring's almost here."

Shun Anesaki
"Yeah… I guess so."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Say..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"…Do you think you can go to school?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(…School…)
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…I think I can. I've gotten used to going outside and talking to people…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"People even tell me I'm cute now…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…I'll be okay. Once I start high school, I'll go to school like I'm supposed to."
Shun Anesaki
"…I see."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"I'm happy for you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
(...Ah...)

Chapter 26: A sister to be proud of

Yes.
I think that was probably the moment when I clearly realized that my feelings had changed.
I was happy whenever Shun was happy.
I wanted to please him even more.
I wanted him to keep smiling, even when he was with me.
So, from that moment on, I decided to do whatever I could to bring him joy.
That I would let him be himself.
For Shun's sake.

I decided to become a sister he[my brother] could be proud of.

Shun Anesaki
"...I'm sorry."

Shun spoke in a small, quiet voice.
"Sorry"?
I tilted my head in confusion, but then remembered what happened in the changing room.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-you can let it go. I mean… yeah, it surprised me and all…"
Shun Anesaki
"No… That's not what I mean."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"
Shun Anesaki
"I'm not talking about that…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"? Then what?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."

His breathing was shallow, and he seemed a little pained.

Shun Anesaki
"…I've been thinking about this for a long time."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...?"
Shun Anesaki
"…I thought maybe I was forcing you to do things you didn't want to do."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Shun Anesaki
"You cut your hair. You started paying attention to your appearance…"
Shun Anesaki
"That was all because of me, wasn't it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

…He's not wrong. But...

Nozomi Anesaki
"…You're talking about it like it was something bad."
Shun Anesaki
"Because it was."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Why?"

A small spark of irritation rose in me. It felt as though he was rejecting everything I'd worked so hard to accomplish.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…Why can't I care about my appearance? Doesn't it make you happy, Shun?"
Shun Anesaki
"…It did. At first."
Shun Anesaki
"You were getting prettier and prettier… and people outside started complimenting you…"
Shun Anesaki
"Seeing you so happy about it made me happy too..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"…But gradually I started feeling like something was wrong."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Wrong…?"
Shun Anesaki
"…You're always worried about how I see you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Shun Anesaki
"You don't do it for yourself. You're more concerned with how you're judged as my sister, aren't you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"I knew you'd been forcing yourself to keep up appearances for my sake."
Shun Anesaki
"…I knew I was the reason it came to that, too."
Shun Anesaki
"...Wasn't I?"

Shun turned his eyes toward me. I couldn't bring myself to say anything.
What he was saying wasn't wrong.
I didn't want to embarrass him[my brother].
I felt like I had to become someone worthy of being the older sister of my popular little brother.
So I studied fashion. I made an effort to always act cheerful. I tried to become a respectable person, even if it was only on the outside.
Because whenever someone said, "What a good big sister," I could tell how pleased Shun was, even though he bashfully tried to hide it.

Shun Anesaki
"…The truth is, I never actually wanted to become a hairstylist."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh…?"
Shun Anesaki

"If I really wanted to become one, I wouldn't have applied to this insanely difficult high school. I would've gone to a school that actually specialized in it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Basically… I thought that if you cut your hair and started looking better, maybe people would stop making fun of you."
Shun Anesaki
"So I lied. I made up some excuse because I wanted to make you prettier."
Shun Anesaki
"…And in that sense, things went half the way I wanted."
Shun Anesaki
"But then I saw you pushing yourself every day at high school… and part of me regretted it."
Shun Anesaki
"…I'm sorry."

…It makes sense now.
So that's why Shun always looked unhappy whenever I put too much effort into my appearance.
.....
I guess I really am pushing myself too hard.
I smile whenever I'm around other people, but the moment I'm alone, all I can do is sigh.
Every time someone praises me, I'm overcome with guilt.
But still...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...I really wanted to become a sister you could be proud of..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"…I see."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"…But I don't want to think of you as just my 'sister.' "
Nozomi Anesaki
"…I see."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"…I'm still feeling sluggish… I'm going to bed…"

Shun rolled over, turning his back to me as if to avoid the awkwardness hanging between us.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Um… Shun, I…"

Shun Anesaki
"I said I'm going to sleep."

Shun hurriedly cut me off.
I could see that the tips of his ears were slightly red.
…So he gets to have his say, but not me…?
Honestly… that's so like him. I couldn't help but smile a little at the thought.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…Good night."
Shun Anesaki
"...Mm."

I quietly left Shun's room.
It felt as though a huge weight had suddenly been lifted from my shoulders.
I still didn't know exactly when I'd fallen in love with Shun.
But I realized that somewhere along the way I'd mistaken what I felt for him beyond my role as his "sister" for familial affection.
Because I was happy that Shun recognized me as his sister.
Because if I continued to be a good older sister, Shun would keep smiling.
Maybe that's why I kept clinging to our sibling relationship.

Chapter 27: A new day

An alarm went off.
…It was time to get up.
I went to bed a little late last night, so I was still a little sleepy.
Still, I somehow managed to open my eyes and slowly sit up.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Okay."

I've got to make sure I look presentable today, too.
After finishing my usual routine, I looked at the clock. It was already past 7:30.
It was time to wake Shun.
I quietly opened the door and peeked inside.
He was still asleep.
I wonder how he's feeling.
I quietly entered the room and approached the bed on tiptoe.
He was curled up asleep, so I leaned over to look at his face and gently placed a hand on his forehead.
…Shun was a little warm. He still seemed to have a fever. Maybe I should let him stay home from school today.
I came back with some water and medicine, and Shun shifted restlessly in his sleep.

Shun Anesaki
"...Mm..."

.....

Shun Anesaki
"...Huh… Sis...?"

...Oh, he woke up.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry. Did I wake you?"
Shun Anesaki
"…No… What time is it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"A little past 7:30."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh… Seriously?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You still have a fever, right? Take the day off from school today. I'll contact your teacher for you."
Shun Anesaki
"…Okay."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'll leave your medicine here. And some jelly, too. Have some if you feel like you can eat."
Shun Anesaki
"Okay."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, and I'll leave a bag."
Shun Anesaki
"…A bag?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Just in case you throw up."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well then, I'm off to school."

I turned away from Shun and made my way toward the door.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis."

Then he called out to stop me.
When I turned around, Shun sat up and was looking at me with a serious expression.
My heart skipped a beat.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-what?"
Shun Anesaki

"Hey… um…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah…?"
Shun Anesaki
"…Are you going straight home today…?"

His serious expression vanished, and Shun spoke in a quiet, hesitant voice.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…You want me to come home right away?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"…I do."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."

My heart skipped another beat.
Sick Shun is nothing like his usual self. He's strangely straightforward, and I never quite know how to react.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…W-well… I'll come straight home once I've done what I need to do."
Shun Anesaki
"…Done what you need to do?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…I was hoping to talk to Oshii-kun for a little while."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"And… there's something I want to talk to you about when I get back, too."
Shun Anesaki
"...Uh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Make sure you listen to me this time, okay?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun nodded awkwardly and slipped back under the covers.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well then, I'm off."
Shun Anesaki
"…Yeah. …Later."

After arriving at school, I looked around the entrance for Oshii-kun.
It didn't look like he was here yet.
I decided to leave him a short note and took out a pen.

I wrote: “To Oshii-kun,”.
Then my hand stopped.
"Oshii-kun." Something about it felt strange.
But… whatever. I left it.
I continued writing that I'd be waiting for him in the library after school, then slipped the note into Oshii-kun's shoe locker.
I wondered if I'd be able to talk to him properly.
Yesterday, I was so overwhelmed by Oshii-kun's intense emotions and the shocking truth he revealed that I still wasn't sure what to make of it all.
That's why, even though I wanted to talk to him, I still wasn't entirely sure what I should say or how I should say it.
There was just one thing I wanted to ask him again.
It was something I already had an answer to in my heart. And I think… that answer is probably the right one.
I had a feeling that I'd finally be able to settle on my own conclusion if I could hear Oshii-kun clearly affirm it himself.

I became so absorbed in my thoughts that, in the blink of an eye, it was time for the final homeroom of the day.

Teacher
"Anesaki-san."

As usual, the teacher stopped me just as I was packing up to leave.
A stack of booklets was piled up on his desk. …I guess this is today's task.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…Yes? What is it?"
Teacher
"Could you put these booklets on the reference shelf in the study area of the library?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, sure."

I readily agreed and picked up the stack of booklets.
…Ugh, it's heavy.

Teacher
"Sorry about this. I appreciate your help."

...Yeah, yeah.

Teacher
"Thank you as always."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Yes."
Female student

"Nozomi, bye-bye!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, bye-bye."
Male student
"Anesaki-san, see you tomorrow!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, see you."
Male student
"Wow, those look heavy. Let me help you."
Female student
"I'll help too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, I'm fine."
Male student
"Are you sure? If you ever need help with anything else, just let me know."
Female student
"Nozomi, you always try to handle everything on your own."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Thank you."

.....
I guess… I've gotten pretty used to acting like this by now…
I'm forcing myself to some extent, but I'm certainly getting something in return for it.
I may have decided to change because of Shun, but in the end, it's benefited me, too.
Shun seems to think it was a bad thing, but I don't feel that way.
Compared to how things used to be, my life now is definitely much better.
And besides…
There are people who know what I'm really like and still accept me.
I think it's because I have that sense of security that I've been able to keep playing the role of "Nozomi Anesaki" without letting the stress build up inside me all this time.

???
"These look... pretty heavy."

A familiar voice suddenly came from beside me.
I turned around, feeling a little nervous, and saw Oshii-kun standing there. He seemed nervous too, as his expression was somewhat stiff.

Yu Oshii
"Where are you taking those?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"The library…"
Yu Oshii
"Perfect, then. I'll give you a hand."

Oshii-kun took half the stack of booklets.

Nozomi Anesaki

"Thank you."
Yu Oshii
"No worries."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…You're so kind, Oshii-kun."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Yu Oshii
"…I'm only kind to you."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Taken at face value, his words sounded almost like a confession of love. They could even be interpreted as revealing some ulterior motive.
But his tone and demeanor conveyed something far more sincere and genuine.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…Shall we go?"
Yu Oshii
"...Yes."

We walked side by side in silence.

Yu Oshii
"…Shun was absent from school today… Is he still feeling sick?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes… He still had a fever this morning."
Yu Oshii
"I see…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Are you okay, Oshii-kun? You got pretty soaked yesterday."
Yu Oshii
"Yes, I'm fine. I'm actually pretty healthy."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see… That's good."
Yu Oshii
"What about you, Senpai? You got even more drenched than I did."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm pretty healthy too."
Yu Oshii
"Is that so..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...We're pretty similar."
Yu Oshii
"...That's true."

The conversation lapsed into silence. There was a slightly awkward air between us.
Still, I didn't feel uncomfortable being here with him.

Chapter 28: My one and only brother

Yu Oshii
"…Where should I put these booklets?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Put them away on that reference shelf."
Yu Oshii
"Got it."

Oshii-kun slid the booklets onto the shelf.

Yu Oshii
"Ow..."

He muttered quietly.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What happened?"
Yu Oshii
"Nothing… I think I cut my finger."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, are you okay?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes. It's really just a tiny cut."

With that, Oshii-kun pulled his hand back as if nothing had happened.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Oshii-kun."
Yu Oshii
"Yes?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're bleeding."
Yu Oshii
"Huh? …Oh, right. It'll probably clot soon."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Doesn't it bother you?"
Yu Oshii
"Not really. It doesn't hurt that much."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Well, it bothers me. Come here for a second."

I beckoned Oshii-kun over and took a Band-Aid out of my bag.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Honestly… Oshii-kun, you're surprisingly careless."
Yu Oshii

"Haha, I hear that pretty often."

.....
…That's exactly what I mean.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I think you're a lot like my dad."
Yu Oshii
"..."

Oshii-kun's expression turned surprised, and he fell silent.
In the meantime, I wrapped a Band-Aid around his fingertips.
His nails were beautifully formed: long and slender, delicate in a way mine weren't. Perhaps he inherited them from our biological mother.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Here you go."
Yu Oshii
"...Thank you."

Once he pulled his hand back, Oshii-kun loosely clenched his fist.

Yu Oshii
"...You also remind me of Mom, in a way."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Yu Oshii
"You may hate the hassle, but you're still always looking out for the people around you..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh... I see."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Silence fell between us as we simply looked at one another.
Are we really alike…? Oshii-kun and I?
…I'm not sure. I don't really feel like we're that similar.
But there was definitely something different about being with him like this. It wasn't the same feeling I had when I was with Shun or anyone else.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Have you come to a conclusion, Oshii-kun?"

I decided to finally address the real issue head-on.
After a long silence, Oshii-kun slowly took a step toward me.

Yu Oshii

"…I spent a lot of time thinking after yesterday."
Yu Oshii
"And honestly, I regretted telling you the truth."
Yu Oshii
"After all, I want everything to stay the way it is. I didn't want the truth to change your life, or put you in a difficult position."
Yu Oshii
"And… I still didn't really understand what these feelings I have for you were."
Yu Oshii
"If I kept hiding the fact that I'm your biological younger brother, maybe someday I'd have a chance to make you mine."
Yu Oshii
"…I was clinging to that possibility in a pretty pathetic way."

Oshii-kun paused for a moment, then took another step toward me.
We were now close enough to touch with just a small reach of the hand.

Yu Oshii
"Can I kiss you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? …Wai—!"

Before I had even a moment to react, Oshii-kun's face drew closer.
Then, at the last possible moment, he stopped. Instead, his arms slipped around my back.
He pulled me into a firm embrace.
The suddenness of it left me frozen in place.

Yu Oshii
"…Yeah. I guess I can't."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Huh…? What…?"
Yu Oshii
"…I think... I finally understand now."

Oshii-kun held me even tighter, then finally spoke, as if he'd gathered his resolve.

Yu Oshii
"More than anything... I want you to accept me as your younger brother."
Yu Oshii
"I don't care if we're strangers as far as society is concerned. I don't care if there's no legal connection between us."
Yu Oshii
"But… I want you, just you, to recognize me as your brother."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki

"…I see…"

Suddenly, I felt as though a clear answer had settled into my mind.
I wasn't sure if I would be able to put it into words properly.
But I decided to tell him honestly what I was feeling.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Oshii-kun."
Yu Oshii
"...Yes?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"To be honest… I still don't really feel like you're my younger brother."
Yu Oshii
"…I understand."
Nozomi Anesaki
"And… I don't want to lose the family life I have now, either."
Yu Oshii
"…Yes. I don't want that either. So… please keep it a secret that I'm your biological brother from now on."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes… I will. But…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I want to tell Shun."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Yu Oshii
"…I see…"

I felt the tension leave Oshii-kun's body.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…Is that… okay?"
Yu Oshii
"…Yes..."

Oshii-kun lightly shook his head, then let out a self-deprecating laugh.

Yu Oshii
"I… have mixed feelings about it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh?"
Yu Oshii
"Part of me is frustrated. I'm jealous of Shun. So many times, I've wished I could be in his place…"
Yu Oshii
"But… at the same… I'm happy. That you'll acknowledge me as your brother…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Even now, I still couldn't truly grasp the reality of it: the person standing before me was my biological younger brother.
And yet, for some reason, I had a premonition. From this point forward, I would surely come to see Oshii-kun as my "little brother."

Yu Oshii
"Senpai."

Once again, Oshii-kun slipped his arms around my back.

Yu Oshii
"Could you call me 'Yu'?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."
Yu Oshii
"Just when we're alone. That's all I ask. …Even once is enough."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"Please."

There was a nervous edge to Oshii-kun's voice. It made me tense up a little too.
It was only a name, yet saying it somehow felt like an incredibly meaningful act.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yu."

I whispered it softly.
Then I timidly wrapped my arms around Oshii-kun's back too.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yu."

This time, I said it clearly.
For a brief moment, I felt Oshii-kun's body tremble ever so slightly.

Yu Oshii
"Big Sister..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Yu Oshii
"Can I call you that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…S-sure…"
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki

"..."
Yu Oshii
"...B-Big Sister..."

He said it in a low, almost inaudible voice.
Even though he was the one who suggested it, he seemed pretty shy. I couldn't help but feel embarrassed too.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yu."
Yu Oshii
"...Y-yes?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It feels… kind of strange, doesn't it?"
Yu Oshii
"…Y-yes, it does…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Could you... say it one more time...?"
Yu Oshii
"Uh..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"..."

He quietly took one deep breath.

Yu Oshii
"Big Sister."

His voice was much more confident this time, and it gradually seeped into my heart.
In that moment, my premonition became a certainty.
I knew that before long, the way I saw Oshii-kun would change.
Oshii—Yu is my one and only younger brother by blood.

Yu Oshii
"...Big Sister."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hm?"
Yu Oshii
"Thank you."

Yu's voice sounded almost tearful.
Though he was larger than me, he somehow seemed incredibly small.
I continued gently rubbing my little brother's back, soothing him as best I could.

Chapter 29: To my special someone

By the time Yu and I parted ways and I left school, it was almost sunset.
Neither of us could bring ourselves to leave, and we ended up talking for quite a while.
I told Shun I'd be home early, though… He was probably sulking by now.
I need to hurry home.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm home."

…It's quiet. Is Shun asleep…?
I stood in front of Shun's room and lightly knocked on the door.
…As I expected, there was no response.
I quietly opened the door and peered into the room.
Shun appeared to be asleep on his bed.
I carefully made my way into the room, doing my best not to make a sound.
…He'd taken his medicine properly. And he'd eaten his jelly, too.
And the bag… Doesn't look like it was used. …That's good.
Does he still have a fever…?
I slowly approached the bed to check on him.
He was sleeping peacefully. He didn't look nearly as pale as before, either.
I slowly reached out my hand and gently touched his forehead.

Shun Anesaki
"?!"

Shun suddenly opened his eyes.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oops, sorry. Did I wake you?"
Shun Anesaki
"Wait, what…? Did I really fall asleep…?"

He rubbed his eyes and sat up.
Looking at his face, I could tell he was feeling much better.

Shun Anesaki
"...When did you get back?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Just now."
Shun Anesaki
"..."

He quickly glanced at the clock by his bedside and for a moment his face twisted into a weird grimace.

He was trying his best not to show it, but it was pretty obvious how he felt.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry, I came back quite late."
Shun Anesaki
"...Huh? Ah, no… it's okay..."

Even as he said it, his expression grew gloomier and gloomier.
Well… he was definitely sulking…
While I was trying to figure out how to cheer him up, he looked away and started mumbling:

Shun Anesaki
"...You were talking with Yu… right…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Right."
Shun Anesaki
"...About what?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Um…"

Where should I even begin?
This was such an important matter that I wasn't sure I could just casually drop it on him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"About Yu himself, actually…"
Shun Anesaki
"...'Yu'?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Oh."

…Damn it, I accidentally called him by his first name.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

At that point, Shun stopped trying to hide his frustration.
I hadn't understood that expression of his before, but now it was perfectly clear to me.
For some reason, this realization made me strangely happy, and I couldn't help grinning—even though it was completely at odds with the mood.

Shun Anesaki
"...Huh… Why are you smiling…?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh… S-sorry, I was just…"
Shun Anesaki
"...Just what? Did you have that much fun with Yu?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…"

He was definitely… jealous, wasn't he…?
What was I supposed to do? This hit me way harder than I'd expected.
I felt like I could roll around on the floor right now.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm sorry, Shun. Please don't be mad."
Shun Anesaki
"...I am not mad at all."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Liar. You are… jealous, aren't you?"
Shun Anesaki
"Wha… HUH?! What are you even talking about, you idiot."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…"
Shun Anesaki
"…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…"
Shun Anesaki
"…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…"
Shun Anesaki
"…AAAH!!! DAMN IT!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, you're right! I'm jealous!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"Where did that come from?! Why are you getting so close to Yu?!"
Shun Anesaki
"You told me you didn't like him, but it was a lie, wasn't it?!"
Shun Anesaki
"I've always loved you, so what am I supposed to do now?!"

Shun blurted it all out in one go and then abruptly turned his face away, breathing heavily.
……
…I couldn't do this.
I felt bad for Shun, but I couldn't stop grinning. My cheeks felt like they were about to burst.
This wasn't the first time I'd been confessed to. In fact, if you count otome games, the number easily exceeded 100.
But this was the first time I felt this fulfilled.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun still wouldn't look at me.
Well… what should I do now? I need to clear up the misunderstanding.
Or should I tell him about Yu first?

I need to reveal that Yu is my biological younger brother… and that there is nothing going on between us…
…No, that seems kind of lengthy.
Let's put the details aside for now; first and foremost, I need to tell him about my feelings.
That would probably be the best way to cheer him up, too.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun."

I called out his name again.
He glared at me with a sullen expression. He seemed really upset.
…There was no other way to fix this… In this situation I should…

Options:
(1) Kiss him.

There was only one option here.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, look at me."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Look at me!"

I held his face between my hands and turned it toward me.

Shun Anesaki
"What are you doing?!"

He yelled.
I took a deep breath, then pulled his face closer.

Shun Anesaki
"!"

Then, in one decisive move, I pressed the option button.

Happy end: My Super Fulfilling Real Life!

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shuuun! If you don't hurry, I'm going to school without you!"
Shun Anesaki
"Ah… wait a second. I'm already done getting ready."

Shun came out of his room. He looked sleepy as usual today.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Here is your lunch. Have you got everything?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Are you feeling all right?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yes."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Am I cute?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."

He gave me a weary look.

Shun Anesaki
"...We're still doing that?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes."
Shun Anesaki
"You could take it a little easier, you know."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm not even trying that hard. It's just a habit now. Besides—"

"I want you to tell me I'm cute."
...Yeah, no.
This is the honest reason, but... There's no way I can actually say that... It'd be so embarrassing.

Shun Anesaki
" 'Besides'?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No. Never mind. ...Well, what do you think? Am I cute?"

He studied me intently.

Shun Anesaki
"...Well, yeah. You're cute."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see. Good."
Shun Anesaki
"...I mean..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"...I-I think you're cute no matter what you do, honestly..."

...Silence.

Nozomi Anesaki
"That was so cheesy…"
Shun Anesaki
"?! Wh-what the heck?! You like this kind of stuff, don't you?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It just feels so out of character."
Shun Anesaki
"…Oh, I see… Damn it… I'm never saying that again…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"B-but… I was happy to hear it."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"C'MON, let's go already!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yeah! Let's go!!!"

…And that's more or less how things went.
As of yesterday, our relationship was no longer just that of "brother and sister."
…It was a little embarrassing to think about.
In front of the school gate, we ran into Shun's usual group of friends.
Yu was with them, too. He looked more at ease than before.

Male student
"Oh, Shun. Feeling better?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."
Male student
"All the girls were super worried about you."
Shun Anesaki
"Ah, I see."
Male student
"I took notes for you while you were gone."
Shun Anesaki
"Seriously? Thanks."

Shun was as popular as ever.

Yu Oshii
"Good morning, Senpai."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, good morning."

As usual, Yu and I walked a step behind Shun and the others.
Shun suddenly turned around. He and Yu silently locked eyes.

There seemed to be a spark of tension between them, but… I decided to tell myself I was imagining it…

Yu Oshii
"…Did you tell Shun?"

Yu quietly asked me after Shun turned back around.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes… Shun was the only one I told."
Yu Oshii
"I see. …How did Shun react?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm… I don't know… He seemed to have mixed feelings about it."

I assured Shun that there was nothing between Yu and me, but he didn't look quite convinced.

Yu Oshii
"Ohh… I see… Is that so? …Haha."

Yu chuckled softly. I wondered what he was thinking.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Did I say something funny?"
Yu Oshii
"No... well, actually… Yes. It is kind of funny."
Yu Oshii
"Maybe my situation isn't so bad. Blood ties are impossible to break, after all."
Yu Oshii
"I might actually have the better deal compared to Shun."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Hahaha…?"

Is that really how it works…?
I wasn't quite sure about the psychology behind it, but Yu looked quite happy, so...
I suppose that's all right.

Male students
"See you later, Miss!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah, see you."

The group of boys slowly wandered off.
However, for some reason, Shun and Yu stayed where they were.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What's up with you two? Aren't you going?"

Yu Oshii
"No… There's still something I'd like to discuss with you."
Shun Anesaki
"Me too."
Shun・Yu
"..."

…Oh… The mood is pretty tense…

Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh… Can this wait until later?"
Shun・Yu
"..."
Yu Oshii
"...What do you think?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh...? Well… I don't mind doing it later..."
Yu Oshii
"Then you can leave."
Shun Anesaki
"Wha…? No way! You leave!"
Yu Oshii
"You said you can wait until later, right?"
Shun Anesaki
"Then what do you need?"
Yu Oshii
"I have something I want to talk to Big Sister about."
Shun Anesaki
"I've got something I want to talk to Sis about, too."
Yu Oshii
"…Don't call her 'Sis.' "
Shun Anesaki
"Fine. 'Nozomi,' then?"
Yu Oshii
"…Don't get too comfortable."
Shun Anesaki
"You're such a pain in the ass."
Yu Oshii
"…Big Sister, what do you even see in this guy?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?!"
Shun Anesaki
"Well, I've got years of memories with her that you don't. It's our history together that matters, not whether we're related by blood."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"…Uh… I didn't think you'd take it so seriously. I'm sorry."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Y-yeah, Yu. Don't take everything Shun says to heart."
Yu Oshii
"...Big Sister..."
Shun Anesaki
"…Why are you taking his side?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You can't keep sulking over every little thing."
Yu Oshii
"…She's so done with you."
Shun Anesaki
"Shut up, you damn siscon!"
Yu Oshii
"Huuh?"

The two of them were already glaring daggers at each other again.
Good grief… It's noisy first thing in the morning.
Looks like my real life is going to be even more fulfilling from now on.

SHUN EPILOGUES

Epilogue 1: Sleepover

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes, welcome!"
Yu Oshii
"...Good evening."

Yu entered hesitantly, looking nervous.
A fairly large bag hung from one of his hands. I figured it contained the clothes he'd need for the day.
Yu's mother—in other words, my biological mother—won't be coming home from work until tomorrow.
After hearing that Yu would be home alone while she was away, I invited him to stay over at my place.

Yu Oshii
"I'm sorry to impose... I'll trouble you for just one night."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ahaha, you don't have to be so formal. Just make yourself at home."
Yu Oshii
"Okay. Thank you for having me."
Shun Anesaki
"...So you've come..."

As I led Yu into the living room, Shun poked his head out from the kitchen.

Shun･Yu
"..."

As soon as they saw each other, the two immediately started shooting each other openly hostile looks. Don't they ever get sick of this?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Come on, you two. How long are you planning to stare each other down?"
Shun Anesaki
"Until Yu stops."
Yu Oshii
"Until Shun stops."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Shun. Enough."
Shun Anesaki
"Huuh, why me?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Because you're the one who started it."
Shun Anesaki
"...Tch."

Shun clicked his tongue, broke eye contact with Yu, and retreated into the kitchen.
I moved closer to Yu and whispered softly into his ear:

Nozomi Anesaki
"Sorry, Yu. Shun is being a jerk, but he doesn't actually hate you."
Yu Oshii
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Actually, earlier today..."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Flour, eggs, cabbage… Oh, and we got some tempura bits too."
Shun Anesaki
"Also green nori and pickled ginger. That should do it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What about the main ingredient? Shrimp like usual, right?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Uh... Let's go with pork."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Aw, I like shrimp more than pork, though. You prefer shrimp too, right?"
Shun Anesaki
"...I do, but..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"? What? Is something wrong?"
Shun Anesaki
"...No... It's just... Yu's having dinner with us tonight, right?"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. He's coming over right before dinner."
Shun Anesaki
"He's... allergic to shrimp, I think."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, really?"
Shun Anesaki
"Back in elementary school, he always left the shrimp dishes untouched at lunch. I got curious and asked him about it, and he told me he was allergic."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ohh... I had no idea!"
Shun Anesaki
"So let's make it pork. He seems to like it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I see, I see. Then let's do that."

Nozomi Anesaki
"...That's what happened."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Funny, right? He's such a typical tsundere."
Shun Anesaki
"Hey."

I hadn't even noticed that Shun was standing right behind me.

Shun Anesaki
"What are you two talking about?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Nothing much, just a little chat."
Shun Anesaki
"Then you don't need to be sitting so close to him."
Yu Oshii
"Jealous?"
Shun Anesaki
"You're so annoying! And you should help with dinner too!!!"
Yu Oshii
"...Sure, I don't mind."
Shun Anesaki
"Wait... Seriously...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Great! Let's all make dinner together."
Shun Anesaki
"You're kidding me."
Yu Oshii
"What should I do?"
Shun Anesaki

"Uh, well... I'll cut the meat, so you can mix all the flour and everything together."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Then I'll get the hot plate ready."

I left the two of them alone and started clearing off the living room table.
Meanwhile, a lively conversation was taking place in the kitchen.

Shun Anesaki
"...Wait, you've never made okonomiyaki before?"
Yu Oshii
"I have."
Shun Anesaki
"Then you know it's too much water?"
Yu Oshii
"Is it? Looks about right to me."
Shun Anesaki
"No, no, that's definitely too much. It says 200 milliliters, you know? Did you even measure it?"
Yu Oshii
"No, I just eyeballed it."
Shun Anesaki
"You idiot. Just follow the recipe. Look, it's right here."
Shun Anesaki
"Here, use this measuring cup. And these measuring spoons, too."
Yu Oshii
"Ugh... What a pain."
Shun Anesaki
"...Forget it. You cut the meat. I'll handle this."
Yu Oshii
"Okay."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"..."
Shun・Yu
"Huh?"
Yu Oshii
"You're eyeballing it too. Use the measuring cup."
Shun Anesaki
"I know what I'm doing. More importantly, who cuts meat like that?"
Yu Oshii
"What's wrong with it?"
Shun Anesaki
"There's plenty wrong with it—ah, whatever. Just leave it."
Yu Oshii
"You're so damn annoying."
Shun Anesaki
"So are you."

.....
W-well... They say that constant bickering is a sign that two people are close.
Everything is fine... probably.

The lively dinner passed in the blink of an eye.
Shun and Yu were constantly trying to one-up each other, as usual, but things never became genuinely hostile or uncomfortable.
I think the two of them are actually incredibly compatible.
So many things got in the way and complicated their relationship, but if they'd met without any baggage between them, I bet they would have ended up as best friends.

Yu Oshii
"Big Sister? Is something wrong?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Yu Oshii
"You seemed kind of spaced out."
Shun Anesaki
"Probably fantasizing again."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wha—no, I wasn't! …Anyway, can I take a bath first?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, go ahead."
Yu Oshii
"Sure."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You guys aren't gonna fight, right? It's getting late, and I don't want to bother the neighbors."
Yu Oshii
"...Don't worry. We'll keep it down. Right?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Yeah, right."
Shun･Yu
"..."

...That mysterious exchange of looks was already pretty ominous.
Well... they'll be fine, right? Surely they're old enough not to get into some big fight.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well then, I'm off to the bath."
Yu Oshii
"Okay."
Shun Anesaki
"Later."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Phew..."

That was a nice soak.
I was planning to get out early today, but I fell into my usual habit and ended up taking a long bath again.
Now then... I wonder what those two are up to.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

No one was in the living room. Where did they go?
As I approached Shun's room, I heard a faint noise coming from inside.
Oh, so that's where they were. Huh, they're actually getting along pretty well.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm done with my bath!"

I opened the door and...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Ugh..."

What is this… suffocating tension...?
I could practically feel an ominous aura emanating from Shun and Yu as they sat in front of the TV.
Apparently, they were playing a video game.

Shun･Yu
"..."

Neither of them said a word. They seemed to be taking it pretty seriously.
They weren't making much noise in real life, but the two characters on the screen were clashing violently, blood streaming from their wounds. It was kind of surreal.

Shun Anesaki
"...Shit!!!"

Eventually, Shun dropped the controller, clearly frustrated.

Shun Anesaki
"That was unfair!"
Yu Oshii
"It wasn't against the rules."
Shun Anesaki
"It was against the spirit of the game!"
Yu Oshii
"You're being too loud. Big Sister told us to keep it quiet, remember?"
Shun Anesaki
"Wha—"
Nozomi Anesaki

"All right, that's enough. Keep it down."
Shun・Yu
"?!"

When I stepped between them, the two of them finally seemed to notice me.

Yu Oshii
"Big Sister, when did you—"
Yu Oshii
"Wh-what are you wearing?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

I glanced down at my outfit, prompted by his reaction.
There was nothing unusual about it. A camisole and hot pants. Typical summer attire. You get the idea.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...I guess I do look pretty sloppy...?"
Yu Oshii
"That's not the issue...!"
Shun Anesaki
"Uh... Yu, I get what you're saying, but this is pretty much her default outfit."
Yu Oshii
"Huh... What?! She dresses like this all the time?!"
Shun Anesaki
"During summer, yeah. Sometimes she even sleeps with her stomach completely exposed."
Yu・Nozomi
"Really?!"

I had no idea. God, that's embarrassing.

Yu Oshii
"A-anyway, this is not okay!!! Please change your clothes!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"You're being way too loud. Calm down."
Yu Oshii
"How are you okay with this?!"
Shun Anesaki
"I'm used to it by now."
Yu Oshii
"...Are you a monk or something?"
Shun Anesaki
"Don't call me that... Even I can only take so much..."
Yu Oshii
" 'Only take so much'...? What?"
Shun Anesaki
"Don't glare at me... You know how I feel..."

Yu Oshii
"D-don't tell me you've already...?"
Shun Anesaki
"?! No! I-I haven't done anything!!!"
Yu Oshii
"If you ever do, I'll seriously kill you!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"Huuh?! Th-that's impossible!!! Think about it!!! We live together, you know?! Just the two of us!!!"
Yu Oshii
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Don't look at me like that! This is hard enough as it is!!!"
Yu Oshii
"You're a monk, right? Surely you can control yourself."
Shun Anesaki
"I can't! Honestly, it's torture every day!!!"

.....

Nozomi Anesaki
"Guys...?"
Shun・Yu
"Oh."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Do you always talk about this kind of thing in front of girls? Aren't you being a little too candid?"
Shun・Yu
"..."

Apparently, it finally dawned on them what they had been saying. Shun and Yu both went bright red, stumbling over their words before finally falling silent.
...Well, that's something.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm not going to wear this anymore..."
Yu Oshii
"...Good. Please do so."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"...You were kind of disappointed, weren't you?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huuh? I-I wasn't thinking anything like that!"
Shun・Yu
"..."
Yu Oshii
"...Let's play again. If I beat you, you have to be a monk for the rest of your life."

Shun Anesaki
"That's a ridiculous condition. But whatever. I'm gonna win anyway."

The two turned back to the screen, their eyes dead serious. The fact that they can get so worked up over something like this just goes to show that they really are on the same wavelength.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Take it easy, you two."

With that, I quietly left Shun's room.
I decided to leave these two boys to their own devices, and...
…Go cuddle with Lord Wald!
When I glanced at the clock, it was almost midnight. I'd gotten completely absorbed in the game.
I wonder if Shun and Yu are still playing... It's awfully quiet in the next room, though…
I quietly peeked into Shun's room.
The game was still on, and Shun was lying sprawled out on the floor. ...It looked like he'd fallen asleep.
Yu was nowhere to be seen. Maybe he went to the bathroom?

Yu Oshii
"Big Sister."

I heard Yu's voice from behind me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, Yu. Did you just get out of the bath?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes. Shun... is he asleep? Should I wake him up?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, leave him. Shun's absolutely awful when he wakes up, so it would just be a pain."
Yu Oshii
"...Haha, I see."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You guys have been playing games this whole time?"
Yu Oshii
"Well... yes. ...I'm sorry."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Yu Oshii
"I lost to Shun..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh... Aah..."

Oh, right, that. So Shun won, huh?

Yu Oshii

"He was really going all out for that match. He must have really wanted it..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Really wanted it, huh..."

Honestly, that guy...

Yu Oshii
"...Well... I suppose it's fine."

Yu muttered with a look of resignation.

Yu Oshii
"Ah, no... I mean, don't get me wrong, it's just..."
Yu Oshii
"...He's not a bad guy, after all."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

I was surprised. It was pretty rare to see Yu get all soft on Shun.

Yu Oshii
"...I think... I might've… misunderstood Shun."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hm?"
Yu Oshii
"Maybe I'd been so fixated on him all this time that I just convinced myself he was a complete jerk."
Yu Oshii
"Or I guess… I needed him to be."
Yu Oshii
"But... after spending the day with him, I realized he's... w-well, a better guy than I thought..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Yu Oshii
"...As much as I hate to admit it... I guess I can understand why you fell in love with him."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...I see..."
Yu Oshii
"...I had a really good time today."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You did?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes. ...I found myself wondering... if our parents hadn't gotten divorced, maybe I could've spent time with you like this."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah... I've thought about that too."

If our parents had never divorced, and I had grown up in the same household as Yu...

I wonder what our relationship would be like now.

Yu Oshii
"...But I think it worked out okay this way, too."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. I think so too."

No matter how things came to be, I'm able to be with Yu now as his biological sister.
I think there's a lot I gained from growing up the way I did.

Yu Oshii
"At least I'm really happy now."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Me too."

As we both laughed softly, an utterly incongruous game soundtrack kept playing in the background.

Yu Oshii
"It doesn't seem like Shun's going to wake up anytime soon, so I'll turn off the TV."
Nozomi Anesaki
"It's pretty late. Maybe we should go to bed too."
Yu Oshii
"I agree. Where should I sleep?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, right. I'll get the futon out for you."
Yu Oshii
"No, really, you don't need to go through all that trouble. I'm fine sleeping wherever. The floor will do."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm... Oh, then you can use Shun's bed."
Yu Oshii
"Huh? Is that really okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Of course. I doubt Shun's going to wake up until tomorrow. I'll just cover him with a blanket."
Yu Oshii
"Let's do that then."

I pulled the blanket over Shun, and he stirred, turning over in his sleep.
...Just as I expected, he showed no sign of waking.
Yu and I shared a quiet smile, then softly whispered "Good night" to each other.

Yu Oshii
"Thank you for having me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Come over anytime."
Yu Oshii
"Of course..."

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Is something wrong?"
Yu Oshii
"No... I was just thinking... I hope someday there'll come a day when I can invite you over to my place."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Yeah. I hope so, too."

Not right now, but someday. Surely.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Someday."
Yu Oshii
"...Yes."
Shun Anesaki
"Hey..."

Shun slowly stepped in between us.

Shun Anesaki
"I'm here too, you know."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I know."
Yu Oshii
"Don't get jealous."
Shun Anesaki
"I'm not jealous!"
Yu Oshii
"Well, I'll get going."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. Bye!"
Yu Oshii
"Goodbye. See you too, Shun."
Shun Anesaki
"...Yeah. See ya."

Yu gave us a little wave and headed out.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun was still wearing a sullen expression.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What are you so mad about?"
Shun Anesaki
"...My body hurts."
Nozomi Anesaki

"Well, you were sleeping on the floor."
Shun Anesaki
"Because Yu was using the bed."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You were already asleep. What else could I have done?"
Shun Anesaki
"...I was awake."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? You were?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Yeah. I woke up while you and Yu were talking."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh, you should have said something."
Shun Anesaki
"...It didn't exactly feel like a good time to interrupt."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Really?"

Were we talking about something weird?
...Oh, come to think of it, Yu said a lot of nice things about Shun.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Were you embarrassed?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well, Yu said you were actually a pretty decent guy, remember?"
Shun Anesaki
"Ah... That... It kinda weirded me out."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're unbelievable..."
Shun Anesaki
"...That's not what I meant anyway..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm?"
Shun Anesaki
"Seeing the two of you together like that... you genuinely feel like actual siblings."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, really?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah. ...I can't really explain it... It's like you're in your own little world that I can't step into."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh...?"

Is that how it seems? I can't really tell myself.

Shun Anesaki
"And that made me feel a little... jealous."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Jealous?"
Shun Anesaki
"Of Yu's position."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What's that supposed to mean? You want to be my blood-related brother?"
Shun Anesaki
"No, that'd be a problem. But... Yu has something I don't, and that's unfair."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're so greedy."
Shun Anesaki
"...Hey. If anything, this is your fault for being all lovey-dovey with him all the time."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What? This is perfectly normal."
Shun Anesaki
"It's not! You're always so close to him. I've hardly ever even gotten that close to you myself..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...So you want to be closer?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh...? No... uh... Yes. No..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Which is it?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Would it be okay?"

Shun hesitantly took a step closer.
The way he put it… made me strangely nervous.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...N-no."

I instinctively stepped back.
Why is that...? I can be close to Yu without giving it a second thought, but with Shun, everything feels different...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...That's indecent."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"It sounded kinda lewd, so no!"
Shun Anesaki
"Huuh?! I-I'm not gonna do anything, especially not this early in the morning!"

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-what are you implying?! It wouldn't be okay at night either...!"
Shun Anesaki
"How long am I supposed to be a monk...? I already won the game, too..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"H-how would I know...?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...What about a kiss? No…?"

He looked up at me and asked timidly. Damn... Is he doing it on purpose…? No, it doesn't seem so… Crap... This is exactly why I can't stand the younger brother-archetype…

Nozomi Anesaki
"...N-no..."
Shun Anesaki
"Why?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Just because."
Shun Anesaki
"We already did it once, so it's fine, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Th-that was just spur of the moment! Right now, it just feels... wrong...!"
Shun Anesaki
"When would it be okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I don't know... Next time...?"
Shun Anesaki
"When's 'next time'?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Someday...?"
Shun Anesaki
"When's 'someday'?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Who knows...?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun's disappointment was written all over his face.
S-sometime... Sometime soon.
Probably. Right... soon.

Epilogue 2: Brother Spiral

Nozomi Anesaki
"So, now you substitute the answer from earlier."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Got it?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Hey, are you listening?"
Shun Anesaki
"I'm listening... I am, but..."

Shun tossed his mechanical pencil aside in exasperation.

Shun Anesaki
"I'm sick of math already."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Already...? Honestly, you..."
Shun Anesaki
"It's not interesting. And it's hard."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Come on... This is practically the basics. How is this hard?"
Shun Anesaki
"It's hard."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...You are just not putting any effort, are you?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."

Got you, huh?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Get it together. Otherwise, you're going to start failing regularly."

For the record, at our school, a failing grade is defined as scoring half or less of the grade average.
Since most of the students here are pretty diligent, the average scores naturally tend to be on the high side.
That makes the cutoff particularly harsh for students who got in through the sports program, as well as the small number of unmotivated students like Shun.

Shun Anesaki
"...*Sigh*... Seriously, why can't everyone just chill out...? Like really... Please lower the failing-grade cutoff..."

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Honestly, why did you even choose to come to this school?"

Shun's grades weren't particularly good back in middle school, either.
Despite that, around the summer of his third year, he suddenly said that he was going to attend the same high school as me.
Honestly, I didn't think he had a chance. In fact, I assumed he was kidding.
But he started studying for real after that, and, incredibly, he passed the entrance exams.
And then, once he entered the school...
The serious, cool Shun I'd seen during exam season vanished in an instant.
I honestly have no idea what he was trying to accomplish.
It wasn't like he wanted to get into a good university and land a good job... at least, it certainly didn't look that way.
If that had been his goal, he'd have kept studying after getting into high school.
So what was it, then? Showing off? Did he just want the prestige of getting into a competitive school?
Hmm... That doesn't really feel right, either. Shun doesn't seem like the kind of person who'd care about something like that.
...Then what was it?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Was it just because of me?"

I teased him.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

.....
What?

Nozomi Anesaki
"No way..."
Shun Anesaki
"...So what if it was? Is that bad?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No... No, of course not..."

It's not like I had a problem with it or anything...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...S-so, does that mean..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You... already liked me... back then...?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...I-I dunno..."

Shun looked away and nervously picked up his mechanical pencil.

Shun Anesaki
"...I'll study."
Nozomi Anesaki
"R-right. Then... try solving all the problems on this page on your own."
Shun Anesaki
"Got it."

Shun started working through the problems in silence.
The room suddenly became quiet, and I found myself feeling a little awkward.
In times like this… That's right. I should play a game and get us back to our usual rhythm.
I stretched out on the bed and turned on my handheld console.
Shun looked up and shot me a suspicious glance.

Shun Anesaki
"Huh...? What are you doing?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm going to play a game. I've got nothing to do while you're working on the problems. It looks like it's going to take you a while."
Shun Anesaki
"You... Well, it's fine, I guess..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Let me know when you're done. I'll check your answers."
Shun Anesaki
"Okay."

.....
Hehe.
.....
Rustle. Rustle.

Shun Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...You never get tired of that, do you...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Got a problem with it? Anyway, I'm kissing Lord Wald right now, so don't interrupt me. Focus on your studying."
Shun Anesaki
"...Fine, okay..."

Shun Anesaki
"Sis. I'm done."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki

"...Sis?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Wait, are you asleep?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...No way, she really is..."
Shun Anesaki
(So what do I do now...? Wake her up?)
Shun Anesaki
(...Jeez... she's sleeping all nice and cozy in my bed...)
Shun Anesaki
(What is she thinking...? Is she doing this on purpose?)
Shun Anesaki
(Well, actually... She's always been like this... Maybe she still thinks of me as her little brother...)
Shun Anesaki
(Besides, even when we're together in a room, all we ever do is study... This is ridiculous.)
Shun Anesaki
(And she said we'd kiss "sometime"... When the hell is "sometime"? I'm sick of having to be a monk...)
Shun Anesaki
(...)
Shun Anesaki
(A-a kiss... That's not a big deal, right...?)
Shun Anesaki
(It's not even our first time... She's the one who kissed me first, anyway...)
Shun Anesaki
(She doesn't actually mind, right? So it's okay, right…?)
Shun Anesaki
(Just a little...)
Shun Anesaki
(...)
Shun Anesaki
(...Ah...)
Shun Anesaki
(Crap... I don't think I'm gonna be able to stop...)

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Lord Wald..."
Wald
"Hm...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Kiss me some more..."
Wald
"Of course, *my sweet princess*..."

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Lord Wa—mm."

.....
Hm?

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."

.....
Uh...
WHAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAT?!

Nozomi Anesaki
"What the heck are you doing?!"
Shun Anesaki
"BWAH?!"

I reacted without thinking and slapped Shun hard across the face. He'd been practically nose-to-nose with me.
Suddenly, the strange sensation on my lips disappeared.
...Th-this wasn't a dream... was it...?
I-I... Shun and I...

Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

I rubbed my eyes.

Shun Anesaki
"Did you really just slap me?!"

Shun sat up, his eyes welling with tears.
The spot where I slapped him was bright red. It looked like it really hurt.

Nozomi Anesaki
"S-sorry, Shun... But it was your fault...!"
Shun Anesaki
"I-it's not like it was a big deal... It was just a kiss...!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Who kisses someone while they're asleep?!"
Shun Anesaki

"...B-but... I couldn't resist..."

Shun sheepishly looked away.
...Wait! No way...!
I hurriedly checked myself, but Shun immediately started waving his hands frantically.

Shun Anesaki
"...N-no! I didn't do anything else! I swear! I just kissed you! That's all!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I see..."

Phew... that's good...
...Wait, no, that's not good at all.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You can't just do things like that without asking."
Shun Anesaki
"...What are you complaining about...? You did the same thing to me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"!!! B-but that was different…! It just happened on the spur of the moment...!"
Shun Anesaki
"Well, I got caught up in the moment too."

...Jeez, now he's acting like he did nothing wrong.

Nozomi Anesaki
"W-well... just this once, okay?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Can I do it one more time?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"

Shun leaned toward me.
I reflexively recoiled.

Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no."
Shun Anesaki
"Huuh? Why not? We might as well at this point. It's all the same no matter how many times we do it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...It's not the same!"
Shun Anesaki
"You've kissed Lord Wald plenty of times."

Nozomi Anesaki
"Th-that doesn't count! That's completely different..."
Shun Anesaki
"So who do you like more? Me or Lord Wald?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Hey, don't hesitate like that..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Wellllll..."

3D and 2D are different things, right? Yeah.

Shun Anesaki
"...So... you don't want to kiss me?"

Once again, he was asking me a question I really didn't know how to answer.
To be honest, I didn't hate the idea.
Not at all. I really didn't... but...
Being in this kind of situation with an actual person was just way too embarrassing...! And with Shun of all people, even more so!

Shun Anesaki
"...Whatever. I'm doing it."

Shun moved even closer, as though he's finally run out of patience.
...His eyes are serious. Looks like I just have to brace myself for this.
O-okay... I can do this... I'm ready whenever you are...
Come on… Bring it on...!

Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"...Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...What?!"
Shun Anesaki
"...Uh... could you at least close your eyes...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh...? O-oh, right..."

Oops... I slipped into my usual habit of staring at Lord Wald...

Nozomi Anesaki
"...O-okay. Just do it already...!"
Shun Anesaki
"...You're not making this very sexy..."
Shun Anesaki
"Oh well…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

Something warm and soft touched my lips.
Even though it wasn't my first time, the sensation felt strangely new.
Actually... considering how eager he seemed, he's surprisingly gentle... almost restrained.
It's... genuinely... kind of nice...
Just as I thought that, Shun suddenly pulled away.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, that's it...?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."

O-oh crap... I can't believe I just said something like that...!

Shun Anesaki
"...What, you want more?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"N-not really..."
Shun Anesaki
"Oh, really? But if you want to, I'm not stopping you."

Look at him getting all cocky... He's totally the one who wants another kiss... Jeez...

Shun Anesaki
"...Shall we?"

With a smug grin, Shun moved his face closer.
Oh, that annoys me.
Fine, if that's how we're playing this...

Nozomi Anesaki
"Take this!"
Shun Anesaki
"?!"

I pulled Shun's face toward me and pressed my lips against his.

It's only the second time I've initiated a kiss myself, but it's still so satisfying watching Shun get all flustered.
So... just a little longer.

Shun Anesaki
"...!"

I gently caught his lip between mine, and Shun's shoulders trembled.
...Okay... that's enough...
Satisfied, I started pulling away… but Shun immediately leaned toward me, as if trying to stop me from leaving.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Mhm."

Our lips came together once more.
We pulled apart, then kissed again. And again.
A succession of kisses, each a little more forceful than the last.
Even though we were only touching lips, my breathing was already growing slightly uneven.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Shun... wait a moment..."

I somehow managed to speak in the brief moment our lips parted.
But he immediately covered my lips again, leaving me with no choice but to simply let him take the lead.
What should I do...? I'm completely at his mercy.
I desperately clutched the hem of Shun's shirt to keep myself steady.
I was starting to run out of breath, and a little sigh slipped out.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun suddenly stopped.
Then he abruptly drew away from me, almost recoiling.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Huh...?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Are we done?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun made a sour face, mumbling awkwardly.

Shun Anesaki

"...I-I want more...! I really do, but..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Y-yeah...?"
Shun Anesaki
"...It's just... Um... I'm seriously at my limit here..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"...? Limit...?"
Shun Anesaki
"..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

...Ah.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...I see..."
Shun Anesaki
"..."

Shun just nodded silently.
I quietly got off the bed.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...I-I'm going to bed now..."
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, you should..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Good night. We'll continue tomorrow."
Shun Anesaki
"...Huh?!"

Shun's voice cracked in surprise.

Shun Anesaki
"Continue?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah."
Shun Anesaki
"Really?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh... seriously...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yes...?"
Shun Anesaki
"Are you sure...?"

He gave me a skeptical look.
What's that...? What exactly are you expecting...?
.....
Ah!

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm talking about continuing our studying, you idiot!!!"
Shun Anesaki
"That's what you meant?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Obviously...!"
Shun Anesaki
"...Ugh... I'm the fool for expecting anything else..."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Don't get your hopes up."

Shun bit his lip impatiently, looking frustrated.

Shun Anesaki
"...When would it be okay?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Wh-who knows?"

Shun looked visibly disappointed.
S-sometime... Eventually.
Probably. Just... not quite yet.

Epilogue 3: Little Brother Paradise

It was noon on a holiday.
I sat in the living room eating lunch, a faint sense of anticipation making me restless.
Though I knew it was pointless, I kept glancing at the clock every minute while listening for signs of what was happening outside. It would soon be time to hear that familiar engine roar.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis."

A voice suddenly called out to me, pulling my attention away from the clock. I turned to face him.
Shun was watching me closely, a look of confusion on his face.

Shun Anesaki
"What's wrong?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Shun Anesaki
"You've been acting kind of restless for a while."

Nozomi Anesaki
"…Have I?"

…Crap. I guess I'd been making it a little too obvious.

Shun Anesaki
"Is something going on?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, not really."

I decided to play dumb.
I could have simply told him, "I'm waiting for a delivery," but I didn't feel like having him question me about it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun, you're already finished eating, aren't you? Why don't you just go back to your room?"

I was eager to get Shun out of the way, and it made me blurt out something colder than I intended.
Of course, I knew he wasn't the sort of person who would get angry or upset over something like that.
Sure enough, Shun just grimaced slightly and—

Shun Anesaki
"Hey, now… Is that any way to talk to your boyfriend?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."

There it was again. His "boyfriend" card.
I could tell he wasn't happy about how little had changed between us since we started dating.
Still, I pretended not to notice and turned my eyes back to the clock.
In my mind, Shun was still more of a younger brother than a lover. I simply didn't know how to create a romantic mood between us, let alone how I was supposed to behave as his girlfriend.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?"
Shun Anesaki
"Wanna go somewhere today?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No."
Shun Anesaki
"Why not?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Because I'm busy today."

Shun Anesaki
"Really?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah."
Shun Anesaki
"Doesn't look like it. You've been lazing around in the living room this whole time."
Nozomi Anesaki
"So have you."

Ideally, I'd like Shun to go back to his room as soon as possible.
…No. Better yet.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Why don't you just go out on your own, Shun?"
Shun Anesaki
"…Why are you trying so hard to get me out of here?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I have something I want to concentrate on today."

All I wanted was some uninterrupted time to properly focus on one particular thing.

Shun Anesaki
"Games, huh?"

His sharp guess made me visibly flinch.

Nozomi Anesaki
"N-no! Studying!"

I somehow managed to deny it, but Shun narrowed his eyes, clearly unimpressed.
…If he figured me out now, the whole thing would unravel.

Shun Anesaki
"You're so fidgety because you're waiting for a package, huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"You got yourself a new game."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"So that's why you haven't been talking about Lord Wald lately."
Nozomi Anesaki
"..."
Shun Anesaki
"Have you already moved on from him?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No! That's not it…!"

What a horrible thing to say.
As if I could ever get tired of Lord Wald...
…Well, I suppose I can't deny that my enthusiasm has cooled off a little lately.
But I still love him dearly.
If the official account drops some new content, I'll be right back to being obsessed.

Shun Anesaki
"Well, I figured you'd probably get tired of him sooner or later."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I told you, I'm not tired of him!"
Shun Anesaki
"So, who's the next boyfriend candidate? A student council president? A samurai? A Demon King? An alien?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…None of those."

I answered curtly and shifted my gaze back to the clock.
The minute hand was agonizingly slow.
If I let my conversation with Shun continue, he would surely start digging for answers, and I might end up blurting out something I shouldn't.
And what would happen after that…? I didn't even want to think about it.
Ugh, I wish the delivery would just get here already.
...And just then, I heard the engine of a delivery truck approaching.

Nozomi Anesaki
"It's here!"

For some reason, Shun stood up at the exact same time I did.
I shot him a questioning look. He turned around as he opened the living room door.

Shun Anesaki
"I'll get it."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…Why?"
Shun Anesaki
"Take a look at what you're wearing."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Ah..."

Come to think of it, I haven't even changed yet.
I was wearing a worn-out camisole and hot pants, and my hair was still a complete mess.
I certainly couldn't let someone else see me in such a state. How careless of me…

Nozomi Anesaki
"…Okay, you can get it… But don't you dare open it yourself."
Shun Anesaki
"I won't."

As soon as Shun left the living room, the doorbell rang.
After a brief exchange, I heard the delivery person depart with a cheerful farewell.
I waited for the right moment and hurried to the entrance, where I found Shun holding an A4-sized envelope.

Nozomi Anesaki
"All right, hand it over."

I held out my hand toward Shun.
But Shun made no move to give it to me, merely looking at me with a stern expression.

Shun Anesaki
"Something about this… feels weird…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Shun Anesaki
"This is an otome game, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh… y-yeah. It is. Why?"
Shun Anesaki
"Can I take a look too?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No."

I answered immediately, and a look of certainty appeared on Shun's face.

Shun Anesaki
"Yeah, something's definitely off."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…What is?"
Shun Anesaki
"You always give me the full rundown whenever you buy a new game."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh..."

Did I really…?
…Oh. Yeah.
I might have gone on about how beautiful the cover art was, rambled about how ridiculously handsome all the romanceable characters were while looking through the manual, and even shared my predictions for who'd become my favorite…

Shun Anesaki
"Don't tell me…"

I flinched.

Shun Anesaki

"…Is it an adult game?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"H-huuh?!"

That's what you thought?!

Nozomi Anesaki
"What are you talking about? They don't even sell those to minors...!"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh. So I was wrong."
Nozomi Anesaki
"You were…! It's just a perfectly wholesome—"

…I couldn't exactly say that. If I remembered correctly, the game had a CERO C (15+) rating.
There might be some fairly suggestive content in it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well… anyway, it's not that kind of game."
Shun Anesaki
"Hmm… then why are you hiding it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"I-I..."

I hesitated.
The truth was simply that I was embarrassed. But if he asked me why I was embarrassed, I had no idea how I would answer.
Besides, the fact that I was going this far to hide it was starting to make me feel like I was making a bigger deal out of it than I should.
It is just one of many otome games. It holds no special meaning for me whatsoever.
There is nothing I have to be ashamed of. I should just be open about it.

Nozomi Anesaki
"…If you want to see it, you can."
Shun Anesaki
"Oh, really? Then I will."

Shun nodded readily and immediately started opening the envelope.
The sound of paper tearing echoed through the entryway.
As I listened, embarrassment and regret slowly crept over me.
…N-no, it's fine. This is no big deal.
It's just a completely normal otome game, that's all—

Shun Anesaki
"Little Brother Paradise."

Shun read.
I thought I was going to die.

The title was ridiculously on the nose, which made the game easy to find, but now I had a bone to pick with the developers.
Why would they give it a title like that? Could they have at least tried to be a little less shameless?

Nozomi Anesaki
"Uwaaaaaahhh!!!"

I completely lost my composure and snatched the package right out of Shun's hands.
Fine. I give up. I might as well admit it.
I was positively drowning in guilt.

Shun Anesaki
"Hoooo?"

Shun came closer with a smug grin on his face.
I wanted nothing more than to crawl into a hole and disappear. Or better yet, bury Shun in one.

Shun Anesaki
"I thought you weren't into the younger-brother archetype?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"…I-I'm exploring new territory…"
Shun Anesaki
"So that's what you meant by 'studying.' "
Nozomi Anesaki
"Guh…"

My embarrassment finally reached its breaking point. I hugged the game tightly to my chest and spun around.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I'm going to play my game, so don't come into my room! Little Brother Paradise is awesome…!"

I yelled in sheer embarrassment and bolted up the stairs.
Shun's amused laughter followed close behind.

Shun Anesaki
"Once you've played it, I want to see what you learned!"

…There was no mistaking it. Shun knew exactly what CERO C meant when he said that.
You little pervert… I grumbled inwardly as I closed the door to my room.

SHUN FANBOOK

Epilogue 4: Moon viewing

My eyes wandered toward the window.
A brilliant silver full moon hung clearly against the deep-blue sky.
Oh, right. Today was the Moon Viewing Festival.
With the clear skies and fine weather, it was a perfect night for the occasion.
On a whim, I left my room and knocked on the door right next to mine.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Shun?"
Shun Anesaki
"What?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Can I come in?"
Shun Anesaki
"Go ahead."

I opened the door and peeked inside.
Surprisingly, Shun was sitting at his desk, busily writing in his notebook.
I won't mention that my first reaction was to think, *That's weird,* rather than be impressed.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Homework?"
Shun Anesaki
"Preparing for class. I've got a feeling the teacher's gonna call on me tomorrow."

Shun answered without even looking up, then grudgingly opened his English-Japanese dictionary.
He seemed unusually focused, so I figured I'd better not disturb him.
I was about to quietly leave when...

Shun Anesaki
"Wait."

Shun stopped what he was doing and turned around.

Shun Anesaki
"You came in here for a reason, didn't you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No, it's really nothing important."
Shun Anesaki
"It might be important to me."

…I had a feeling he was expecting something from me.

Feeling somewhat apologetic, I spoke with an air of complete nonchalance.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Well, it's the Moon Viewing Festival today."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? Oh, is it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah. The full moon is really clear tonight, so I was thinking maybe we could go outside and admire it for a while."
Shun Anesaki
"Oh…"

He looked disappointed, like, "That's it?"
That was why I said it wasn't anything important. Though honestly, I had no idea what he'd been expecting anyway.

Nozomi Anesaki
"That's all. Sorry for interrupting your studying."

I was finally about to leave when I heard some movement behind me.
Shun had left his schoolwork on the desk and was slipping on his jacket.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What about your studying?"
Shun Anesaki
"Break time."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…We're just going to look at the moon, okay? Nothing else."
Shun Anesaki
"I get it. Jeez, what do you take me for?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"A perpetually horny monkey."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh?!"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yu said that."
Shun Anesaki
"…That bastard…"

A long, quiet pause.

Shun Anesaki
"…Can I hold your hand?"

…Well, I suppose I don't mind that much.
We climbed to a hilltop within walking distance of home and looked up at the sky.
I had to admit, after going all the way outside to see it, the moon didn't look all that different from how it had from inside my room.

Still, I invited Shun out because I was looking for a small change in our otherwise uneventful everyday lives.
It was me who was secretly hoping for something more.

Shun Anesaki
"The air feels nice."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah."
Shun Anesaki
"It's so quiet."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Yeah."

Silence settled in.
The chorus of insects.
The soft rustle of grass stirred by the wind.
Just one step beyond the confines of home, and the world surrounding us transforms completely.

Shun Anesaki
"The moon sure is beautiful."

Shun murmured, narrowing his eyes in the moon's silvery glow.
I had a feeling that this ordinary moment was becoming something special.
I held my breath and gazed at his profile, and then...

Shun Anesaki
"I'm getting hungry."

...Huh?

Nozomi Anesaki
"…What was that?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No... never mind... what else did I expect..."

It was very unlikely that Shun knew about Natsume Sōseki's famous anecdote. And even if he did, I couldn't imagine him pulling off something so sentimental.
Regretting that I'd gotten my hopes up for even a second, I let myself sink back into our ordinary world.
I relaxed.

Shun Anesaki
"...Ah!"

Suddenly, Shun brought a hand to his mouth.

Even in the soft, misty moonlight, I could make out the faint flush spreading across his face.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Uh, wh-what? What's gotten into you all of a sudden?"
Shun Anesaki
"W-well… about earlier…"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh?"
Shun Anesaki
"That whole 'the moon is beautiful' thing…"

I froze.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You knew about it…?"
Shun Anesaki
"…It's pretty famous."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Right..."

…Thank goodness. Turns out he was more cultured than I expected.

Shun Anesaki
"But I didn't mean it like that earlier."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I know that."
Shun Anesaki
"You were blushing though."
Nozomi Anesaki
"I was not."

I kept a firm front, determined not to let Shun get the upper hand.
I felt like I'd lose the moment I looked at his face, so I busied myself with admiring the full moon instead.
I was afraid of letting him see how much power he had over me.

Shun Anesaki
"Sis."
Nozomi Anesaki
"What?"
Shun Anesaki
"Look at me."
Nozomi Anesaki
"…No."
Shun Anesaki
"Why not?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"No reason."

Our conversation trailed off.
The silvery light seared itself into my eyes, leaving a lingering afterimage behind my closed eyelids.

Shun Anesaki
"How would you translate it?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"...Translate what?"
Shun Anesaki
"You know, the kind of thing Natsume Sōseki was talking about."
Nozomi Anesaki
" 'I could die happy.' "
Shun Anesaki
"That's Futabatei Shimei*."
*Both Sōseki and Futabatei Shimei are associated with famous, indirect literary expressions of romantic love.
Nozomi Anesaki
"I can't believe you actually know that…"
Shun Anesaki
"Don't underestimate a Sasajiin High student."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Look at you, getting all cocky."

The words came more easily now.
Being back in our familiar rhythm made me feel safe.

Nozomi Anesaki
"How would you translate it, Shun?"

I turned to look at him.

Shun Anesaki
"..."

His hand tightened around mine.
A perfect circle appeared in my darkened vision.
The faint scent of a familiar shampoo lingered for a moment before softly fading away.
Neither of us said anything.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...That's way too direct."
Shun Anesaki
"…That's the way you prefer it, right?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Coming from you… it's completely out of character."
Shun Anesaki
"Just get used to it already."

Shun leaned in toward me again.
Thinking he was about to bite me, I recoiled, but he stopped at the last moment, narrowing his eyes in annoyance.
It was a dangerous look. I could feel my resolve slipping.

Nozomi Anesaki
"You know… Shun…"
Shun Anesaki
"…What?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"You're more of a wolf than a monkey…"
Shun Anesaki
"It's a full moon, after all."

Epilogue 5: Christmas Eve

(Shun's POV)
It's not that I didn't have plans. I had somewhere to be, too.
Even so, there was something strangely lonely about walking around outside by myself on the night of December 24th.
Amid streets adorned with Christmas lights, I hurried into a convenience store, passing noisy groups of students, couples, and families enjoying the evening together.
I made my way toward the back of the store and stopped as soon as I turned the corner.
...Just my luck. I found the last person I wanted to deal with.
As I hesitated over what to say, he noticed me as well and openly grimaced.
That pissed me off.
Still, when he narrows his eyes like that, his expression bears a slight resemblance to Sis's, leaving me with complicated feelings.

Shun Anesaki
"Yo."

Figuring I should at least say hello, I casually raised a hand, and Yu turned to face me with a resigned look
Still, I doubt he genuinely hates me. I don't hate him, either.

Yu Oshii
"Shun... what are you doing here?"
Shun Anesaki
"I just came to do some shopping."

I showed him a bottle of sparkling juice.

Shun Anesaki
"What about you?"
Yu Oshii

"I'm shopping too."

Yu was carrying a basket with one meal and a drink inside.
This struck me as odd.
For a moment I hesitated to ask, but I couldn't see any reason to tiptoe around him like that.

Shun Anesaki
"That's your dinner for tonight?"
Yu Oshii
"Yeah. My mom's away on a business trip and won't be back until the day after tomorrow."

He answered everything I wanted to ask in one go with remarkable precision.
There was no self-deprecation or snarkiness in his response, so I figured he simply wanted to give me a thorough response.
He's sharp and rather detached.

Shun Anesaki
"So you're gonna be home alone tonight?"
Yu Oshii
"Pretty much."
Shun Anesaki
"You should've gone to the class party."
Yu Oshii
"An all-night karaoke session? Really?"
Shun Anesaki
"...I guess it's not your kind of thing."

An all-nighter aside, I can't imagine this guy singing at all.

Yu Oshii
"You not going is unusual though."
Shun Anesaki
"Well..."
Yu Oshii
"I guess you've got Big Sister around."

Ah, that sounded pretty snide. Kind of annoying.

Yu Oshii
"A sparkling drink? How classy."
Shun Anesaki
"Well, Sis wanted it."
Yu Oshii
"Figures."
Shun Anesaki
"Seriously, you okay?"

Recently, I've started to feel like Yu has changed. Perhaps he's finally broken free of whatever had been weighing on him.
Maybe this is his true nature.
When he gets into one of those strange moods, I can really see the family resemblance between him and Sis.
That, too, left me with mixed feelings.
The conversation trailed off, and an awkward silence followed. We both seemed to be waiting to see what the other person would do next.
Yu made the move first.

Yu Oshii
"All right, I'm gonna go to the register."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh? Oh, wait a second."

I impulsively stopped him, only to realize I didn't actually have anything to say.

Shun Anesaki
"No, never mind."
Yu Oshii
"What is it?"
Shun Anesaki
"Oh, well... wanna walk home together?"
Yu Oshii
"..."

Yu shot me a glare, then walked off toward the register without a word.
After watching him go, I grabbed a few snacks and circled around the store toward the household goods aisle.
I found what I had come for and reached out to grab it. Then something sitting right next to it caught me completely off guard.
As my mind instantly began running through all sorts of possibilities...

Yu Oshii
"Oi."

A voice suddenly came from behind me, and I instinctively pulled my hand back.
Yu had returned from the register.
Under that reproachful gaze, so much like my Sis's, I was seized by a sense of guilt that left me with nowhere to hide.

Yu Oshii
"What were you trying to buy?"
Shun Anesaki
"Huh?
Yu Oshii
"WHAT. ARE. YOU. TRYING. TO. BUY?"

Oh shit, what do I do? This guy's scary.
Under the weight of that intense pressure, I somehow managed to calm myself down and cautiously picked it up.
Yu muttered, "Huh?"

Yu Oshii
"…Plastic wrap?"
Shun Anesaki
"Y-yeah."

It was plastic wrap.
Just ordinary plastic wrap.
Nothing more, nothing less.

Yu Oshii
"…Is this really what you wanted?"
Shun Anesaki
"Y-yeah. Sis asked me to get it."

This is 100% the truth.

Yu Oshii
"…Hmm. Anything else you need to get?"
Shun Anesaki
"No. Nothing else. I've got everything."

Yu pressed his lips together and silently scrutinized my face, as though trying to see through me
It was time for the verdict.

Yu Oshii
"No way..."

Yu suddenly started shaking and grabbed hold of me, practically lunging at me.

Yu Oshii
"You're going to do it without protection?!"
Shun Anesaki
"Will you just shut up already?"

I regretted suggesting that we go home together.

Shun Anesaki
"I'm home..."

Dealing with Yu's incessant complaining all the way home had left me needlessly exhausted.
I slowly made my way into the living room.
Sis, who was at the kitchen counter, turned around, her long ponytail swishing behind her.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Welcome back. Did you get everything?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hm? You look kind of tired."
Shun Anesaki
"Not really..."

I was about to tell her I'd met Yu, but I swallowed the words.
I knew what it was. Ugly jealousy.
He had so many things I didn't.
I just couldn't see myself beating him.

Nozomi Anesaki
"...Shun?"
Shun Anesaki
"…It's nothing."

I shook my head and put the shopping bag down on the table.
She looked at me curiously, then lowered her gaze and went back to what she was doing.
The homemade cake was almost done.

Shun Anesaki
"Can I help with anything?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Hmm... You can take the stems off the strawberries."
Shun Anesaki
"Got it."

I stood beside her and began cutting the stems off the strawberries.
A soft, sweet fragrance drifted over from her side, and I cast a sidelong glance at her hands.
Whipped cream.
Whipped cream... wh-whipped cream...
I'm so stupid...!
*One of the characters in whipped cream means "raw", which made him think about how Yu earlier talked about them doing it without protection.
I shook my head, snapping myself out of those weird thoughts, and put all my focus into hulling the strawberries.

Shun Anesaki
"I'm done."

By the time I dropped the last strawberry into the bowl, I'd more or less managed to clear my head.
"Thanks," Sis said flatly, piping the whipped cream onto the strawberries.
That sweet scent drifted over again, and for some reason, I found myself growing restless.

"Just get away from her," my rational side whispered, while my instincts urged me, "Don't hold back."
It would be a lie to say I hadn't been thinking about it.
It was Christmas Eve. Of course it was going to be at the back of my mind.
*Christmas is more of a couple's holiday than a family one in Japan.
And just moments ago, that whole thing had made me associate it with some very explicit images.
I told myself it couldn't be helped.
Besides, I'd been holding myself back all this time, hadn't I?
I'd thought things would get easier once summer was over and I no longer had to see her in that sloppy loungewear.
But reality wasn't so kind.
It didn't matter how much skin she showed, sometimes, even the slightest thing was enough to set me off.
Every time it happened, I'd suppress my desire by thinking of something that would kill the mood. But I was reaching my limit.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Hey!"

I suddenly came to my senses.
Something cold was touching my lips. It was a strawberry.

Nozomi Anesaki
"What do you think you are doing?"

Her sideways glare snapped me back to reality.
Only then did I realize that I'd put an arm around her shoulders.
I'd done it unconsciously.

Shun Anesaki
"...Nothing."

I lowered my hand while chewing on the strawberry she'd stuffed into my mouth.
The sourness brought me back to my senses a little.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Jeez..."

She pouted and went back to decorating the cake.
The hand holding the piping bag trembled slightly as she squeezed out the whipped cream.
I watched her like that for a while, and eventually, she looked up at me, her cheeks bright red.

Nozomi Anesaki
"S-stop... don't look at me..."
Shun Anesaki
"Huh...?"

I realized she was getting flustered because I was watching her.
Something stirred in my chest, and I heard that switch inside me click on.
This was bad.
I practically jumped away from her, putting as much distance between us as possible, and desperately tried to think of something that would kill my excitement.
The first thing that came to mind was...

Yu Oshii
"Monk... Monk..."

The image of him repeating those words over and over, like some kind of curse.
I quickly pulled my phone out of my pocket.

Shun Anesaki
“Come to my place right now. Get your things ready for a sleepover.”

I typed it out and sent it without giving it a second thought.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Wh-what? What's this all of a sudden?"

Sis had been watching me the whole time, and now she blinked rapidly, clearly confused.

Shun Anesaki
"...Actually... Yu's coming over to stay tonight. Is that okay...?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Really?"
Shun Anesaki
"Yeah... His mom is away on a business trip, so he'd be all alone."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, I see. You should've told me sooner! Of course it's fine! Let's have a party together!"

Her face lit up with a dazzling smile.
I was done for.

Epilogue 6: Silent Night

(Yu's POV)
I was in the library.
I sat in a seat at the back, writing in my notebook.
Then I sensed someone approaching.
I looked up, waiting for her to arrive, my heart filled with happiness.
The soft sound of footsteps drew closer.
I couldn't hear anything else.
Not the ticking of the clock. Not even the sound of my own breathing.
Before long, she appeared as if from nowhere.

Nozomi Kimura
"Sorry, did I keep you waiting?"

She asked with a smile.
I shook my head.
Still wearing that smile, she sat down across from me.
In that instant, I became conscious of my own breathing and the pounding of my heart.
It felt as though she and I were the only two people who existed in this world.

Nozomi Kimura
"Oshii-kun."
Yu Oshii
"Please call me Yu."
Nozomi Kimura
"...Yu."

She smiled shyly, looking a little embarrassed.
I thought she was cute.
The prickling ache in my chest was, without a doubt, romantic longing.
I abruptly rose to my feet and leaned toward her.
I took her by the shoulders and moved my face closer to hers, catching her completely off guard.

Nozomi Kimura
"Wait."

She placed a hand against my chest and pushed me back.
But there was hardly any strength behind it.
She wasn't seriously trying to resist.
So I leaned in even closer.
Her body was trembling.

Nozomi Kimura
"...Is this really okay?"

She asked anxiously.

Yu Oshii
"Of course."

I replied.

Nozomi Kimura
"...Really?"
Yu Oshii
"Yes."
Nozomi Kimura

"Even with someone like me?"

Her gaze wavered with fear beneath her unkempt, overgrown bangs.
I thought she was precious.

Yu Oshii
"I love you."

I didn't hesitate.
I leaned in and kissed her.

The moment I woke up, my happiness vanished like smoke in the wind.
An unpleasant sensation surged up from deep within my chest in its place, making me feel sick to my stomach.
This was self-loathing.
Loathing for the desire sleeping within me.
For the fact that I couldn't deny it.
When I closed my eyes, the scene vividly came rushing back, playing out behind my eyelids.
I'd never even kissed anyone before, yet in that moment, I could clearly feel the warmth of her body.
A shiver ran through me, followed by a strange throbbing in my legs.
Once again, self-loathing gnawed at me.

Yu Oshii
"...What am I, some kind of pervert?"

I spat the words out under my breath and got up from my futon.
The heater had already been turned off, but a faint warmth still lingered in the room.
I slowly swept my gaze across the dimly lit room.
The hands of the clock pointed to a little after two in the morning. So it was Christmas already.
Shun was fast asleep in his bed, completely buried beneath the blankets.
It struck me just how strange this whole situation was.
If he hadn't invited me over, he and Big Sister would be—
No. I should stop.
Thinking about it makes me feel like I'm going insane.
I knew Shun didn't invite me out of consideration.
...Though, in the end, it worked out in my favor too. So I couldn't bring myself to criticize him for it.
Shun was a good guy.
He was sensible and sincere.
That's why I hate myself.
I could come up with all sorts of reasons to comfort myself, like the fact that I was her biological brother, but I had a feeling that she would choose him even if I were in his position.
I let out a sigh and got to my feet.
As soon as I stepped out of the room, the cold December air seeped into me.
It was cold.
But that was exactly what I needed.

If my body cooled down, maybe my head would clear too.
I just wanted to regain my composure.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Yu?"

The sudden sound of her voice made me stiffen.
I turned around to find Big Sister walking toward me in her pajamas.
I was glad it was winter.
If she'd appeared in that summer loungewear of hers, coming here to cool off would've been completely pointless.

Nozomi Anesaki
"The bathroom?"
Yu Oshii
"No."

After answering, I immediately thought that I should've just said yes.
Leaving the room for no reason would be unnatural.
If this were my own home, it wouldn't matter. But I was a guest.

Yu Oshii
"What about you?"

I deflected by asking her a question in return.

Nozomi Anesaki
"I just happened to wake up."
Yu Oshii
"Ah... Did the sound of me leaving the room wake you?"
Nozomi Anesaki
"Well, I've always been a light sleeper."

She smiled, not denying it.
A thought crossed my mind.
What if she'd been waiting for Shun to leave the room?
I was sick of myself for always resorting to such defeatist thoughts.
Even feeling this way was wrong.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Did something happen?"

Before I realized it, Big Sister was standing right in front of me, peering closely at my face.
Her eyes were brighter than they had been that day, but the innocent look in them hadn't changed at all.

Yu Oshii
"...No, it's nothing."

That was all I could manage to say.
The sweet scent that filled my nostrils made me feel almost dizzy.
The reason she could be so completely unguarded around me like this was probably because she saw me unequivocally as her "biological younger brother."
And she probably didn't question what I'd told her, those words that I myself wanted to believe.
That was true.
I hadn't lied.
I wanted to be her brother.
That was my deepest desire.
I was jealous of Shun for the place he occupied in her life, but the truth was, I took great pride in the fact that we were bound by blood.
And yet, despite all that, I was still in love with her.

Yu Oshii
"Well... I think I'll head back."

I looked away from her, trying to wrench myself free from the dangerous impulse taking hold of me.

Nozomi Anesaki
"Huh? Didn't you need something?"
Yu Oshii
"No, I just wanted to cool off for a bit."
Nozomi Anesaki
"Oh, okay. Good night."
Yu Oshii
"Good night."

When I returned to the room, I exhaled into the tepid air.
Had she noticed something was off? The thought made me uneasy.
No, surely not. She trusted me.
No, actually...
There was no way she could have noticed.
It wasn't that she was dense.
But because she was "normal."
Feeling utterly dejected, I slipped back under the futon in the middle of the room.

Shun Anesaki
"...What did you guys talk about?"

A hoarse voice suddenly broke the silence.
I wondered when he'd woken up.
If he was worried, he should've just come over to see what was going on, I thought, amused by how much of a coward Shun was.

Yu Oshii

"Nothing in particular."
Shun Anesaki
"Hmm..."
Yu Oshii
"What? Are you wary of me?"
Shun Anesaki
"...Of course I am."
Yu Oshii
"Even though we're blood relatives?"

I said it in a deliberately provocative way.
I was annoyed, yet at the same time, I shuddered at the realization that I was taking pleasure in feeling superior to him.
Neither of us said anything.
A pause hung between us.
I waited for Shun to respond amid the suffocating silence.
Eventually, he turned over in bed, fixed me with a cold stare, and spoke:

Shun Anesaki
"You know that's irrelevant."

The sheer hostility he directed at me made me feel a dull ache deep in my chest.
Much to my dismay, we really understood each other well.

Yu Oshii
"Don't worry."

I turned away from him.

Yu Oshii
"I won't do anything to her, and I have no intention of getting in your way."
Shun Anesaki
"...Really?"
Yu Oshii
"Really. You of all people should know that."

Shun grumbled behind me.

Shun Anesaki
"Well... I don't know. If I were in your place, I probably would have done something."

I couldn't help but laugh at the sheer seriousness of his tone.

Yu Oshii
"That's messed up."
Shun Anesaki
"You're one to talk."

"Yeah, you're right," I replied to him in my mind and closed my eyes.

"Even with someone like me?"
The girl from my dream asked me that in the darkness.
I didn't see anything wrong with it.
No matter what she looked like—even if she were my sister—if she gave me permission, I would kiss her.
I was, without a doubt, messed up.
But it was just a fantasy.
I would never do anything like that in reality.
If she realized what kind of person I was, I would lose even the right to be her brother.